

A Selection from the Poems of William Morris

William Morris and Francis Hueffer

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A Selection from the Poems of William Morris

William Morris and Francis Hueffer

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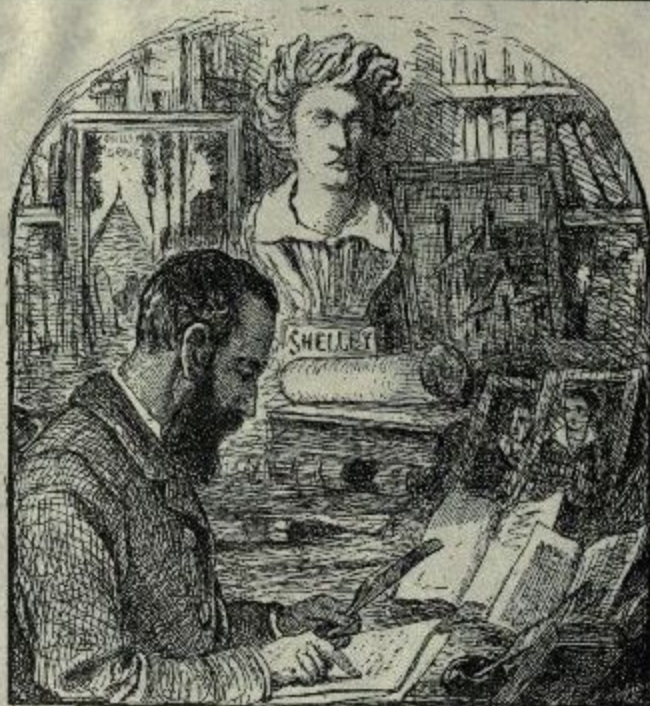
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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK A SELECTION
FROM THE POEMS OF WILLIAM MORRIS ***

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The figure that you here see put
 Was for H. Burston, Tinsman cut,
 Amid his household gods to bide,
 And relics culled from far and wide.
 This looks to his on whom you look,
 For Scott his graving tackle took

And wished the man to watch therein,
 That none by spoils the book might win.
 Then wrote fur! of great and small,
 The world holds books enough for all.
 Of roughly handling this beware,
 And put it in its place with care!

Franz Hueffer who came into the Rossetti circle in the manner indicated in the following letter (of which the greater part is in the writing of the late Lucy Rossetti - daughter of Ford Madox Brown) was a broad-headed, plodding, able German who wrote and spoke English perfectly enough before his naturalization. He was somewhat heavy in his enthusiasms; and Gabriel Rossetti laughed at him a good deal. On one occasion D.G.R. let off the following "nursery rhyme":-

There's a fluffy-haired German called Hueffer
A loud and pragmatical duffer;
To stand on a tower
And shout "Schopenhauer"

So reckoned his mission by Hueffer.
There was no malice in these rhymes of

Rossetti's; but even his dear friend Morris ("Topsy" as his intimates called him on account of his shock of black hair) was not exempt from personal sallies of the kind, - as this, when M. got alarmed about his increasing bulk:-

There was a young person called Topsy
Who fancied he suffered from Dropsy!
He shook like a jelly,
Till the Doctor cried "Belly!" -
Which angered, but comforted Topsy.

Poor dear Morris! he had cause enough for alarm. Diabetes was only one among the agencies by which his stalwart frame was disintegrated at the age of 62.

H.B.F.

7 November 1897.

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A loud and pragmatistical duffer:
To stand on a tower
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Is reckoned his mission by Huffer.

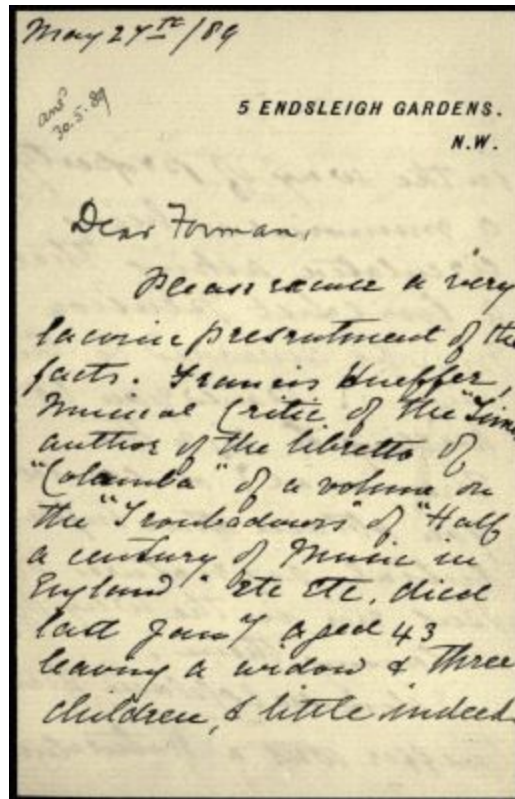
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H.B.F.

7 November 1897.



May 27th/89

5 ENDSLEIGH GARDENS.

N.W.

Dear Forman,

Please excuse a very laconic presentment of the facts. Francis Hueffer, Musical Critic of the "Times", author of the libretto of "Columba" of a volume on the "Troubadours" of "Half a century of Music in England" etc etc, died last Jan 7 aged 43 leaving a widow & three children, & little indeed.

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TAUCHNITZ EDITION.

VOL. 2378.

POEMS BY WILLIAM MORRIS.

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A SELECTION

FROM

THE POEMS
OF
WILLIAM MORRIS.

EDITED
WITH A MEMOIR
BY FRANCIS HUEFFER.

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LEIPZIG
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1886.

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MEMOIR

OF

WILLIAM MORRIS.

William Morris, poet, decorative designer and socialist, was born in 1834 at Clay Street, Walthamstow, now almost a suburb of London, at that time a country village in Essex. He went to school at Marlborough College and thence to Exeter College, Oxford, where he took his degree in 1857. During his stay in the University the subsequent mode of his life was prepared and foreshadowed in two important directions. Like most poets Morris was not what is called very assiduous "at his book"; the routine of college training was no more an attraction to him than the ordinary amusements and dissipations of undergraduate existence. But he was studious all the same, reading the classics in his own somewhat spasmodic way and exploring with even greater zeal the mysteries of mediæval lore. His fellow-worker in these studies and his most intimate friend was and is at the present day Mr. Burne Jones, the famous painter, at that time a student of divinity. Artistic and literary pursuits thus went hand in hand, and received additional zest when the two young men became acquainted with Dante Gabriel Rossetti, Holman Hunt and other painters of the Pre-Raphaelite school who came to Oxford to execute the frescoes still dimly visible on the ceiling of the Union Debating Hall. Of the aims and achievements of the Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood, and of the revival of mediæval feeling in art and literature originally advocated by its members ample account has been given in the memoir of Rossetti prefixed to his poems in the Tauchnitz edition. Its influence on Morris's early work, both in matter and form, will strike every observant reader of the opening ballads of the present collection. Later on the poet worked out for himself a distinct and individual phase of the mediæval movement, as will be mentioned by and by. At one time little was wanting to make Morris follow his friend Burne Jones's example and leave the pen for the brush. There is indeed still extant from his hand an unfinished picture evincing a remarkable sense of colour. He also for a short time became a pupil of the late Mr. G. E. Street, the architect, to whose genius London owes its finest modern Gothic building—the Law Courts in the Strand. On second thoughts, however, Morris came to the conclusion that poetry was his true field of action. His first literary venture was a

monthly periodical started under his auspices in 1856 and called *The Oxford and Cambridge Magazine*. It contained, amongst other contributions from Morris's pen, a prose tale of a highly romantic character, and was, as regards artistic tendencies, essentially a sequel of *The Germ*, the organ of the Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood, begun and continued for three numbers only, six years before. Several of the contributors to the earlier venture, including Rossetti, also supported its offshoot. Neither, however, gained popular favour, and after a year's struggling existence *The Oxford and Cambridge Magazine* also came to an untimely end. At present both are eagerly sought for by collectors and fetch high prices at antiquarian sales. So changeable is the fate of books.

In 1859 Morris married, after having the year before brought out his first volume of verse entitled *The Defence of Guenevere and Other Poems*. The book fell dead from the press, and it was not till it was republished 25 years later that the world recognised in it some of the freshest and most individual efforts of its author, whose literary position was by that time established beyond cavil. That position the poet owed in the first instance to two works published in rapid succession, *The Life and Death of Jason*, and *The Earthly Paradise*, the latter a collection of tales in verse filling four stout volumes. His remaining original works are *Love is enough*, a "morality" in the mediæval sense of the word, and *The Story of Sigurd the Volsung*, his longest and, in the opinion of some, his most perfect epic. In addition to these should be mentioned the translations from the old Norse undertaken in conjunction with Mr. Magnusson the well-known Icelandic scholar, and comprising *The Story of Grettir the Strong* (1869), *The Volsunga Saga, with certain songs from the Elder Edda* (1870), and *Three Northern Love Stories* (1875); and finally a metrical rendering of *The Æneids of Virgil*.

For a critical discussion or a detailed analysis of Morris's work this is not the place. It must be sufficient to indicate briefly the ideas which underlie that work and give it its literary *cachet*. Two main currents, derivable perhaps from a common source but running in different directions can be easily discerned. The subjects of his tales are almost without exception derived either from Greek myth or from mediæval folklore. After all that has been said and written of the gulf that divides the classic from the romantic feeling—"Barbaren und Hellenen", as Heine puts it, such a conjunction might appear incongruous. But the connecting link has here

been found in the poet's mind. He looks upon his classical subject-matter through a mediæval atmosphere, in other words he writes about Venus and Cupid and Psyche and Medea as a poet of Chaucer's age might have done, barring of course the differences of language, although in this respect also it may be noted that the archaisms of expression affected by the modern poet appear indifferently in the Greek and the mediæval tales. The phenomenon is by no means unique in literature. Let the reader compare Chapman's Homer with Pope's, or let him open Morris's *Jason* where the bells of Colchis "melodiously begin to ring", and the meaning of the aforementioned "mediæval atmosphere" will at once be as palpable to him as it was to Keats when, reading Chapman's rude verse, after Pope's polished stanzas, he felt

like some watcher of the
skies
When a new planet swims into his
ken.

It was the romantic chord of Keats's nature, that chord which vibrates in *La belle Dame sans Merci*, which was harmoniously struck and made the great master of form overlook the formal imperfection of the earlier poet. To the same element such stories as *Jason*, or *The Love of Alcestis* and the *Bellerophon* in *The Earthly Paradise* owe their charm.

Morris's position towards mediæval subjects did not at first essentially differ from that of other poets of similar tendency. In his first volume English and French knights and damsels figure prominently, and the beautiful and frail wife of King Arthur is the heroine of the chief poem and has given her name to the book. But in the interval which elapsed between that volume and the *Earthly Paradise* a considerable change had come over the poet's dream. By the aid of Mr. Magnusson he had become acquainted with the treasure of northern folklore hidden in the Icelandic sagas, the two Eddas, the story of the Volsungs (of which a masterly translation is due to the two friends), the Laxdæla saga and other tales of more or less remote antiquity.

In the *Earthly Paradise* the double current of the poet's fancy above alluded to is most strikingly apparent. The very framework in which the various

tales are set seems to have been designed with that view. Guided probably by a vague tradition of a pre-Columbian discovery of America by the Vikings, the prologue relates how during a terrible pestilence certain mariners leave their northern home in search of the land where old age and death are not and where life is rounded by unbroken pleasure. Sailing west they come to a fair country. They gaze on southern sunshine and virgin forest and fertile champaign, but death meets them at every step, and happiness is farthest from their grasp when the people worship them as gods and sacrifice at their shrine. Escaping from this golden thralldom they regain their ship, and after many dangers and privations are driven by the wind to an island inhabited by descendants of the ancient Greeks, who have preserved their old worship and their old freedom. Here the weary wanderers of the main are hospitably received, and here they resolve to dwell in peace, forgetful of their vain search for the earthly paradise. At the beginning and the middle of every month the elders of the people and their guests meet together to while away the time with song and friendly converse. The islanders relate the traditions of their Grecian home, the mariners relate the sagas of the North, and Laurence, a Swabian priest who had joined the Norsemen in their quest, contributes the legends of Tannhäuser and of the ring given to Venus by the Roman youth. Here then there is full scope for the quaint beauty of romantic classicism and for the weird glamour of northern myth. Without encroaching upon the field of criticism proper the writer may state that, in his opinion, amongst the classic tales none is more graceful and finished than "The Golden Apples", and amongst the northern none more grandly developed and more epical in the strict sense of the word than *The Lovers of Gudrun* based upon the Icelandic Laxdæla saga. The latter, unfortunately, cannot find a place in this volume for reasons of space.

Every student of old northern literature is aware that amongst its remains none are more interesting as literary monuments, none more characteristic of the people from which they sprang than the two Eddas and the Volsunga Saga. Next to the Siege of Troy and the Arthurian legends perhaps no story or agglomeration of stories has left so many and so important traces in international fiction as the tale of Sigurd or Siegfried and his race, the heroic god-born Volsungs. Considering indeed the political insignificance and remoteness in which that story took its earliest surviving form this

enormous success—if the modern term may be applied—seems at first singularly out of proportion. But it must be remembered that Iceland was little more than the storehouse of these old traditions which were the common property of the Teuto-Scandinavian race long before the Norsemen set foot on the northern isle. Of the two modern versions of the tale which are most thoroughly inspired by the ancient myth one, that of Wagner in his tetralogy *Der Ring des Nibelungen*, is dramatic in form, the other, Morris's *The Story of Sigurd the Volsung*, bears all the characteristics of the epic. To this difference of artistic aim, the difference of shape which the tale takes in the hands of the two poets may be traced. In one point however they agree. Both Wagner and Morris go back to the old Icelandic sources in preference to the mediæval German version of the tale embodied in the *Nibelungenlied*. From this the German poet borrows little more than the localization of his drama on the banks of the river Rhine, the English poet scarcely anything but his metre—the *Langzeile* or long-line with six hightoned, and any number of unaccentuated syllables.

The ordinary modern reader taking up the Volsunga Saga or either of the Eddas without preparation would probably see in them little more than a confused accumulation of impossible adventures and deeds of prowess with an admixture of incest, fratricide and other horrors. But on looking closer one discovers a certain plan in this entanglement, a plan much obscured by the unbridled fancy of the old narrators, and hardly realised by themselves, but which, if properly sifted, amounts to what we should call a moral or idea. To "point this moral," to consistently develop this idea, is the task of the modern poet courageous enough to grapple with such a subject. Two ways are open to him. Either he may wholly abandon the sequence of the old tale, and group its *disjecta membra* round a leading idea as a centre, or else he may adhere to the order and essence of the legend as originally told, only emphasising such points as are essential to the significance of the story, and omitting or throwing into comparative shade those incidents which by their nature betray themselves to be arbitrary additions of later date. Wagner has chosen the former way, Morris the latter. This fact, and the divergent requirements of the drama and the epic, sufficiently account for their difference of treatment. The leading idea in both cases remains the same; it is the fatal curse which attaches to the gold or, which is the same in a moral sense, to the desire for gold—*auri sacra fames*.

At first sight the tale of Sigurd, Fafnir's bane, seems to have little connection with this idea. It is briefly this. Sigurd, the son of Sigmund the Volsung, is brought up at the court of King Elf, the second husband of his mother, after Sigmund has been slain in battle. With a sword, fashioned from the shards of his father's weapon, he slays Fafnir, a huge worm or dragon, and possesses himself of the treasure watched by the monster, including a ring and the "helm of aweing," the latter in the *Nibelungenlied*, converted into the "Tarnkappe", a magic cap which makes the bearer invisible and endows him with supernatural strength. Tasting of the blood of the dragon, he understands the language of birds, and an eagle tells him of a beautiful maiden lying asleep on a rock called Hindfell, surrounded by a wall of wavering fire. Through it Sigurd rides and awakes Brynhild the sword maiden, or Valkyrie, from her magic slumber. Love naturally follows. The pair live together on Hindfell for a season and Brynhild teaches the youth the runes of her wisdom, a conception of woman's refining and civilising mission frequently met with in old Germanic tales. When Sigurd leaves her to seek new adventures they plight the troth of eternal love, and

Then he set the ring on her finger, and once if ne'er again
They kissed and clung together, and their hearts were full
and fain.

From Brynhild's rock Sigurd journeys to a realm "south of the Rhine" where dwell the kingly brothers, Gunnar, Hogni, and Guttorm, the Niblungs, together with their sister Gudrun, "the fairest of maidens", and their mother Grimhild, "a wise wife" and a fierce-hearted woman, as the Volsunga Saga alternately describes her. It is through a love-philter brewed by her that Sigurd forgets the vows exchanged with Brynhild, and becomes enamoured of Gudrun, whom he soon after weds. So powerful is the charm that the very name of his former love has been wiped from Sigurd's memory, and he willingly undertakes the task to woo and win Brynhild for his brother Gunnar. For that purpose he, by means of his magic cap, assumes Gunnar's semblance, and after having once more crossed the wall of wavering flame compels Brynhild to become his bride. But, faithful to his promise, he places a drawn sword between himself and the maid "as they lie on one bed together." On parting from her he receives back from Brynhild his own ring given to her at Hindfell in the days of their bliss.

Sigurd then returns to Gunnar and resumes his own form, and all return home, the King leading his unwilling bride in triumph.

The subsequent events are the outgrowth of the tragic guilt thus incurred. Sigurd reveals the secret of Brynhild's wooing to his wife, and allows her to take possession of the fatal ring, which she during a quarrel shows to Gunnar's wife. Brynhild thus informed of the fraud practised on her, thinks of vengeance, and incites her husband and his brothers to kill Sigurd. The deed is done while Sigurd lies asleep in his chamber with Gudrun, or, according to the more poetic version of the German epic, while he bends over a brook in the forest to quench his thirst after a day's hunting. But as soon as her beloved foe is killed the old passion never quenched rises up again in Brynhild's heart. To be united with her lover in death she pierces her breast with a sword, and one pyre consumes both.

With this climax Wagner very properly concludes his drama. But the epic poet likes to follow the course of events to their ultimate consequences, and Morris, in accordance with the Volsunga Saga, proceeds to relate how, after many years of mournful widowhood, Gudrun is married to Atli, a mighty king, the brother of Brynhild. Eager to become possessed of Sigurd's treasure he invites the Niblungs, its actual owners, to his country, and there the kingly brothers and all their followers are killed by base treachery and after the most heroic resistance. They refuse sternly to ransom their lives by a discovery of the hoard which previous to their departure they have hidden at the bottom of a lake, and which thus is irrecoverably lost to mankind. Gudrun has incited her husband to the deed and has looked on calmly while her kinsmen were slain one after the other. But when all are dead and the murder of Sigurd has been revenged, the feeling of blood relationship so powerful among Northern nations is reawakened in her. While Atli and his earls are asleep she sets fire to the kingly hall, and her wretched husband falls by her own hand. It is characteristic of the Icelandic epic that after all these fates and horrors Gudrun lives for a number of years and is yet again married to a third husband. But to this length even Morris refuses to accompany the tale. In accordance with the Volsunga Saga his Gudrun throws herself into the sea; but the waves do not carry her "to the burg of king Imakr, a mighty king and lord of many folk."

All this is very grand and weird, the reader will say, but where is the moral, the ideal essence of which these events are but the earthly reflex? To this essence we gradually ascend by inquiring into the mythological sources of the tale, by asking who is Sigurd, whence does he come, on what mission is he sent and by whom? also what is the significance of the treasure watched by a dragon and coveted by all mankind? This treasure we then shall find and the curse attaching to it ever since it was robbed from Andvari, the water-elf, is the keynote of the whole story. The curse proves fatal to all its successive owners from Andvari himself and Fafnir, who, for its sake, kills his father, down to Sigurd and Brynhild and the Niblung brothers. Nay, Odin himself, the supreme God, becomes subject to the curse of the gold through having once coveted it, and we dimly discern that the ultimate doom of the Aesir, the Ragnarök, or dusk of the Gods, of which the *Voluspa* speaks, is intimately connected with the same baneful influence. It further becomes evident that Sigurd the Volsung, the descendant of Odin, is destined to wrest the treasure and the power derived from it from the Niblungs, the dark or cloudy people who threaten the bright godworld of Valhall with destruction. And this leads us back to a still earlier stage of the myth in which Sigurd himself becomes the symbol of the celestial luminary conquering night and misty darkness, an idea repeatedly hinted at by Morris and splendidly illustrated by Wagner, when Siegfried appears on the stage illumined by the first rays of the rising sun. In the work of the German poet all this is brought out with a distinctness of which only dramatic genius of the highest order is capable. With an astounding grasp of detail and with a continuity of thought rarely equalled, Wagner has remoulded the confused and complex argument of the old tale, omitting what seemed unnecessary, and placing in juxtaposition incidents organically connected but separated by the obtuseness of later sagamen.

Morris, as has been said before, proceeds on a different principle. His first object is to tell a tale, and to tell it as nearly as possible in the spirit and according to the letter of the old Sagas. In this he has succeeded in a manner at once indicative of his high poetic gifts and of a deep sympathy with the spirit of the Northern Myth, which breathes in every line and in every turn of his phraseology. To compare the peculiar tinge of his language with the ordinary archaisms and euphonisms of literary poets would be mistaking a field flower for its counterpart in a milliner's shop window. It is

true that he also hints at the larger philosophic and moral issues of the tale. But when he refers to the end of the gods brought about by their own guilt or to the redeeming mission of Sigurd, it is done in the mysterious, not to say half conscious manner of the saga itself, and the effect is such as from his own point of view he intended it and could not but intend it to be.

Between the publication of *The Defence of Guenevere* and that of *Jason* ten years elapsed. During most of this time the poet was employed in artistic pursuits. In 1861 he started in conjunction with a number of friends the business of decorator and artistic designer which still bears his name. Growing from very modest beginnings this enterprise was destined to work an entire change in the external aspect of English homes. It soon extended its activity to every branch of art-workmanship. D. G. Rossetti, Madox Brown, and Burne Jones drew cartoons for the stained glass windows to be seen in many of our churches and colleges. Morris himself designed wall-papers and the patterns of carpets. The latter are woven on hand-loom in his factory at Merton Abbey, which stands on the banks of the river Wandle surrounded by orchards, and looks as like a medieval workshop as the modern dresses of the workgirls will allow. Another member of the firm, Philip Webb, was the first modern architect to build houses of red brick in the style vaguely and not quite correctly described as "Queen Anne." At present these houses count by thousands in London and a whole village of them has been built at Turnham Green. The members of the firm did not confine their attention to any particular style or age or country. Wherever beautiful things could be found they collected them and made them popular. Old china English, and foreign, Japanese fans and screens, Venetian glass and German pottery were equally welcome to them and through them to the public generally. It may be said that the "aesthetic" fashion as it came to be called will like other fashions die out, and that people in the course of time will grow tired of "living up to" their furniture and dresses. At the same time the idea thus insisted upon that beauty is an essential and necessary ingredient of practical modern English life is not likely to be without beneficial and permanent effect.

It was as artistic worker and employer of skilled labour that Morris imbibed that profound disgust with our social condition which induced him to adopt the principles of extreme socialism. For a long time his views had tended in that direction, and at the end of 1884 he joined the Socialist League, a body

professing the doctrines of international revolutionary socialism. He is the editor of its official organ, the *Commonweal*, which contains many contributions from his pen both in prose and verse. That the poet has not been entirely sunk in the politician, that longing for beauty is at least the partial cause of this desire for change at any price, is however proved by such a sentiment as, "Beauty, which is what is meant by *art*, using the word in its widest sense, is, I contend, no mere accident of human life which people can take or have as they choose, but a positive necessity of life, if we are to live as nature meant us to, that is unless we are content to be less than men," or by such a vision of a future earthly paradise as is expressed in the following lines:

Then a man shall work and bethink him, and rejoice in the
deeds of his hand,
Nor yet come home in the even, too faint and weary to
stand,
.
For that which the worker winneth shall then be his indeed,
Nor shall half be reaped for nothing by him that sowed no
seed.
.
Then all *mine* and *thine* shall be *ours*, and no more shall any
man crave
For riches that serve for nothing but to fetter a friend for a
slave.

One may admire the pathetic beauty of such lines, without sharing the poet's hope, that their import will ever be realised, in a world peopled by men and not by angels. History teaches and personal experience confirms that art enjoyment and art creation of the highest type must be confined to the few, and it is to be feared that social democracy, whatever it may do for the physical welfare of the many, will care little about beauty, either in nature or in art. The *Demos* will never admire Rossetti's pictures or Keats's poetry, and the first thing the much-vaunted peasant proprietors, or peasant communes would do would be to cut down our ancient trees, level every hedgerow and turn parks and commons into potato plots or it may be turnip fields. One may feel certain of all this and yet admire the author of *The*

Earthly Paradise, "the idle singer of an empty day" when he preaches universal brotherhood in the crossways of Hammersmith, and wrestles with policemen, or wrangles with obtuse magistrates about the freedom of speech. Conviction thus upheld at the cost of worldly advantage and personal convenience and taste must command respect even from those who cannot share it.

FRANCIS HUEFFER.

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FROM

**"THE DEFENCE OF GUENEVERE AND
OTHER POEMS."**

THE DEFENCE OF GUENEVERE.

But, knowing now that they would
have her speak,
She threw her wet hair backward
from her brow,
Her hand close to her mouth
touching her cheek,

As though she had had there a
shameful blow,
And feeling it shameful to feel ought
but shame,
All through her heart, yet felt her
cheek burned so,

She must a little touch it; like one
lame
She walked away from Gauwaine,
with her head
Still lifted up; and on her cheek of
flame

The tears dried quick; she stopped at
last and said:
"O knights and lords, it seems but
little skill
To talk of well-known things past
now and dead.

"God wot I ought to say, I have done
ill,
And pray you all forgiveness
heartily!

Because you must be right such great
lords—still

"Listen, suppose your time were
come to die,
And you were quite alone and very
weak;
Yea, laid a dying while very mightily

"The wind was ruffling up the narrow
streak
Of river through your broad lands
running well:
Suppose a hush should come, then
some one speak:

"One of these cloths is heaven, and
one is hell,
Now choose one cloth for ever,
which they be,
I will not tell you, you must
somehow tell

"Of your own strength and
mightiness; here, see!"
Yea, yea, my lord, and you to ope
your eyes,
At foot of your familiar bed to see

"A great God's angel standing, with
such dyes,
Not known on earth, on his great
wings, and hands,
Held out two ways, light from the
inner skies

"Showing him well, and making his
 commands
Seem to be God's commands,
 moreover, too,
Holding within his hands the cloths
 on wands;

"And one of these strange choosing
 cloths was blue,
Wavy and long, and one cut short
 and red;
No man could tell the better of the
 two.

"After a shivering half-hour you said,
'God help! heaven's colour, the blue;'
 and he said, 'hell.'
Perhaps you then would roll upon
 your bed,

"And cry to all good men that loved
 you well,
'Ah Christ! if only I had known,
 known, known;'
Launcelot went away, then I could
 tell,

"Like wisest man how all things
 would be, moan,
And roll and hurt myself, and long to
 die,
And yet fear much to die for what
 was sown.

"Nevertheless you, O Sir Gauwaine,
 lie,

Whatever may have happened
through these years,
God knows I speak truth, saying that
you lie."

Her voice was low at first, being full
of tears,
But as it cleared, it grew full loud
and shrill,
Growing a windy shriek in all men's
ears,

A ringing in their startled brains,
until
She said that Gauwaine lied, then her
voice sunk,
And her great eyes began again to
fill,

Though still she stood right up, and
never shrunk,
But spoke on bravely, glorious lady
fair!
Whatever tears her full lips may have
drunk,

She stood, and seemed to think, and
wrung her hair,
Spoke out at last with no more trace
of shame,
With passionate twisting of her body
there:

"It chanced upon a day Launcelot
came
To dwell at Arthur's Court; at
Christmas-time

This happened; when the heralds
sung his name,

"Son of King Ban of Benwick,'
seemed to chime
Along with all the bells that rang that
day,
O'er the white roofs, with little
change of rhyme.

"Christmas and whitened winter
passed away,
And over me the April sunshine
came,
Made very awful with black hail-
clouds, yea

"And in the Summer I grew white
with flame,
And bowed my head down—
Autumn, and the sick
Sure knowledge things would never
be the same,

"However often Spring might be most
thick
Of blossoms and buds, smote on me,
and I grew
Careless of most things, let the clock
tick, tick,

"To my unhappy pulse, that beat right
through
My eager body; while I laughed out
loud,
And let my lips curl up at false or
true,

"Seemed cold and shallow without
any cloud.

Behold my judges, then the cloths
were brought:

While I was dizzied thus, old
thoughts would crowd,

"Belonging to the time ere I was
bought

By Arthur's great name and his little
love,

Must I give up for ever then, I
thought,

"That which I deemed would ever
round me move

Glorifying all things; for a little
word,

Scarce ever meant at all, must I now
prove

"Stone-cold for ever? Pray you, does
the Lord

Will that all folks should be quite
happy and good?

I love God now a little, if this cord

"Were broken, once for all what
striving could

Make me love anything in earth or
heaven.

So day by day it grew, as if one
should

"Slip slowly down some path worn
smooth and even,

Down to a cool sea on a summer
day;
Yet still in slipping there was some
small leaven

"Of stretched hands catching small
stones by the way,
Until one surely reached the sea at
last,
And felt strange new joy as the worn
head lay

"Back, with the hair like sea-weed;
yea all past
Sweat of the forehead, dryness of the
lips,
Washed utterly out by the dear waves
o'er cast,

"In the lone sea, far off from any
ships!
Do I not know now of a day in
Spring?
No minute of that wild day ever slips

"From out my memory; I hear
thrushes sing,
And wheresoever I may be,
straightway
Thoughts of it all come up with most
fresh sting:

"I was half mad with beauty on that
day,
And went without my ladies all
alone,

In a quiet garden walled round every
way;

"I was right joyful of that wall of
stone,
That shut the flowers and trees up
with the sky,
And trebled all the beauty: to the
bone,

"Yea right through to my heart,
grown very shy
With weary thoughts, it pierced, and
made me glad;
Exceedingly glad, and I knew verily,

"A little thing just then had made me
mad;
I dared not think, as I was wont to
do,
Sometimes, upon my beauty; If I had

"Held out my long hand up against
the blue,
And, looking on the tenderly
darken'd fingers,
Thought that by rights one ought to
see quite through,

"There, see you, where the soft still
light yet lingers,
Round by the edges; what should I
have done,
If this had joined with yellow spotted
singers,

"And startling green drawn upward
by the sun?
But shouting, loosed out, see now!
all my hair,
And trancedly stood watching the
west wind run

"With faintest half-heard breathing
sound—why there
I lose my head e'en now in doing
this;
But shortly listen—In that garden
fair

"Came Launcelot walking; this is
true, the kiss
Wherewith we kissed in meeting that
spring day,
I scarce dare talk of the remember'd
bliss,

"When both our mouths went
wandering in one way,
And aching sorely, met among the
leaves;
Our hands being left behind strained
far away.

"Never within a yard of my bright
sleeves
Had Launcelot come before—and
now, so nigh!
After that day why is it Guenevere
grieves?

"Nevertheless you, O Sir Gauwaine,
lie,

Whatever happened on through all
those years,
God knows I speak truth, saying that
you lie.

"Being such a lady could I weep these
tears
If this were true? A great queen such
as I
Having sinn'd this way, straight her
conscience sears;

"And afterwards she liveth hatefully,
Slaying and poisoning, certes never
weeps,—
Gauwaine be friends now, speak me
lovingly.

"Do I not see how God's dear pity
creeps
All through your frame, and trembles
in your mouth?
Remember in what grave your
mother sleeps,

"Buried in some place far down in the
south,
Men are forgetting as I speak to you;
By her head sever'd in that awful
drouth

"Of pity that drew Agravaine's fell
blow,
I pray your pity! let me not scream
out
For ever after, when the shrill winds
blow

"Through half your castle-locks! let
me not shout
For ever after in the winter night
When you ride out alone! in battle-
rout

"Let not my rusting tears make your
sword light!
Ah! God of mercy how he turns
away!
So, ever must I dress me to the fight,

"So—let God's justice work!
Gauwaine, I say,
See me hew down your proofs: yea
all men know
Even as you said how Mellyagraunce
one day,

"One bitter day in *la Fausse Garde*,
for so
All good knights held it after, saw—
Yea, sirs, by cursed unknighly
outrage; though

"You, Gauwaine, held his word
without a flaw,
This Mellyagraunce saw blood upon
my bed—
Whose blood then pray you? is there
any law

"To make a queen say why some
spots of red
Lie on her coverlet? or will you say,

'Your hands are white, lady, as when
you wed,

"'Where did you bleed?' and must I
stammer out—'Nay',
I blush indeed, fair lord, only to rend
My sleeve up to my shoulder, where
there lay

"'A knife-point last night:' so must I
defend
The honour of the lady Guenevere?
Not so, fair lords, even if the world
should end

"This very day, and you were judges
here
Instead of God. Did you see
Mellyagraunce
When Launcelot stood by him? what
white fear

"Curdled his blood, and how his teeth
did dance,
His side sink in? as my knight cried
and said,
'Slayer of unarm'd men, here is a
chance!

"'Setter of traps, I pray you guard
your head,
By God I am so glad to fight with
you,
Stripper of ladies, that my hand feels
lead

"For driving weight; hurrah now!
draw and do,
For all my wounds are moving in my
breast,
And I am getting mad with waiting
so.'

"He struck his hands together o'er the
beast,
Who fell down flat, and grovell'd at
his feet,
And groan'd at being slain so young
—'at least.'

"My knight said, 'Rise you, sir, who
are so fleet
At catching ladies, half-arm'd will I
fight,
My left side all uncover'd!' then I
weet,

"Up sprang Sir Mellyagraunce with
great delight
Upon his knave's face; not until just
then
Did I quite hate him, as I saw my
knight

"Along the lists look to my stake and
pen
With such a joyous smile, it made me
sigh
From agony beneath my waist-chain,
when

"The fight began, and to me they
drew nigh;

Ever Sir Launcelot kept him on the
right,
And traversed warily, and ever high

"And fast leapt caitiff's sword, until
my knight
Sudden threw up his sword to his left
hand,
Caught it, and swung it; that was all
the fight.

"Except a spout of blood on the hot
land;
For it was hottest summer; and I
know
I wonder'd how the fire, while I
should stand,

"And burn, against the heat, would
quiver so,
Yards above my head; thus these
matters went:
Which things were only warnings of
the woe

"That fell on me. Yet Mellyagraunce
was shent,
For Mellyagraunce had fought
against the Lord;
Therefore, my lords, take heed lest
you be blent

"With all this wickedness; say no rash
word
Against me, being so beautiful; my
eyes,

Wept all away the grey, may bring
some sword

"To drown you in your blood; see my
breast rise,
Like waves of purple sea, as here I
stand;
And how my arms are moved in
wonderful wise,

"Yea also at my full heart's strong
command,
See through my long throat how the
words go up
In ripples to my mouth; how in my
hand

"The shadow lies like wine within a
cup
Of marvellously colour'd gold; yea
now
This little wind is rising, look you
up,

"And wonder how the light is falling
so
Within my moving tresses: will you
dare
When you have looked a little on my
brow,

"To say this thing is vile? or will you
care
For any plausible lies of cunning
woof,
When you can see my face with no
lie there

"For ever? am I not a gracious proof

—

'But in your chamber Launcelot was
found'—

Is there a good knight then would
stand aloof,

"When a queen says with gentle
queenly sound:

'O true as steel come now and talk
with me,

I love to see your step upon the
ground

"Unwavering, also well I love to see
That gracious smile light up your
face, and hear
Your wonderful words, that all mean
verily

"The thing they seem to mean: good
friend, so dear
To me in everything, come here to-
night,
Or else the hours will pass most dull
and drear;

"If you come not, I fear this time I
might
Get thinking over much of times
gone by,
When I was young, and green hope
was in sight:

"For no man cares now to know why
I sigh;

And no man comes to sing me
pleasant songs,
Nor any brings me the sweet flowers
that lie

"So thick in the gardens; therefore
one so longs
To see you, Launcelot; that we may
be
Like children once again, free from
all wrongs

"Just for one night.' Did he not come
to me?
What thing could keep true
Launcelot away
If I said 'Come?' there was one less
than three

"In my quiet room that night, and we
were gay;
Till sudden I rose up, weak, pale, and
sick,
Because a bawling broke our dream
up, yea

"I looked at Launcelot's face and
could not speak,
For he looked helpless too, for a little
while;
Then I remember how I tried to
shriek,

"And could not, but fell down; from
tile to tile
The stones they threw up rattled o'er
my head

And made me dizzier; till within a
while

"My maids were all about me, and
my head
On Launcelot's breast was being
soothed away
From its white chattering, until
Launcelot said—

"By God! I will not tell you more to-
day,
Judge any way you will—what
matters it?
You know quite well the story of that
fray,

"How Launcelot still'd their bawling,
the mad fit
That caught up Gauwaine—all, all,
verily,
But just that which would save me;
these things flit.

"Nevertheless you, O Sir Gauwaine,
lie,
Whatever may have happen'd these
long years,
God knows I speak truth, saying that
you lie!

"All I have said is truth, by Christ's
dear tears."
She would not speak another word,
but stood
Turn'd sideways; listening, like a
man who hears

His brother's trumpet sounding
 through the wood
Of his foe's lances. She lean'd
 eagerly,
And gave a slight spring sometimes,
 as she could

At last hear something really;
 joyfully
Her cheek grew crimson, as the
 headlong speed
Of the roan charger drew all men to
 see,
The knight who came was Launcelot
 at good need.

A GOOD KNIGHT IN PRISON.

SIR GUY, *being in the court of a Pagan castle.*

This castle where I dwell, it stands
A long way off from Christian lands,
A long way off my lady's hands,
A long way off the aspen trees,
And murmur of the lime-tree bees.

But down the Valley of the Rose
My lady often hawking goes,
Heavy of cheer; oft turns behind,
Leaning towards the western wind,
Because it bringeth to her mind
Sad whisperings of happy times,
The face of him who sings these
rhymes.

King Guilbert rides beside her
there,
Bends low and calls her very fair,
And strives, by pulling down his hair,
To hide from my dear lady's ken
The grisly gash I gave him, when
I cut him down at Camelot;
However he strives, he hides it not,
That tourney will not be forgot,
Besides, it is King Guilbert's lot,
Whatever he says she answers not.
Now tell me, you that are in love,
From the king's son to the wood-
dove,
Which is the better, he or I?

For this king means that I should die
In this lone Pagan castle, where
The flowers droop in the bad air
On the September evening.

Look, now I take mine ease and
sing,
Counting as but a little thing
The foolish spite of a bad king.

For these vile things that hem
me in,
These Pagan beasts who live in sin,
The sickly flowers pale and wan,
The grim blue-bearded castellan,
The stanchions half worn-out with
rust,
Whereto their banner vile they trust—
Why, all these things I hold them just
Like dragons in a missal book,
Wherein, whenever we may look,
We see no horror, yea, delight
We have, the colours are so bright;
Likewise we note the specks of white,
And the great plates of burnish'd
gold.

Just so this Pagan castle old,
And everything I can see there,
Sick-pining in the marshland air,
I note; I will go over now,
Like one who paints with knitted
brow,
The flowers and all things one by
one,

From the snail on the wall to the
setting sun.

Four great walls, and a little one
That leads down to the barbican,
Which walls with many spears they
man,
When news comes to the castellan
Of Launcelot being in the land.

And as I sit here, close at hand
Four spikes of sad sick sunflowers
stand,
The castellan with a long wand
Cuts down their leaves as he goes by,
Ponderingly, with screw'd-up eye,
And fingers twisted in his beard—
Nay, was it a knight's shout I heard?
I have a hope makes me afeard:
It cannot be, but if some dream
Just for a minute made me deem
I saw among the flowers there
My lady's face with long red hair,
Pale, ivory-colour'd dear face come,
As I was wont to see her some
Fading September afternoon,
And kiss me, saying nothing, soon
To leave me by myself again;
Could I get this by longing:
vain!

The castellan is gone: I see
On one broad yellow flower a bee
Drunk with much honey—
Christ! again,
Some distant knight's voice brings me
pain,

I thought I had forgot to feel,
I never heard the blissful steel
These ten years past; year after year,
Through all my hopeless sojourn
here,
No Christian pennon has been near;
Laus Deo! the dragging wind draws
on
Over the marches, battle won,
Knights' shouts, and axes hammering,
Yea, quicker now the dint and ring
Of flying hoofs; ah, castellan,
When they come back count man for
man,
Say whom you miss.

The PAGANS, *from the battlements.*

Mahmoud to aid!
Why flee ye so like men dismay'd?

The PAGANS, *from without.*

Nay, haste! for here is Launcelot,
Who follows quick upon us, hot
And shouting with his men-at-arms.

SIR GUY.

Also the Pagans raise alarms,
And ring the bells for fear; at last
My prison walls will be well past.

SIR LAUNCELOT, *from outside.*

Ho! in the name of the Trinity,

Let down the drawbridge quick to
me,
And open doors, that I may see
Guy the good knight.

THE PAGANS, *from the battlements.*

Nay, Launcelot,
With mere big words ye win us not.

SIR LAUNCELOT.

Bid Miles bring up la perriere,
And archers clear the vile walls there,
Bring back the notches to the ear,
Shoot well together! God to aid!
These miscreants shall be well paid.

Hurrah! all goes together; Miles
Is good to win my lady's smiles
For his good shooting—Launcelot!
On knights a-pace! this game is hot!

SIR GUY *sayeth afterwards.*

I said, I go to meet her now,
And saying so, I felt a blow
From some clench'd hand across my
brow,
And fell down on the sunflowers
Just as a hammering smote my ears,
After which this I felt in sooth;
My bare hands throttling without ruth
The hairy-throated castellan;
Then a grim fight with those that ran
To slay me, while I shouted, "God

For the Lady Mary!" deep I trod
That evening in my own red blood;
Nevertheless so stiff I stood,
That when the knights burst the old
 wood
Of the castle-doors, I was not dead.

I kiss the Lady Mary's head,
Her lips, and her hair golden red,
Because to-day we have been wed.

SHAMEFUL DEATH.

There were four of us about that bed;
The mass-priest knelt at the side,
I and his mother stood at the head,
Over his feet lay the bride;
We were quite sure that he was dead,
Though his eyes were open
wide.

He did not die in the night,
He did not die in the day,
But in the morning twilight
His spirit pass'd away,
When neither sun nor moon was
bright,
And the trees were merely grey.

He was not slain with the sword,
Knight's axe, or the knightly
spear,
Yet spoke he never a word
After he came in here;
I cut away the cord
From the neck of my brother
dear.

He did not strike one blow,
For the recreants came behind,
In a place where the hornbeams grow,
A path right hard to find,
For the hornbeam boughs swing so,
That the twilight makes it blind.

They lighted a great torch then,
When his arms were pinion'd
fast,
Sir John the knight of the Fen,
Sir Guy of the Dolorous Blast,
With knights threescore and ten,
Hung brave Lord Hugh at last.

I am threescore and ten,
And my hair is all turn'd grey,
But I met Sir John of the Fen
Long ago on a summer day,
And am glad to think of the moment
when
I took his life away.

I am threescore and ten,
And my strength is mostly
pass'd,
But long ago I and my men,
When the sky was overcast,
And the smoke roll'd over the reeds
of the fen,
Slew Guy of the Dolorous Blast.

And now, knights all of you,
I pray you pray for Sir Hugh,
A good knight and a true,
And for Alice, his wife, pray too.

THE EVE OF CRECY.

Gold on her head, and gold on her
feet,
And gold where the hems of her kirtle
meet,
And a golden girdle round my sweet;

*Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.*

Margaret's maids are fair to see,
Freshly dress'd and pleasantly;
Margaret's hair falls down to her
knee;—

*Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.*

If I were rich I would kiss her feet,
I would kiss the place where the gold
hems meet,
And the golden girdle round my
sweet—

*Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.*

Ah me! I have never touch'd her
hand;
When the arriere-ban goes through
the land,
Six basnets under my pennon stand;

*Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.*

And many an one grins under his
hood:
"Sir Lambert de Bois, with all his
men good,
Has neither food nor firewood;"—
Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.

If I were rich I would kiss her feet,
And the golden girdle of my sweet,
And thereabouts where the gold hems
meet;—
Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.

Yet even now it is good to think,
While my few poor varlets grumble
and drink
In my desolate hall where the fires
sink;—
Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.

Of Margaret sitting glorious there,
In glory of gold and glory of hair,
And glory of glorious face most fair;
—
Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.

Likewise to-night I make good cheer,
Because this battle draweth near:
For what have I to lose or fear?—
Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.

For, look you, my horse is good to
prance
A right fair measure in this war-
dance,
Before the eyes of Philip of France;

—
*Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.*

And sometime it may hap, perdie,
While my new towers stand up three
and three,
And my hall gets painted fair to see—
*Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.—*

That folks may say: "Times change,
by the rood,
For Lambert, banneret of the wood,
Has heaps of food and firewood;—
*Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite;—*

"And wonderful eyes, too, under the
hood
Of a damsel of right noble blood:"
St. Ives, for Lambert of the wood!—
*Ah! qu'elle est belle La
Marguerite.*

THE HAYSTACK IN THE FLOODS.

Had she come all the way for this,
To part at last without a kiss?
Yea, had she borne the dirt and rain
That her own eyes might see him
 slain
Beside the haystack in the floods?

Along the dripping leafless woods,
The stirrup touching either shoe,
She rode astride as troopers do;
With kirtle kilted to her knee,
To which the mud splash'd
 wretchedly;
And the wet dripp'd from every tree
Upon her head and heavy hair,
And on her eyelids broad and fair;
The tears and rain ran down her face.

By fits and starts they rode apace,
And very often was his place
Far off from her; he had to ride
Ahead, to see what might betide
When the road cross'd; and
 sometimes, when
There rose a murmuring from his
 men,
Had to turn back with promises;
Ah me! she had but little ease;
And often for pure doubt and dread
She sobb'd, made giddy in the head

By the swift riding; while, for cold,

Her slender fingers scarce could hold
The wet reins; yea, and scarcely, too,
She felt the foot within her shoe
Against the stirrup: all for this,
To part at last without a kiss
Beside the haystack in the floods.

For when they near'd that old soak'd
 hay,
They saw across the only way
That Judas, Godmar, and the three
Red running lions dismally
Grinn'd from his pennon, under
 which
In one straight line along the ditch,
They counted thirty heads.

 So then,
While Robert turn'd round to his men,
She saw at once the wretched end,
And, stooping down, tried hard to
 rend
Her coif the wrong way from her
 head,
And hid her eyes; while Robert said:
"Nay, love, 'tis scarcely two to one,
At Poitiers where we made them run
So fast—why, sweet my love, good
 cheer,
The Gascon frontier is so near,
Nought after this."

 But, "O," she
 said,
"My God! my God! I have to tread
The long way back without you; then
The court at Paris; those six men;

The gratings of the Chatelet;
The swift Seine on some rainy day
Like this, and people standing by,
And laughing, while my weak hands
 try
To recollect how strong men swim.
All this, or else a life with him,
For which I should be damned at last,
Would God that this next hour were
 past!"

He answer'd not, but cried his cry,
"St. George for Marny!" cheerily;
And laid his hand upon her rein.
Alas! no man of all his train
Gave back that cheery cry again;
And, while for rage his thumb beat
 fast
Upon his sword-hilt, some one cast
About his neck a kerchief long,
And bound him.

 Then they went
 along
To Godmar; who said: "Now, Jehane,
Your lover's life is on the wane
So fast, that, if this very hour
You yield not as my paramour,
He will not see the rain leave off—
Nay, keep your tongue from gibe and
 scoff,
Sir Robert, or I slay you now."

She laid her hand upon her brow,
Then gazed upon the palm, as though
She thought her forehead bled, and
 —"No,"

She said, and turn'd her head away,
As there were nothing else to say,
And everything were settled: red
Grew Godmar's face from chin to
head:

"Jehane, on yonder hill there stands
My castle, guarding well my lands:
What hinders me from taking you,
And doing that I list to do
To your fair wilful body, while
Your knight lies dead?"

A wicked smile
Wrinkled her face, her lips grew thin,
A long way out she thrust her chin:
"You know that I should strangle you
While you were sleeping; or bite
through
Your throat, by God's help—ah!" she
said,
"Lord Jesus, pity your poor maid!
For in such wise they hem me in,
I cannot choose but sin and sin,
Whatever happens: yet I think
They could not make me eat or drink,
And so should I just reach my rest."

"Nay, if you do not my behest,
O Jehane! though I love you well,"
Said Godmar, "would I fail to tell
All that I know." "Foul lies," she said.
"Eh? lies, my Jehane? by God's head,
At Paris folks would deem them true!
Do you know, Jehane, they cry for
you,
'Jehane the brown! Jehane the brown!
Give us Jehane to burn or drown!'—"

Eh—gag me, Robert!—sweet my
friend,
This were indeed a piteous end
For those long fingers, and long feet,
And long neck, and smooth shoulders
sweet;
An end that few men would forget
That saw it—So, an hour yet:
Consider, Jehane, which to take
Of life or death!"

So, scarce awake
Dismounting, did she leave that
place,
And totter some yards: with her face
Turn'd upward to the sky she lay,
Her head on a wet heap of hay,
And fell asleep: and while she slept,
And did not dream, the minutes crept
Round to the twelve again; but she,
Being waked at last, sigh'd quietly,
And strangely childlike came, and
said:
"I will not." Straightway Godmar's
head,
As though it hung on strong wires,
turn'd
Most sharply round, and his face
burn'd.

For Robert—both his eyes were dry,
He could not weep but gloomily
He seem'd to watch the rain; yea, too,
His lips were firm; he tried once more
To touch her lips; she reach'd out,
sore
And vain desire so tortured them,

The poor grey lips, and now the hem
Of his sleeve brush'd them.

With a start
Up Godmar rose, thrust them apart;
From Robert's throat he loosed the
bands
Of silk and mail; with empty hands
Held out, she stood and gazed, and
saw,
The long bright blade without a flaw
Glide out from Godmar's sheath, his
hand
In Robert's hair; she saw him bend
Back Robert's head; she saw him
send
The thin steel down; the blow told
well,
Right backward the knight Robert
fell,
And moan'd as dogs do, being half
dead,
Unwitting, as I deem: so then
Godmar turn'd grinning to his men,
Who ran, some five or six, and beat
His head to pieces at their feet.

Then Godmar turn'd again and said:
"So, Jehane, the first fitte is read!
Take note, my lady, that your way
Lies backward to the Chatelet!"
She shook her head and gazed awhile
At her cold hands with a rueful smile,
As though this thing had made her
mad.
This was the parting that they had
Beside the haystack in the floods.

RIDING TOGETHER.

For many, many days together
The wind blew steady from the
East;
For many days hot grew the weather,
About the time of our Lady's
Feast.

For many days we rode together,
Yet met we neither friend nor
foe;
Hotter and clearer grew the weather,
Steadily did the East wind blow.

We saw the trees in the hot, bright
weather,
Clear-cut, with shadows very
black,
As freely we rode on together
With helms unlaced and bridles
slack.

And often as we rode together,
We, looking down the green-
bank'd stream,
Saw flowers in the sunny weather,
And saw the bubble-making
bream.

And in the night lay down together,
And hung above our heads the
rood,

Or watch'd night-long in the dewy
weather,
The while the moon did watch
the wood.

Our spears stood bright and thick
together,
Straight out the banners stream'd
behind,
As we gallop'd on in the sunny
weather,
With faces turn'd towards the
wind.

Down sank our threescore spears
together,
As thick we saw the Pagans ride;
His eager face in the clear fresh
weather,
Shone out that last time by my
side.

Up the sweep of the bridge we dash'd
together,
It rock'd to the crash of the
meeting spears,
Down rain'd the buds of the dear
spring weather,
The elm-tree flowers fell like
tears.

There, as we roll'd and writhed
together,
I threw my arms above my head,
For close by my side, in the lovely
weather,

I saw him reel and fall back
dead.

I and the slayer met together,
He waited the death-stroke there
in his place,
With thoughts of death, in the lovely
weather,
Gapingly mazed at my madden'd
face.

Madly I fought as we fought together;
In vain: the little Christian band
The pagans drowned, as in stormy
weather,
The river drowns low-lying land.

They bound my blood-stain'd hands
together,
They bound his corpse to nod by
my side:
Then on we rode, in the bright-March
weather,
With clash of cymbals did we
ride.

We ride no more, no more together;
My prison-bars are thick and
strong,
I take no heed of any weather,
The sweet Saints grant I live not
long.

SUMMER DAWN.

Pray but one prayer for me 'twixt thy
closed lips,

Think but one thought of me up
in the stars.

The summer night waneth, the
morning light slips,

Faint and grey 'twixt the leaves
of the aspen, betwixt the
cloud-bars,

That are patiently waiting there for
the dawn:

Patient and colourless, though
Heaven's gold

Waits to float through them along
with the sun.

Far out in the meadows, above the
young corn,

The heavy elms wait, and
restless and cold

The uneasy wind rises; the roses are
dun;

Through the long twilight they pray
for the dawn,

Round the lone house in the midst of
the corn.

Speak but one word to me over
the corn,

Over the tender, bow'd locks of
the corn.

FROM

"THE LIFE AND DEATH OF JASON."

BOOK XIV.

The Sirens—The Garden of the Hesperides —The Heroes do Sacrifice at Malea.

Across the open sea they drew their
wake
For three long days, and when the
fourth 'gan break
Their eyes beheld the fair Trinacrian
shore,
And there-along they coasted two
days more.
Then first Medea warned them to
take heed,
Lest they should end all memory of
their deed
Where dwell the Sirens on the yellow
sand,
And folk should think some tangled
poisonous land
Had buried them, or some tumultuous
sea
O'er their white bones was tossing
angrily;
Or that some muddy river, far from
Greece,
Drove seaward o'er the ringlets of the
Fleece.

But when the Minyæ hearkened
to this word,
With many a thought their wearied
hearts were stirred,
And longing for the near-gained
Grecian land,
Where in a little while their feet
should stand;
Yet none the less like to a happy
dream,
Now, when they neared it, did their
own home seem,
And like a dream the glory of their
quest,
And therewithal some thought of
present rest
Stole over them, and they were fain
to sigh,
Hearkening the sighing restless wind
go by.
But hard on even of the second
day,
As o'er the gentle waves they took
their way,
The orange-scented land-breeze
seemed to bear
Some other sounds unto the listening
ear
Than all day long they had been
hearkening,
The land-born signs of many a well-
known thing.
Thereat Medea trembled, for she
knew
That nigh the dreadful sands at last
they drew,

For certainly the Sirens' song she
heard,
Though yet her ear could shape it to
no word,
And by their faces could the queen
behold
How sweet it was, although no tale it
told,
To those worn toilers o'er the bitter
sea.

Now, as they sped along, they
presently,
Rounding a headland, reached a little
bay
Walled from the sea by splintered
cliffs and grey,
Capped by the thymy hills' green
wind-beat head,
Where 'mid the whin the burrowing
rabbits fed.
And 'neath the cliff they saw a belt of
sand,
'Twixt Nereus' pasture and the high
scarped land,
Whereon, yet far off, could their eyes
behold
White bodies moving, crowned and
girt with gold,
Wherefrom it seemed that lovely
music welled.

So when all this the grey-eyed
queen beheld,
She said: "O Jason, I have made thee
wise
In this and other things; turn then
thine eyes

Seaward, and note the ripple of the
 sea,
Where there is hope as well as fear
 for thee.
Nor look upon the death that lurketh
 there
'Neath the grey cliff, though sweet it
 seems and fair;
For thou art young upon this day to
 die.
Take then the helm, and gazing
 steadily
Upon the road to Greece, make strong
 thine hand,
And steer us toward the lion-haunted
 land,
And thou, O Thracian! if thou e'er
 hast moved
Men's hearts with stories of the Gods
 who loved,
And men who suffered, move them
 on this day,
Taking the deadly love of death away,
That even now is stealing over them,
While still they gaze upon the ocean's
 hem,
Where their undoing is if they but
 knew."

 But while she spake, still nigher
 Argo drew
Unto the yellow edges of the shore,
And little help she had of ashen oar,
For as her shielded side rolled
 through the sea,
Silent with glittering eyes the Minyæ

Gazed o'er the surge, for they were
nigh enow
To see the gusty wind of evening
blow
Long locks of hair across those
bodies white,
With golden spray hiding some dear
delight;
Yea, nigh enow to see their red lips
smile,
Wherefrom all song had ceased now
for a while,
As though they deemed the prey was
in the net,
And they no more had need a bait to
set,
But their own bodies, fair beyond
man's thought,
Under the grey cliff, hidden not of
aught
But of such mist of tears as in the
eyes
Of those seafaring men might chance
to rise.

A moment Jason gazed, then
through the waist
Ran swiftly, and with trembling hands
made haste
To trim the sail, then to the tiller ran,
And thrust aside the skilled Milesian
man,
Who with half-open mouth, and
dreamy eyes,
Stood steering Argo to that land of
lies;
But as he staggered forward, Jason's
hand

Hard on the tiller steered away from
land,
And as her head a little now fell off
Unto the wide sea, did he shout this
scoff
To Thracian Orpheus: "Minstrel, shall
we die,
Because thou hast forgotten utterly
What things she taught thee whom
men call divine?
Or will thy measures but lead folk to
wine,
And scented beds, and not to noble
deeds?
Or will they fail as fail the shepherd's
reeds
Before the trumpet, when these sea-
witches
Pipe shrilly to the washing of the
seas?
I am a man, and these but beasts, but
thou
Giving these souls, that all were men
ere now,
Shalt be a very God and not a man!"
So spake he; but his fingers
Orpheus ran
Over the strings, and sighing turned
away
From that fair ending of the sunny
bay;
But as his well-skilled hands were
preluding
What his heart swelled with, they
began to sing
With pleading voices from the yellow
sands,

Clustered together, with appealing
hands
Reached out to Argo as the great sail
drew,
While o'er their white limbs sharp the
spray-shower flew,
Since they spared not to set white feet
among
The cold waves heedless of their
honied song.
Sweetly they sang, and still the
answer came
Piercing and clear from him, as bursts
the flame
From out the furnace in the moonless
night;
Yet, as their words are no more
known aright
Through lapse of many ages, and no
man
Can any more across the waters wan
Behold those singing women of the
sea,
Once more I pray you all to pardon
me,
If with my feeble voice and harsh I
sing
From what dim memories yet may
chance to cling
About men's hearts, of lovely things
once sung
Beside the sea, while yet the world
was young.

THE SIRENS.

O happy seafarers are ye,

And surely all your ills are past,
And toil upon the land and sea,
Since ye are brought to us at
last.

To you the fashion of the world,
Wide lands laid waste, fair cities
burned,
And plagues, and kings from
kingdoms hurled,
Are nought, since hither ye have
turned.

For as upon this beach we stand,
And o'er our heads the sea-fowl
flit,
Our eyes behold a glorious land,
And soon shall ye be kings of it.

ORPHEUS.

A little more, a little more,
O carriers of the Golden Fleece,
A little labour with the oar,
Before we reach the land of
Greece.

E'en now perchance faint rumours
reach
Men's ears of this our victory,
And draw them down unto the beach
To gaze across the empty sea.

But since the longed-for day is nigh,
And scarce a God could stay us
now,
Why do ye hang your heads and sigh,

Hindering for nought our eager
prow?

THE SIRENS.

Ah, had ye chanced to reach the
home
On which your fond desires
were set,
Into what troubles had ye come?
Short love and joy and long
regret.

But now, but now, when ye have lain
Asleep with us a little while
Beneath the washing of the main,
How calm shall be your waking
smile!

For ye shall smile to think of life
That knows no troublous change
or fear,
No unavailing bitter strife,
That ere its time brings trouble
near.

ORPHEUS.

Is there some murmur in your ears,
That all that we have done is
nought,
And nothing ends our cares and fears,
Till the last fear on us is
brought?

THE SIRENS.

Alas! and will ye stop your ears,
In vain desire to do aught,
And wish to live 'mid cares and fears,
Until the last fear makes you
nought?

ORPHEUS.

Is not the May-time now on earth,
When close against the city wall
The folk are singing in their mirth,
While on their heads the May-
flowers fall?

THE SIRENS.

Yes, May is come, and its sweet
breath
Shall well-nigh make you weep
to-day,
And pensive with swift-coming
death,
Shall ye be satiate of the May.

ORPHEUS.

Shall not July bring fresh delight,
As underneath green trees ye sit,
And o'er some damsel's body white
The noontide shadows change
and flit?

THE SIRENS.

No new delight July shall bring
But ancient fear and fresh desire,

And, spite of every lovely thing,
Of July surely shall ye tire.

ORPHEUS.

And now, when August comes on
thee,
And 'mid the golden sea of corn
The merry reapers thou mayst see,
Wilt thou still think the earth
forlorn?

THE SIRENS.

Set flowers upon thy short-lived
head,
And in thine heart forgetfulness
Of man's hard toil, and scanty bread,
And weary of those days no less.

ORPHEUS.

Or wilt thou climb the sunny hill,
In the October afternoon,
To watch the purple earth's blood fill
The grey vat to the maiden's
tune?

THE SIRENS.

When thou beginnest to grow old,
Bring back remembrance of thy
bliss
With that the shining cup doth hold,
And weary helplessly of this.

ORPHEUS.

Or pleasureless shall we pass by
The long cold night and leaden
day,
That song, and tale, and minstrelsy
Shall make as merry as the
May?

THE SIRENS.

List then, to-night, to some old tale
Until the tears o'erflow thine
eyes;
But what shall all these things avail,
When sad to-morrow comes and
dies?

ORPHEUS.

And when the world is born again,
And with some fair love, side by
side,
Thou wanderest 'twixt the sun and
rain,
In that fresh love-begetting tide;

Then, when the world is born again,
And the sweet year before thee
lies,
Shall thy heart think of coming pain,
Or vex itself with memories?

THE SIRENS.

Ah! then the world is born again

With burning love unsatisfied,
And new desires fond and vain,
And weary days from tide to
tide.

Ah! when the world is born again,
A little day is soon gone by,
When thou, unmoved by sun or rain,
Within a cold straight house
shalt lie.

Therewith they ceased awhile, as
languidly
The head of Argo fell off toward the
sea,
And through the water she began to
go,
For from the land a fitful wind did
blow,
That, dallying with the many-
coloured sail,
Would sometimes swell it out and
sometimes fail,
As nigh the east side of the bay they
drew;
Then o'er the waves again the music
flew.

THE SIRENS.

Think not of pleasure, short and
vain.
Wherewith, 'mid days of toil and
pain,
With sick and sinking hearts ye strive
To cheat yourselves that ye may live
With cold death ever close at hand;

Think rather of a peaceful land,
The changeless land where ye may be
Roofed over by the changeful sea.

ORPHEUS.

And is the fair town nothing
then,
The coming of the wandering men
With that long talked of thing and
strange,
And news of how the kingdoms
change;
The pointed hands, and wondering
At doers of a desperate thing?
Push on, for surely this shall be
Across a narrow strip of sea.

THE SIRENS.

Alas! poor souls and timorous,
Will ye draw nigh to gaze at us
And see if we are fair indeed,
For such as we shall be your meed,
There, where our hearts would have
you go.
And where can the earth-dwellers
show
In any land such loveliness
As that wherewith your eyes we
bless,
O wanderers of the Minyæ,
Worn toilers over land and sea?

ORPHEUS.

Fair as the lightning thwart the
sky,
As sun-dyed snow upon the high
Untrodden heaps of threatening stone
The eagle looks upon alone,
O fair as the doomed victim's wreath,
O fair as deadly sleep and death,
What will ye with them, earthly men,
To mate your three-score years and
ten?
Toil rather, suffer and be free,
Betwixt the green earth and the sea.

THE SIRENS.

If ye be bold with us to go,
Things such as happy dreams may
show
Shall your once heavy eyes behold
About our palaces of gold;
Where waters 'neath the waters run,
And from o'erhead a harmless sun
Gleams through the woods of
chrysolite.
There gardens fairer to the sight
Than those of the Phæacian king
Shall ye behold; and, wondering,
Gaze on the sea-born fruit and
flowers,
And thornless and unchanging
bowers,
Whereof the May-time knoweth
nought.
So to the pillared house being
brought,
Poor souls, ye shall not be alone,
For o'er the floors of pale blue stone

All day such feet as ours shall pass,
And, 'twixt the glimmering walls of
 glass,
Such bodies garlanded with gold,
So faint, so fair, shall ye behold,
And clean forget the treachery
Of changing earth and tumbling sea.

ORPHEUS.

O the sweet valley of deep grass,
Where-through the summer stream
 doth pass,
In chain of shallow, and still pool,
From misty morn to evening cool;
Where the black ivy creeps and
 twines
O'er the dark-armed, red-trunkèd
 pines,
Whence clattering the pigeon flits,
Or, brooding o'er her thin eggs, sits,
And every hollow of the hills
With echoing song the mavis fills.
There by the stream, all unafraid,
Shall stand the happy shepherd maid,
Alone in first of sunlit hours;
Behind her, on the dewy flowers,
Her homespun woollen raiment lies,
And her white limbs and sweet grey
 eyes
Shine from the calm green pool and
 deep,
While round about the swallows
 sweep,
Not silent; and would God that we,
Like them, were landed from the sea.

THE SIRENS.

Shall we not rise with you at
night,
Up through the shimmering green
twilight,
That maketh there our changeless
day,
Then going through the moonlight
grey,
Shall we not sit upon these sands,
To think upon the troublous lands
Long left behind, where once ye
were,
When every day brought change and
fear?
There, with white arms about you
twined,
And shuddering somewhat at the
wind
That ye rejoiced erewhile to meet,
Be happy, while old stories sweet,
Half understood, float round your
ears,
And fill your eyes with happy tears.
Ah! while we sing unto you
there,
As now we sing, with yellow hair
Blown round about these pearly
limbs,
While underneath the grey sky swims
The light shell-sailor of the waves,
And to our song, from sea-filled
caves
Booms out an echoing harmony,
Shall ye not love the peaceful sea?

ORPHEUS.

Nigh the vine-covered hillocks
green,
In days ago, have I not seen
The brown-clad maidens amorous,
Below the long rose-trellised house,
Dance to the querulous pipe and
shrill,
When the grey shadow of the hill
Was lengthening at the end of day?
Not shadowy nor pale were they,
But limbed like those who 'twixt the
trees,
Follow the swift of Goddesses.
Sunburnt they are somewhat, indeed,
To where the rough brown woollen
weed
Is drawn across their bosoms sweet,
Or cast from off their dancing feet;
But yet the stars, the moonlight grey,
The water wan, the dawn of day,
Can see their bodies fair and white
As Hers, who once, for man's delight,
Before the world grew hard and old,
Came o'er the bitter sea and cold;
And surely those that met me there,
Her handmaidens and subjects were;
And shame-faced, half-repressed
desire
Had lit their glorious eyes with fire,
That maddens eager hearts of men.
O would that I were with them when
The new-risen moon is gathering
light,
And yellow from the homestead
white

The windows gleam; but verily
This waits us o'er a little sea.

THE SIRENS.

Come to the land where none
grows old,
And none is rash or over-bold,
Nor any noise there is nor war,
Nor rumour from wild lands afar,
Nor plagues, nor birth and death of
kings;
No vain desire of unknown things
Shall vex you there, no hope or fear
Of that which never draweth near;
But in that lovely land and still
Ye may remember what ye will,
And what ye will, forget for aye.
So while the kingdoms pass
away,
Ye sea-beat hardened toilers erst,
Unresting, for vain fame athirst,
Shall be at peace for evermore,
With hearts fulfilled of Godlike lore,
And calm, unwavering Godlike love,
No lapse of time can turn or move.
There, ages after your fair Fleece
Is clean forgotten, yea, and Greece
Is no more counted glorious,
Alone with us, alone with us,
Alone with us, dwell happily,
Beneath our trembling roof of sea.

ORPHEUS.

Ah! do ye weary of the strife

And long to change this eager life
For shadowy and dull hopelessness,
Thinking indeed to gain no less
Than far from this grey light to lie,
And there to die and not to die,
To be as if ye ne'er had been,
Yet keep your memory fresh and
 green,
To have no thought of good or ill,
Yet feed your fill or pleasure still?
O idle dream! Ah, verily
If it shall happen unto me
That I have thought of anything,
When o'er my bones the sea-fowl
 sing,
And I lie dead, how shall I pine
For those fresh joys that once were
 mine,
On this green fount of joy and mirth,
The ever young and glorious earth;
Then, helpless, shall I call to mind
Thoughts of the sweet flower-scented
 wind,
The dew, the gentle rain at night,
The wonder-working snow and white.
The song of birds, the water's fall,
The sun that maketh bliss of all;
Yea, this our toil and victory,
The tyrannous and conquered sea.

THE SIRENS.

Ah, will ye go, and whither then
 Will ye go from us, soon to die,
To fill your three-score years and ten,
 With many an unnamed misery?

And this the wretchedest of all,
That when upon your lonely
eyes
The last faint heaviness shall fall
Ye shall bethink you of our cries.

Come back, nor grown old, seek in
vain
To hear us sing across the sea.
Come back, come back, come back
again,
Come back, O fearful Minyæ!

ORPHEUS.

Ah, once again, ah, once again,
The black prow plunges through
the sea,
Nor yet shall all your toil be vain,
Nor yet forgot, O Minyæ.

In such wise sang the Thracian,
in such wise
Out gushed the Sirens' deadly
melodies;
But long before the mingled song was
done,
Back to the oars the Minyæ, one by
one,
Slunk silently; though many an one
sighed sore,
As his strong fingers met the wood
once more,
And from his breast the toilsome
breathing came.
But as they laboured, some for
very shame

Hung down their heads, and yet
amongst them some
Gazed at the place whence that sweet
song had come;
But round the oars and Argo's
shielded side
The sea grew white, and she began to
glide
Swift through the waters of that
deadly bay;
But when a long wake now behind
her lay,
And still the whistle of the wind
increased,
Past shroud and mast, and all the
song had ceased,
Butes rose up, the fair Athenian man,
And with wild eyes betwixt the
rowers ran
Unto the poop and leapt into the sea;
Then all men rested on their oars, but
he
Rose to the top, and towards the
shore swam fast;
While all eyes watched him, who had
well-nigh past
The place where sand and water 'gan
to meet
In wreaths and ripples round the
ivory feet,
When sun-burnt swimmer, snow-
white glancing limb,
And yellow sand unto their eyes grew
dim,
Nor did they see their fellow any
more.

But when they once again
 beheld the shore
The wind sung o'er the empty beach
 and bare,
And by the cliff uprose into the air
A delicate and glittering little cloud,
That seemed some many-coloured
 sun to shroud;
But as the rugged cliff it drew above
The wondering Minyæ beheld it
 move
Westward, toward Lilybæum and the
 sun.

Then once more was their
 seaward course begun,
And soon those deadly sands were far
 astern,
Nor ever after could the heroes learn
If Butes lived or died; but old tales
 tell
That while the tumbling waves he
 breasted well,
Venus beheld him, as unseen she
 drew
From sunny Cyprus to the headland
 blue
Of Lilybæum, where her temple is;
She, with a mind his sun-burnt brows
 to kiss,
E'en as his feet were dropping nigh
 the beach,
And ere his hand the deadly hands
 could reach,
Stooped, as the merlin stoops upon
 the dove,
And snatched him thence to be
 awhile her love,

Betwixt the golden pillars of her
 shrine,
That those who pass the Ægades see
 shine
From high-raised Lilybæum o'er the
 sea.

But far away the sea-beat Minyæ
Cast forth the foam, as through the
 growing night
They laboured ever, having small
 delight
In life all empty of that promised
 bliss,
In love that scarce can give a dying
 kiss,
In pleasure ending sweet songs with a
 wail,
In fame that little can dead men avail,
In vain toil struggling with the fateful
 stream,
In hope, the promise of a morning
 dream.

Yet as night died, and the cold
 sea and grey
Seemed running with them toward
 the dawn of day,
Needs must they once again forget
 their death,
Needs must they, being alive and
 drawing breath,
As men who of no other life can
 know
In their own minds again immortal
 grow.

But toward the south a little now
 they bent,

And for a while o'er landless sea they
went,
But on the third day made another
land
At dawn of day, and thitherward did
stand;
And since the wind blew lightly from
the shore,
Somewhat abeam, they feared not
with the oar
To push across the shallowing sea and
green,
That washed a land the fairest they
had seen,
Whose shell-strewn beach at highest
of the tide
'Twixt sea and flowery shore was
nowise wide,
And drawn a little backward from the
sea
There stood a marble wall wrought
cunningly,
Rosy and white, set thick with
images,
And over-topped with heavy-fruited
trees,
Which by the shore ran, as the bay
did bend,
And to their eyes had neither gap nor
end;
Nor any gate: and looking over this,
They saw a place not made for
earthly bliss,
Or eyes of dying men, for growing
there
The yellow apple and the painted
pear,

And well-filled golden cups of
 oranges
Hung amid groves of pointed cypress
 trees;
On grassy slopes the twining vine-
 boughs grew,
And hoary olives 'twixt far mountains
 blue,
And many-coloured flowers, like as a
 cloud
The rugged southern cliffs did softly
 shroud;
And many a green-necked bird sung
 to his mate
Within the slim-leaved, thorny
 pomegranate,
That flung its unstrung rubies on the
 grass,
And slowly o'er the place the wind
 did pass
Heavy with many odours that it bore
From thymy hills down to the sea-
 beat shore,
Because no flower there is, that all
 the year,
From spring to autumn, beareth
 otherwhere,
But there it flourished; nor the fruit
 alone
From 'twixt the green leaves and the
 boughs outshone,
For there each tree was ever
 flowering.
 Nor was there lacking many a
 living thing
Changed of its nature; for the roebuck
 there

Walked fearless with the tiger; and
the bear
Rolled sleepily upon the fruit-strawn
grass,
Letting the conies o'er his rough hide
pass,
With blinking eyes, that meant no
treachery.
Careless the partridge passed the red
fox by;
Untouched the serpent left the
thrushes brown,
And as a picture was the lion's frown.
But in the midst there was a
grassy space,
Raised somewhat over all the flowery
place,
On marble terrace-walls wrought like
a dream;
And round about it ran a clear blue
stream,
Bridged o'er with marble steps, and
midmost there
Grew a green tree, whose smooth
grey boughs did bear
Such fruit as never man elsewhere
had seen,
For 'twixt the sunlight and the
shadow green
Shone out fair apples of red gleaming
gold.
Moreover round the tree, in many a
fold,
Lay coiled a dragon, glittering little
less
Than that which his eternal
watchfulness

Was set to guard; nor yet was he
alone,
For from the daisied grass about him
shone
Gold raiment wrapping round two
damsels fair,
And one upon the steps combed out
her hair,
And with shut eyes sung low as in a
dream;
And one stood naked in the cold blue
stream,
While on the bank her golden raiment
lay;
But on that noontide of the quivering
day,
She only, hearing the seafarers' shout,
Her lovely golden head had turned
about,
And seen their white sail flapping o'er
the wall,
And as she turned had let her tresses
fall,
Which the thin water rippling round
her knee
Bore outward from her toward the
restless sea.
Not long she stood, but looking
seaward yet,
From out the water made good haste
to get,
And catching up her raiment hastily,
Ran up the marble stair, and 'gan to
cry:
"Wake, O my sisters, wake, for now
are come

The thieves of Æa to our peaceful
home."

Then at her voice they gat them
to their feet,
And when her raiment all her body
sweet
Once more had hidden, joining hand
to hand,
About the sacred apples did they
stand,
While coiled the dragon closer to the
tree,
And raised his head above them
threateningly.

Meanwhile, from Argo many a
sea-beat face
Gazed longingly upon that lovely
place,
And some their eager hands already
laid
Upon the gangway. Then Medea said:

—
"Get back unto the oars, O Minyæ,
Nor loiter here, for what have such as
we
To do herein, where, 'mid undying
trees,
Undying watch the wise Hesperides,
And where the while they watch,
scarce can a God
Set foot upon the fruit-besprinkled
sod
That no snow ever covers? therefore
haste,
Nor yet in wondering your fair lives
waste;

For these are as the Gods, nor think
 of us,
Nor to their eyes can aught be
 glorious
That son of man can do; would God
 that I
Could see far off the misty headland
 lie,
Where we the guilt of blood shall
 wash away,
For I grow weary of the dashing
 spray,
And ceaseless roll of interwoven
 seas,
And fain were sitting 'neath the
 whispering trees
In homely places, where the children
 play,
Who change like me, grow old, and
 die some day."
 She ceased, and little soothly did
 they grieve,
For all its loveliness, that land to
 leave,
For now some God had chilled their
 hardihead,
And in their hearts had set a sacred
 dread,
They knew not why; but on their oars
 they hung,
A little longer as the sisters sung.

 "O ye, who to this place have
 strayed,
That never for man's eyes was made,
Depart in haste, as ye have come,
And bear back to your sea-beat home

This memory of the age of gold,
And for your eyes, grown over-bold,
Your hearts shall pay in sorrowing,
For want of many a half-seen thing.

"Lo, such as is this garden green,
In days past, all the world has been,
And what we know all people knew,
Save this, that unto worse all grew.

"But since the golden age is
gone,
This little place is left alone,
Unchanged, unchanging, watched of
us,
The daughters of wise Hesperus.

"Surely the heavenly Messenger
Full oft is fain to enter here,
And yet without must he abide;
Nor longeth less the dark king's bride
To set red lips unto that fruit
That erst made nought her mother's
suit.

Here would Diana rest awhile,
Forgetful of her woodland guile,
Among these beasts that fear her
nought.

Nor is it less in Pallas' thought,
Beneath our trees to ponder o'er
The wide, unfathomed sea of lore;
And oft-kissed Citheræa, no less
Weary of love, full fain would press
These flowers with soft unsandalled
feet.

"But unto us our rest is sweet,
Neither shall any man or God
Or lovely Goddess touch the sod

Where-under old times buried lie,
Before the world knew misery.
Nor will we have a slave or king,
Nor yet will we learn anything
But that we know, that makes us glad;
While oft the very Gods are sad
With knowing what the Fates shall
do.

"Neither from us shall wisdom
go

To fill the hungering hearts of men,
Lest to them threescore years and ten
Come but to seem a little day,
Once given, and taken soon away.
Nay, rather let them find their life
Bitter and sweet, fulfilled of strife,
Restless with hope, vain with regret,
Trembling with fear, most strangely
set

'Twixt memory and forgetfulness;
So more shall joy be, troubles less,
And surely when all this is past,
They shall not want their rest at last.

"Let earth and heaven go on
their way,
While still we watch from day to day,
In this green place left all alone,
A remnant of the days long gone."

There in the wind they hung, as
word by word
The clear-voiced singers silently they
heard;
But when the air was barren of their
song,
Anigh the shore they durst not linger
long,

So northward turned forewearied
Argo's head,
And dipping oars, from that fair
country sped,
Fulfilled of new desires and pensive
thought,
Which that day's life unto their hearts
had brought.
Then hard they toiled upon the
bitter sea,
And in two days they did not fail to
be
In sight of land, a headland high and
blue
Which straight Milesian Erginus
knew
To be the fateful place which now
they sought,
Stormy Malea, so thitherward they
brought
The groaning ship, and, casting
anchor, lay
Beneath that headland's lee, within a
bay,
Wherefrom the more part landed, and
their feet
Once more the happy soil of Greece
did meet.
Therewith they failed not to
bring ashore
Rich robes of price and of fair arms
good store,
And gold and silver, that they there
might buy
What yet they lacked for their
solemnity;

Then, while upon the highest point of
land
Some built an altar, Jason, with a
band
Of all the chiefest of the Minyæ,
Turned inland from the murmur of
the sea.
Not far they went ere by a little
stream
Down in a valley they could see the
gleam
Of brazen pillars and fair-gilded
vanes,
And, dropping down by dank dark-
wooded lanes
From off the hill-side, reached a
house at last
Where in and out men-slaves and
women passed,
And guests were streaming fast into
the hall,
Where now the oaken boards were
laid for all.
With these the Minyæ went, and soon
they were
Within a pillared hall both great and
fair,
Where folk already sat beside the
board,
And on the dais was an ancient lord.
But when these saw the fearless
Minyæ
Glittering in arms, they sprang up
hastily,
And each man turned about unto the
wall

To seize his spear or staff: then
 through the hall
Jason cried out: "Laconians, fear ye
 not,
Nor leave the flesh-meat while it
 reeketh hot
For dread of us, for we are men as ye,
And I am Jason of the Minyæ,
And come from Æa to the land of
 Greece,
And in my ship bear back the Golden
 Fleece,
And a fair Colchian queen to fill my
 bed.
And now we pray to share your wine
 and bread,
And other things we need, and at our
 hands
That ye will take fair things of many
 lands."

 "Sirs," said the ancient lord, "be
 welcome here,
Come up and sit by me, and make
 such cheer
As here ye can: glad am I that to me
The first of Grecian men from off the
 sea
Ye now are come."

 Therewith the
 great hall
 rang
With joyful shouts, and as, with clash
 and clang
Of well-wrought arms, up to the dais
 they went,
All eyes upon the Minyæ were bent,

Nor could they have enough of
wondering
At this or that sea-tossed victorious
king.
So with the strangers there they
held high feast,
And afterwards the slaves drove
many a beast
Down to the shore, and carried back
again
Great store of precious things in pack
and wain;
Wrought gold and silver, gems, full
many a bale
Of scarlet cloth, and fine silk, fit to
veil
The perfect limbs of dreaded
Goddesses;
Spices fresh-gathered from the
outland trees,
And arms well-wrought, and precious
scarce-known wine,
And carven images well-nigh divine.
So when all folk with these were
satisfied,
Back went the Minyæ to the water-
side,
And with them that old lord, fain to
behold
Victorious Argo and the Fleece of
Gold.
And so aboard amid the oars he lay
Throughout the night, and at the
dawn of day
Did all men land, nor spared that day
to wear

The best of all they had of gold-
wrought gear,
And every one, being crowned with
olive grey,
Up to the headland did they take their
way,
Where now already stood the
crownèd priests
About the altars by the gilt-horned
beasts.
There, as the fair sun rose, did Jason
break
Over the altar the thin barley-cake,
And cast the salt abroad, and there
were slain
The milk-white bulls, and there red
wine did rain
On to the fire from out the ancient jar,
And high rose up the red flame, seen
afar
From many another headland of that
shore:
But over all its crackling and its roar
Uprose from time to time a joyous
song,
That on the summer morning lay for
long,
The mighty voices of the Minyæ
Exulting o'er the tossing conquered
sea,
That far below thrust on by tide and
wind
The crumbling bases of the headland
mined.

FROM

"THE EARTHLY PARADISE."

AN APOLOGY.

Of Heaven or Hell I have no power to
sing,
I cannot ease the burden of your
fears,
Or make quick-coming death a little
thing,
Or bring again the pleasure of past
years,
Nor for my words shall ye forget your
tears,
Or hope again for aught that I can
say,
The idle singer of an empty day.

But rather, when aweary of your
mirth,
From full hearts still unsatisfied ye
sigh,
And, feeling kindly unto all the earth,
Grudge every minute as it passes by,
Made the more mindful that the sweet
days die—
—Remember me a little then I pray,
The idle singer of an empty day.

The heavy trouble, the
bewildering care
That weighs us down who live and
earn our bread,
These idle verses have no power to
bear;
So let me sing of names remembered,
Because they, living not, can ne'er be
dead,
Or long time take their memory quite
away

From us poor singers of an empty
day.

Dreamer of dreams, born out of
my due time,
Why should I strive to set the crooked
straight?
Let it suffice me that my murmuring
rhyme
Beats with light wing against the
ivory gate,
Telling a tale not too importunate
To those who in the sleepy region
stay,
Lulled by the singer of an empty day.

Folk say, a wizard to a northern
king
At Christmas-tide such wondrous
things did show,
That through one window men beheld
the spring,
And through another saw the summer
glow,
And through a third the fruited vines
a-row,
While still, unheard, but in its wonted
way,
Piped the drear wind of that
December day.

So with this Earthly Paradise it
is,
If ye will read aright, and pardon me,
Who strive to build a shadowy isle of
bliss
Midmost the beating of the steely sea,

Where tossed about all hearts of men
must be:
Whose ravening monsters mighty
men shall slay,
Not the poor singer of an empty day.

FROM

PROLOGUE—THE WANDERERS.

ARGUMENT.

Certain gentlemen and mariners of Norway, having considered all that they had heard of the Earthly Paradise, set sail to find it, and after many troubles and the lapse of many years came old men to some Western land, of which they had never before heard: there they died, when they had dwelt there certain years, much honoured of the strange people.

Forget six counties overhung with
 smoke,
Forget the snorting steam and piston
 stroke,
Forget the spreading of the hideous
 town;
Think rather of the pack-horse on the
 down,
And dream of London, small, and
 white, and clean,
The clear Thames bordered by its
 gardens green;
Think, that below bridge the green
 lapping waves
Smite some few keels that bear
 Levantine staves,
Cut from the yew wood on the burnt-
 up hill,
And pointed jars that Greek hands
 toiled to fill,
And treasured scanty spice from
 some far sea,

Florence gold cloth, and Ypres
 napery,
And cloth of Bruges, and hogsheads
 of Guienne;
While nigh the thronged wharf
 Geoffrey Chaucer's pen
Moves over bills of lading—mid such
 times
Shall dwell the hollow puppets of my
 rhymes.

A nameless city in a distant sea,
White as the changing walls of faërie,
Thronged with much people clad in
 ancient guise
I now am fain to set before your eyes;
There, leave the clear green water and
 the quays,
And pass betwixt its marble palaces,
Until ye come unto the chiefest
 square;
A bubbling conduit is set midmost
 there,
And round about it now the maidens
 throng,
With jest and laughter, and sweet
 broken song,
Making but light of labour new begun
While in their vessels gleams the
 morning sun.
On one side of the square a
 temple stands,
Wherein the gods worshipped in
 ancient lands
Still have their altars, a great market-
 place

Upon two other sides fills all the
space,
And thence the busy hum of men
comes forth;
But on the cold side looking toward
the north
A pillared council-house may you
behold,
Within whose porch are images of
gold,
Gods of the nations who dwelt
anciently
About the borders of the Grecian sea.

Pass now between them, push
the brazen door,
And standing on the polished marble
floor
Leave all the noises of the square
behind;
Most calm that reverent chamber
shall ye find,
Silent at first, but for the noise you
made
When on the brazen door your hand
you laid
To shut it after you—but now behold
The city rulers on their thrones of
gold,
Clad in most fair attire, and in their
hands
Long carven silver-banded ebony
wands;
Then from the daïs drop your eyes
and see
Soldiers and peasants standing
reverently

Before those elders, round a little
band
Who bear such arms as guard the
English land,
But battered, rent, and rusted sore,
and they,
The men themselves, are shrivelled,
bent, and grey;
And as they lean with pain upon their
spears
Their brows seem furrowed deep with
more than years;
For sorrow dulls their heavy sunken
eyes,
Bent are they less with time than
miseries.

Pondering on them the city grey-
beards gaze
Through kindly eyes, midst thoughts
of other days,
And pity for poor souls, and vague
regret
For all the things that might have
happened yet,
Until, their wonder gathering to a
head,
The wisest man, who long that land
has led,
Breaks the deep silence, unto whom
again
A wanderer answers. Slowly as in
pain,
And with a hollow voice as from a
tomb
At first he tells the story of his doom,

But as it grows and once more hopes
and fears,
Both measureless, are ringing round
his ears,
His eyes grow bright, his seeming
days decrease,
For grief once told brings somewhat
back of peace.

THE ELDER OF THE CITY.

From what unheard-of world, in
what strange keel,
Have ye come hither to our
commonweal?
No barbarous race, as these our
peasants say,
But learned in memories of a long-
past day,
Speaking, some few at least, the
ancient tongue
That through the lapse of ages still
has clung
To us, the seed of the Ionian race.
Speak out and fear not; if ye
need a place
Wherein to pass the end of life away,
That shall ye gain from us from this
same day,
Unless the enemies of God ye are;
We fear not you and yours to bear us
war,
And scarce can think that ye will try
again
Across the perils of the shifting plain

To seek your own land whereso that
may be:
For folk of ours bearing the memory
Of our old land, in days past oft have
striven
To reach it, unto none of whom was
given
To come again and tell us of the tale,
Therefore our ships are now content
to sail,
About these happy islands that we
know.

THE WANDERER.

Masters, I have to tell a tale of
woe,
A tale of folly and of wasted life,
Hope against hope, the bitter dregs of
strife,
Ending, where all things end, in death
at last:
So if I tell the story of the past,
Let it be worth some little rest, I pray,
A little slumber ere the end of day.

No wonder if the Grecian tongue
I know,
Since at Byzantium many a year ago
My father bore the twibil valiantly;
There did he marry, and get me, and
die,
And I went back to Norway to my
kin,
Long ere this beard ye see did first
begin

To shade my mouth, but nathless not
before
Among the Greeks I gathered some
small lore,
And standing midst the Væringers,
still heard
From this or that man many a
wondrous word;
For ye shall know that though we
worshipped God,
And heard mass duly, still of
Swithiod
The Greater, Odin and his house of
gold,
The noble stories ceased not to be
told;
These moved me more than words of
mine can say
E'en while at Micklegarth my folks
did stay;
But when I reached one dying
autumn-tide
My uncle's dwelling near the forest
side,
And saw the land so scanty and so
bare,
And all the hard things men contend
with there,
A little and unworthy land it seemed,
And yet the more of Asagard I
dreamed,
And worthier seemed the ancient
faith of praise.

But now, but now—when one of
all those days

Like Lazarus' finger on my heart
should be
Breaking the fiery fixed eternity,
But for one moment—could I see
once more
The grey-roofed sea-port sloping
towards the shore,
Or note the brown boats standing in
from sea,
Or the great dromond swinging from
the quay,
Or in the beech-woods watch the
screaming jay
Shoot up betwixt the tall trunks,
smooth and grey—
Yea, could I see the days before
distress
When very longing was but
happiness.

Within our house there was a
Breton squire
Well learned, who fail'd not to fan the
fire
That evermore unholpen burned in
me
Strange lands and things beyond
belief to see;
Much lore of many lands this Breton
knew;
And for one tale I told, he told me
two.
He, counting Asagard a new-told
thing,
Yet spoke of gardens ever blossoming
Across the western sea where none
grew old,

E'en as the books at Micklegarth had
told,
And said moreover that an English
knight
Had had the Earthly Paradise in sight,
And heard the songs of those that
dwelt therein.
But entered not, being hindered by
his sin.
Shortly, so much of this and that he
said
That in my heart the sharp barb
entered,
And like real life would empty stories
seem,
And life from day to day an empty
dream.

Another man there was, a
Swabian priest,
Who knew the maladies of man and
beast,
And what things helped them; he the
stone still sought
Whereby base metal into gold is
brought,
And strove to gain the precious
draught, whereby
Men live midst mortal men yet never
die;
Tales of the Kaiser Redbeard could he
tell
Who neither went to Heaven nor yet
to Hell,
When from that fight upon the Asian
plain

He vanished, but still lives to come
again
Men know not how or when; but I
listening
Unto this tale thought it a certain
thing
That in some hidden vale of Swithiod
Across the golden pavement still he
trod.

But while our longing for such
things so grew,
And ever more and more we deemed
them true,
Upon the land a pestilence there fell
Unheard of yet in any chronicle,
And, as the people died full fast of it,
With these two men it chanced me
once to sit,
This learned squire whose name was
Nicholas,
And Swabian Laurence, as our
manner was;
For could we help it scarcely did we
part
From dawn to dusk: so heavy, sad at
heart,
We from the castle-yard beheld the
bay
Upon that ne'er-to-be-forgotten day,
Little we said amidst that dreary
mood,
And certes nought that we could say
was good.

It was a bright September
afternoon,

The parched-up beech-trees would be
 yellowing soon
The yellow flowers grown deeper
 with the sun
Were letting fall their petals one by
 one;
No wind there was, a haze was
 gathering o'er
The furthest bound of the faint yellow
 shore;
And in the oily waters of the bay
Scarce moving aught some fisher-
 cobles lay,
And all seemed peace; and had been
 peace indeed
But that we young men of our life
 had need,
And to our listening ears a sound was
 borne
That made the sunlight wretched and
 forlorn—
—The heavy tolling of the minster
 bell—
And nigher yet a tinkling sound did
 tell
That through the streets they bore our
 Saviour Christ
By dying lips in anguish to be kissed.

At last spoke Nicholas, "How
 long shall we
Abide here, looking forth into the sea
Expecting when our turn shall come
 to die?
Fair fellows, will ye come with me
 and try

Now at our worst that long-desired
quest,
Now—when our worst is death, and
life our best."
"Nay, but thou know'st," I said,
"that I but wait
The coming of some man, the turn of
fate,
To make this voyage—but I die
meanwhile,
For I am poor, though my blood be
not vile,
Nor yet for all his lore doth Laurence
hold
Within his crucibles aught like to
gold;
And what hast thou, whose father
driven forth
By Charles of Blois, found shelter in
the North?
But little riches as I needs must
deem."
"Well," said he, "things are
better than they seem,
For 'neath my bed an iron chest I
have
That holdeth things I have made shift
to save
E'en for this end; moreover, hark to
this,
In the next firth a fair long ship there
is
Well victualled, ready even now for
sea,
And I may say it 'longeth unto me;
Since Marcus Erling, late its owner,
lies

Dead at the end of many miseries,
And little Kirstin, as thou well mayst
 know,
Would be content throughout the
 world to go
If I but took her hand, and now still
 more
Hath heart to leave this poor death-
 stricken shore.
Therefore my gold shall buy us
 Bordeaux swords
And Bordeaux wine as we go
 oceanwards.

 "What say ye, will ye go with
 me to-night,
Setting your faces to undreamed
 delight,
Turning your backs unto this
 troublous hell,
Or is the time too short to say
 farewell?"

 "Not so," I said, "rather would I
 depart
Now while thou speakest, never has
 my heart
Been set on anything within this
 land."

 Then said the Swabian, "Let us
 now take hand
And swear to follow evermore this
 quest
Till death or life have set our hearts at
 rest."

 So with joined hands we swore,
 and Nicholas said,

"To-night, fair friends, be ye
 apparelled
To leave this land, bring all the arms
 ye can
And such men as ye trust, my own
 good man
Guards the small postern looking
 towards St. Bride,
And good it were ye should not be
 espied,
Since mayhap freely ye should not go
 hence,
Thou Rolf in special, for this
 pestilence
Makes all men hard and cruel, nor are
 they
Willing that folk should 'scape if they
 must stay:
Be wise; I bid you for a while
 farewell,
Leave ye this stronghold when St.
 Peter's bell
Strikes midnight, all will surely then
 be still,
And I will bide you at King Tryggve's
 hill
Outside the city gates."

 Each went his
 way
Therewith, and I the remnant of that
 day
Gained for the quest three men that I
 deemed true,
And did such other things as I must
 do,
And still was ever listening for the
 chime

Half maddened by the lazy lapse of
time,
Yea, scarce I thought indeed that I
should live
Till the great tower the joyful sound
should give
That set us free: and so the hours
went past,
Till startled by the echoing clang at
last
That told of midnight, armed from
head to heel
Down to the open postern did I steal,
Bearing small wealth—this sword
that yet hangs here
Worn thin and narrow with so many a
year,
My father's axe that from Byzantium,
With some few gems my pouch yet
held, had come,
Nought else that shone with silver or
with gold.
But by the postern gate could I
behold
Laurence the priest all armed as if for
war,
From off the town-wall, having some
small store
Of arms and furs and raiment: then
once more
I turned, and saw the autumn
moonlight fall
Upon the new-built bastions of the
wall,
Strange with black shadow and grey
flood of light,

And further off I saw the lead shine
 bright
On tower and turret-roof against the
 sky,
And looking down I saw the old town
 lie
Black in the shade of the o'er-hanging
 hill,
Stricken with death, and dreary, but
 all still
Until it reached the water of the bay,
That in the dead night smote against
 the quay
Not all unheard, though there was
 little wind.
But as I turned to leave the place
 behind,
The wind's light sound, the slowly
 falling swell,
Were hushed at once by that shrill-
 tinkling bell,
That in that stillness jarring on mine
 ears,
With sudden jangle checked the rising
 tears,
And now the freshness of the open
 sea
Seemed ease and joy and very life to
 me.
 So greeting my new mates with
 little sound,
We made good haste to reach King
 Tryggve's mound,
And there the Breton Nicholas
 beheld,
Who by the hand fair Kirstin Erling
 held,

And round about them twenty men
there stood,
Of whom the more part on the holy
rood
Were sworn till death to follow up the
quest,
And Kirstin was the mistress of the
rest.
Again betwixt us was there little
speech,
But swiftly did we set on toward the
beach,
And coming there our keel, the
Fighting Man,
We boarded, and the long oars out we
ran,
And swept from out the firth, and
sped so well
That scarcely could we hear St.
Peter's bell
Toll one, although the light wind
blew from land;
Then hoisting sail southward we 'gan
to stand,
And much I joyed beneath the moon
to see
The lessening land that might have
been to me
A kindly giver of wife, child, and
friend,
And happy life, or at the worser end
A quiet grave till doomsday rend the
earth.

Night passed, day dawned, and we
grew full of mirth
As with the ever-rising morning wind

Still further lay our threatened death
 behind,
Or so we thought: some eighty men
 we were,
Of whom but fifty knew the
 shipman's gear,
The rest were uplanders; midst such
 of these
As knew not of our quest, with
 promises
Went Nicholas dealing florins round
 about,
With still a fresh tale for each new
 man's doubt,
Till all were fairly won or seemed to
 be
To that strange desperate voyage o'er
 the sea.

OGIER THE DANE.

ARGUMENT.

When Ogier was born, six fay ladies came to the cradle where he lay, and gave him various gifts, as to be brave and happy and the like; but the sixth gave him to be her love when he should have lived long in the world: so Ogier grew up and became the greatest of knights, and at last, after many years, fell into the hands of that fay, and with her, as the story tells, he lives now, though he returned once to the world, as is shown in the process of this tale.

Within some Danish city by the sea,
Whose name, changed now, is all
 unknown to me,
Great mourning was there one fair
 summer eve,
Because the angels, bidden to receive
The fair Queen's lovely soul in
 Paradise,
Had done their bidding, and in royal
 guise
Her helpless body, once the prize of
 love,
Unable now for fear or hope to move,
Lay underneath the golden canopy;
And bowed down by unkingly misery
The King sat by it, and not far away,
Within the chamber a fair man-child
 lay,
His mother's bane, the king that was
 to be,
Not witting yet of any royalty,

Harmless and loved, although so new
to life.

Calm the June evening was, no
sign of strife
The clear sky showed, no storm grew
round the sun,
Unhappy that his day of bliss was
done;
Dumb was the sea, and if the beech-
wood stirred,
'Twas with the nestling of the grey-
winged bird
Midst its thick leaves; and though the
nightingale
Her ancient, hapless sorrow must
bewail,
No more of woe there seemed in her
song
Than such as doth to lovers' words
belong,
Because their love is still unsatisfied.
But to the King, on that sweet
eventide,
No earth there seemed, no heaven
when earth was gone;
No help, no God! but lonely pain
alone;
And he, midst unreal shadows,
seemed to sit
Himself the very heart and soul of it.
But round the cradle of the new-born
child
The nurses now the weary time
beguiled
With stories of the just departed
Queen;

And how, amid the heathen folk first
seen,
She had been won to love and
godliness;
And as they spoke, e'en midst his dull
distress,
An eager whisper now and then
would smite
Upon the King's ear, of some past
delight,
Some once familiar name, and he
would raise
His weary head, and on the speaker
gaze
Like one about to speak, but soon
again
Would drop his head and be alone
with pain,
Nor think of these; who, silent in
their turn,
Would sit and watch the waxen tapers
burn
Amidst the dusk of the quick-
gathering night,
Until beneath the high stars'
glimmering light,
The fresh earth lay in colourless
repose.
So passed the night, and now
and then one rose
From out her place to do what might
avail
To still the new-born infant's fretful
wail;
Or through the softly-opened door
there came

Some nurse new waked, who,
 whispering low the name
Of her whose turn was come, would
 take her place;
Then toward the King would turn
 about her face
And to her fellows whisper of the
 day,
And tell again of her just past away.

 So passed the night, the moon
 arose and grew,
From off the sea a little west-wind
 blew,
Rustling the garden-leaves like
 sudden rain;
And ere the moon had 'gun to fall
 again
The wind grew cold, a change was in
 the sky,
And in deep silence did the dawn
 draw nigh;
Then from her place a nurse arose to
 light
Fresh hallowed lights, for, dying with
 the night,
The tapers round about the dead
 Queen were;
But the King raised his head and 'gan
 to stare
Upon her, as her sweeping gown did
 glide
About the floor, that in the stillness
 cried
Beneath her careful feet; and now as
 she
Had lit the second candle carefully,

And on its silver spike another one
Was setting, through her body did
there run
A sudden tremor, and the hand was
stayed
That on the dainty painted wax was
laid;
Her eyelids fell down and she seemed
to sleep,
And o'er the staring King began to
creep
Sweet slumber too; the bitter lines of
woe
That drew his weary face did softer
grow,
His eyelids dropped, his arms fell to
his side;
And moveless in their places did
abide
The nursing women, held by some
strong spell,
E'en as they were, and utter silence
fell
Upon the mournful, glimmering
chamber fair.
But now light footsteps coming
up the stair,
Smote on the deadly stillness, and the
sound
Of silken dresses trailing o'er the
ground;
And heavenly odours through the
chamber passed,
Unlike the scents that rose and lily
cast
Upon the freshness of the dying
night;

Then nigher drew the sound of
 footsteps light
Until the door swung open
 noiselessly—
A mass of sunlit flowers there seemed
 to be
Within the doorway, and but pale and
 wan
The flame showed now that serveth
 mortal man,
As one by one six seeming ladies
 passed
Into the room, and o'er its sorrow cast
That thoughtless sense of joy
 bewildering,
That kisses youthful hearts amidst of
 spring;
Crowned were they, in such glorious
 raiment clad,
As yet no merchant of the world has
 had
Within his coffers; yet those crowns
 seemed fair
Only because they kissed their
 odorous hair,
And all that flowery raiment was but
 blessed
By those fair bodies that its splendour
 pressed.
 Now to the cradle from that
 glorious band,
A woman passed, and laid a tender
 hand
Upon the babe, and gently drew aside
The swathings soft that did his body
 hide;

And, seeing him so fair and great, she
smiled,
And stooped, and kissed him, saying,
"O noble child,
Have thou a gift from Gloriande this
day;
For to the time when life shall pass
away
From this dear heart, no fear of death
or shame,
No weariness of good shall foul thy
name."

So saying, to her sisters she
returned;
And one came forth, upon whose
brow there burned
A crown of rubies, and whose
heaving breast
With happy rings a golden hauberk
pressed;
She took the babe, and somewhat
frowning said,
"This gift I give, that till thy limbs are
laid
At rest for ever, to thine honoured life
There never shall be lacking war and
strife,
That thou a long-enduring name
mayst win,
And by thy deeds, good pardon for
thy sin."

With that another, who, unseen,
meanwhile
Had drawn anigh, said with a joyous
smile,
"And this forgotten gift to thee I give,

That while amidst the turmoil thou
dost live,
Still shalt thou win the game, and
unto thee
Defeat and shame but idle words
shall be."

Then back they turned, and
therewithal, the fourth
Said, "Take this gift for what it may
be worth
For that is mine to give; lo, thou shalt
be
Gentle of speech, and in all courtesy
The first of men: a little gift this is,
After these promises of fame and
bliss."

Then toward the babe the fifth
fair woman went;
Grey-eyed she was, and simple, with
eyes bent
Down on the floor, parted her red lips
were,
And o'er her sweet face marvellously
fair
Oft would the colour spread full
suddenly;
Clad in a dainty gown and thin was
she,
For some green summer of the fay-
land dight,
Tripping she went, and laid her
fingers light
Upon the child, and said, "O little
one,
As long as thou shalt look upon the
sun

Shall women long for thee; take heed
to this
And give them what thou canst of
love and bliss."
Then, blushing for her words,
therefrom she past,
And by the cradle stood the sixth and
last,
The fairest of them all; awhile she
gazed
Down on the child, and then her hand
she raised,
And made the one side of her bosom
bare;
"Ogier," she said, "if this be foul or
fair
Thou know'st not now, but when
thine earthly life
Is drunk out to the dregs, and war and
strife
Have yielded thee whatever joy they
may,
Thine head upon this bosom shalt
thou lay;
And then, despite of knowledge or of
God,
Will we be glad upon the flowery sod
Within the happy country where I
dwell:
Ogier, my love that is to be,
farewell!"

She turned, and even as they
came they passed
From out the place, and reached the
gate at last

That oped before their feet, and
 speedily
They gained the edges of the
 murmuring sea,
And as they stood in silence, gazing
 there
Out to the west, they vanished into
 air,
I know not how, nor whereto they
 returned.

 But mixed with twilight in the
 chamber burned
The flickering candles, and those
 dreary folk,
Unlike to sleepers, from their trance
 awoke,
But nought of what had happed
 meanwhile they knew.
Through the half-opened casements
 now there blew
A sweet fresh air, that of the flowers
 and sea
Mingled together, smelt deliciously,
And from the unseen sun the
 spreading light
Began to make the fair June blossoms
 bright,
And midst their weary woe uprose
 the sun,
And thus has Ogier's noble life
 begun.

Hope is our life, when first our life
grows clear;
Hope and delight, scarce crossed by
lines of fear,
Yet the day comes when fain we
would not hope,
But forasmuch as we with life must
cope,
Struggling with this and that, and
who knows why?
Hope will not give us up to certainty,
But still must bide with us: and with
this man,
Whose life amid such promises began
Great things she wrought; but now
the time has come
When he no more on earth may have
his home.
Great things he suffered, great
delights he had,
Unto great kings he gave good deeds
for bad;
He ruled o'er kingdoms where his
name no more
Is had in memory, and on many a
shore
He left his sweat and blood to win a
name
Passing the bounds of earthly
creatures' fame.
A love he won and lost, a well-loved
son
Whose little day of promise soon was
done:
A tender wife he had, that he must
leave

Before his heart her love could well
 receive;
Those promised gifts, that on his
 careless head
In those first hours of his fair life
 were shed
He took unwitting, and unwitting
 spent,
Nor gave himself to grief and
 discontent
Because he saw the end a-drawing
 nigh.
 Where is he now? in what land
 must he die,
To leave an empty name to us on
 earth?
A tale half true, to cast across our
 mirth
Some pensive thoughts of life that
 might have been;
Where is he now, that all this life has
 seen?

Behold, another eve I bid you
 see
Than that calm eve of his nativity;
The sun is setting in the west, the sky
Is clear and hard, and no clouds come
 anigh
The golden orb, but further off they
 lie,
Steel-grey and black with edges red
 as blood,
And underneath them is the weltering
 flood
Of some huge sea, whose tumbling
 hills, as they

Turn restless sides about, are black or
grey,
Or green, or glittering with the golden
flame;
The wind has fallen now, but still the
same
The mighty army moves, as if to
drown
This lone, bare rock, whose shear
scarped sides of brown
Cast off the weight of waves in
clouds of spray.
Alas! what ships upon an evil
day
Bent over to the wind in this ill sea?
What navy, whose rent bones lie
wretchedly
Beneath these cliffs? a mighty one it
was,
A fearful storm to bring such things
to pass.

This is the loadstone rock; no
armament
Of warring nations, in their madness
bent
Their course this way; no merchant
wittingly
Has steered his keel unto this luckless
sea;
Upon no shipman's card its name is
writ,
Though worn-out mariners will speak
of it
Within the ingle on the winter's night,
When all within is warm and safe and
bright,

And the wind howls without: but
 'gainst their will
Are some folk driven here, and then
 all skill
Against this evil rock is vain and
 nought,
And unto death the shipmen soon are
 brought;
For then the keel, as by a giant's
 hand,
Is drawn unto that mockery of a land,
And presently unto its sides doth
 cleave;
When if they 'scape swift death, yet
 none may leave
The narrow limits of that barren isle,
And thus are slain by famine in a
 while
Mocked, as they say, by night with
 images
Of noble castles among groves of
 trees,
By day with sounds of merry
 minstrelsy.

 The sun sinks now below this
 hopeless sea,
The clouds are gone, and all the sky
 is bright;
The moon is rising o'er the growing
 night,
And by its light may ye behold the
 bones
Of generations of these luckless ones
Scattered about the rock; but nigh the
 sea
Sits one alive, who uncomplainingly

Awaits his death. White-haired is he
and old,
Arrayed in royal raiment, bright with
gold,
But tarnished with the waves and
rough salt air;
Huge is he, of a noble face and fair,
As for an ancient man, though toil
and eld
Furrow the cheeks that ladies once
beheld
With melting hearts—Nay, listen, for
he speaks!
"God, thou hast made me strong!
nigh seven weeks
Have passed since from the wreck we
haled our store,
And five long days well told, have
now passed o'er
Since my last fellow died, with my
last bread
Between his teeth, and yet I am not
dead.
Yea, but for this I had been strong
enow
In some last bloody field my sword to
show.
What matter? soon will all be past
and done,
Where'er I died I must have died
alone:
Yet, Caraheu, a good death had it
been
Dying, thy face above me to have
seen,
And heard my banner flapping in the
wind,

Then, though my memory had not left
thy mind,
Yet hope and fear would not have
vexed thee more
When thou hadst known that
everything was o'er;
But now thou waitest, still expecting
me,
Whose sail shall never speck thy
bright blue sea.

"And thou, Clarice, the
merchants thou mayst
call,
To tell thee tales within thy pictured
hall,
But never shall they tell true tales of
me:
Whatever sails the Kentish hills may
see
Swept by the flood-tide toward thy
well-walled town,
No more on my sails shall they look
adown.

"Get thee another leader,
Charlemaine,
For thou shalt look to see my shield
in vain,
When in the fair fields of the
Frankish land,
Thick as the corn they tread, the
heathen stand.

"What matter? ye shall learn to
live your lives;
Husbands and children, other friends
and wives,
Shall wipe the tablets of your
memory clean,

And all shall be as I had never been.

"And now, O God, am I alone
with Thee;
A little thing indeed it seems to be
To give this life up, since it needs
must go
Some time or other; now at last I
know
How foolishly men play upon the
earth,
When unto them a year of life seems
worth
Honour and friends, and these vague
hopes and sweet
That like real things my dying heart
do greet,
Unreal while living on the earth I
trod,
And but myself I knew no other god.
Behold, I thank Thee that Thou
sweet'nest thus
This end, that I had thought most
piteous,
If of another I had heard it told."

What man is this, who weak and
worn and old,
Gives up his life within that dreadful
isle,
And on the fearful coming death can
smile?
Alas! this man, so battered and
outworn,
Is none but he, who, on that summer
morn,

Received such promises of glorious
life:
Ogier the Dane this is, to whom all
strife
Was but as wine to stir awhile the
blood,
To whom all life, however hard, was
good:
This is the man, unmatched of heart
and limb,
Ogier the Dane, whose sight has
waxed not dim
For all the years that he on earth has
dwelt;
Ogier the Dane, that never fear has
felt,
Since he knew good from ill; Ogier
the Dane,
The heathen's dread, the evil-doer's
bane.

BRIGHT had the moon grown as his
words were done,
And no more was there memory of
the sun
Within the west, and he grew drowsy
now,
And somewhat smoother was his
wrinkled brow
As thought died out beneath the hand
of sleep,
And o'er his soul forgetfulness did
creep,

Hiding the image of swift-coming
 death;
Until as peacefully he drew his breath
As on that day, past for a hundred
 years,
When, midst the nurse's quickly-
 falling tears,
He fell asleep to his first lullaby.
 The night changed as he slept,
 white clouds and high
Began about the lonely moon to
 close;
And from the dark west a new wind
 arose,
And with the sound of heavy-falling
 waves
Mingled its pipe about the loadstone
 caves;
But when the twinkling stars were hid
 away,
And a faint light and broad, like dawn
 of day,
The moon upon that dreary country
 shed,
Ogier awoke, and lifting up his head
And smiling, muttered, "Nay, no
 more again;
Rather some pleasure new, some
 other pain,
Unthought of both, some other form
 of strife;"
For he had waked from dreams of his
 old life,
And through St. Omer's archer-
 guarded gate
Once more had seemed to pass, and
 saw the state

Of that triumphant king; and still,
 though all
Seemed changed, and folk by other
 names did call
Faces he knew of old, yet none the
 less
He seemed the same, and, midst that
 mightiness,
Felt his own power, and grew the
 more athirst
For coming glory, as of old, when
 first
He stood before the face of
 Charlemaine,
A helpless hostage with all life to
 gain.

 But now, awake, his worn face
 once more sank
Between his hands, and, murmuring
 not, he drank
The draught of death that must that
 thirst allay.

 But while he sat and waited for
 the day
A sudden light across the bare rock
 streamed,
Which at the first he noted not, but
 deemed
The moon her fleecy veil had broken
 through;
But ruddier indeed this new light
 grew
Than were the moon's grey beams,
 and, therewithal,
Soft far-off music on his ears did fall;

Yet moved he not, but murmured,
 "This is death,
An easy thing like this to yield my
 breath,
Awake, yet dreaming, with no sounds
 of fear,
No dreadful sights to tell me it is
 near;
Yea, God, I thank Thee!" but with
 that last word
It seemed to him that he his own
 name heard
Whispered, as though the wind had
 borne it past;
With that he gat unto his feet at last,
But still awhile he stood, with sunken
 head,
And in a low and trembling voice he
 said,
"Lord, I am ready, whither shall I go?
I pray Thee unto me some token
 show."
And, as he said this, round about he
 turned,
And in the east beheld a light that
 burned
As bright as day; then, though his
 flesh might fear
The coming change that he believed
 so near,
Yet did his soul rejoice, for now he
 thought
Unto the very heaven to be brought:
And though he felt alive, deemed it
 might be
That he in sleep had died full easily.

Then toward that light did he
begin to go,
And still those strains he heard, far
off and low,
That grew no louder; still that bright
light streamed
Over the rocks, yet nothing brighter
seemed,
But like the light of some unseen
bright flame
Shone round about, until at last he
came
Unto the dreary islet's other shore,
And then the minstrelsy he heard no
more,
And softer seemed the strange light
unto him;
But yet or ever it had grown quite
dim,
Beneath its waning light could he
behold
A mighty palace set about with gold,
Above green meads and groves of
summer trees
Far-off across the welter of the seas;
But, as he gazed, it faded from his
sight,
And the grey hidden moon's diffused
soft light,
Which soothly was but darkness to
him now,
His sea-girt island prison did but
show.
But o'er the sea he still gazed
wistfully,
And said, "Alas! and when will this
go by

And leave my soul in peace? must I
still dream
Of life that once so dear a thing did
seem,
That, when I wake, death may the
bitterer be?
Here will I sit until he come to me,
And hide mine eyes and think upon
my sin,
That so a little calm I yet may win
Before I stand within the awful
place."
Then down he sat and covered
up his face,
Yet therewithal his trouble could not
hide,
Nor waiting thus for death could he
abide,
For, though he knew it not, the
yearning pain
Of hope of life had touched his soul
again—
If he could live awhile, if he could
live!
The mighty being, who once was
wont to give
The gift of life to many a trembling
man;
Who did his own will since his life
began;
Who feared not aught, but strong and
great and free
Still cast aside the thought of what
might be;
Must all this then be lost, and with no
will,

Powerless and blind, must he some
fate fulfil,
Nor know what he is doing any
more?

Soon he arose and paced along
the shore,
And gazed out seaward for the
blessed light;
But nought he saw except the old sad
sight,
The ceaseless tumbling of the billows
grey,
The white upspringing of the spurts
of spray
Amidst that mass of timbers, the rent
bones
Of the sea-houses of the hapless ones
Once cast like him upon this deadly
isle.

He stopped his pacing in a little
while,
And clenched his mighty hands, and
set his teeth,
And gazing at the ruin underneath,
He swung from off the bare cliff's
jagged brow,
And on some slippery ledge he
wavered now,
Without a hand-hold, and now stoutly
clung
With hands alone, and o'er the welter
hung,
Not caring aught if thus his life
should end;
But safely midst all this did he
descend

The dreadful cliff, and since no beach
was there,
But from the depths the rock rose
stark and bare,
Nor crumbled aught beneath the
hammering sea,
Upon the wrecks he stood unsteadily.

But now, amid the clamour of
the waves,
And washing to-and-fro of beams and
staves,
Dizzy with hunger, dreamy with
distress,
And all those days of fear and
loneliness,
The ocean's tumult seemed the
battle's roar,
His heart grew hot, as when in days
of yore
He heard the cymbals clash amid the
crowd
Of dusky faces; now he shouted loud,
And from crushed beam to beam
began to leap,
And yet his footing somehow did he
keep
Amidst their tossing, and indeed the
sea
Was somewhat sunk upon the island's
lee.
So quickly on from wreck to wreck
he passed,
And reached the outer line of wrecks
at last,
And there a moment stood unsteadily,

Amid the drift of spray that hurried
by,
And drew Courtain his sword from
out its sheath,
And poised himself to meet the
coming death,
Still looking out to sea; but as he
gazed,
And once or twice his doubtful feet
he raised
To take the final plunge, that
heavenly strain
Over the washing waves he heard
again,
And from the dimness something
bright he saw
Across the waste of waters towards
him draw;
And hidden now, now raised aloft, at
last
Unto his very feet a boat was cast,
Gilded inside and out, and well
arrayed
With cushions soft; far fitter to have
weighed
From some sweet garden on the
shallow Seine,
Or in a reach of green Thames to
have lain,
Than struggle with that huge
confused sea;
But Ogier gazed upon it doubtfully
One moment, and then, sheathing
Courtain, said,
"What tales are these about the newly
dead

The heathen told? what matter, let all
pass;
This moment as one dead indeed I
was,
And this must be what I have got to
do,
I yet perchance may light on
something new
Before I die; though yet perchance
this keel
Unto the wondrous mass of charmed
steel
Is drawn as others." With that word
he leapt
Into the boat, and o'er the cushions
crept
From stem to stern, but found no
rudder there,
Nor any oars, nor were the cushions
fair
Made wet by any dashing of the sea.
Now while he pondered how
these things could be,
The boat began to move therefrom at
last,
But over him a drowsiness was cast,
And as o'er tumbling hills the skiff
did pass,
He clean forgot his death and where
he was.

At last he woke up to a sunny
day,
And, looking round, saw that his
shallop lay
Moored at the edge of some fair
tideless sea

Unto an overhanging thick-leaved
tree,
Where in the green waves did the low
bank dip
Its fresh and green grass-covered
daisied lip;
But Ogier looking thence no more
could see
That sad abode of death and misery,
Nor aught but wide and empty ocean,
grey
With gathering haze, for now it
neared midday;
Then from the golden cushions did he
rise,
And wondering still if this were
Paradise
He stepped ashore, but drew Courtain
his sword
And muttered therewithal a holy
word.

Fair was the place, as though
amidst of May,
Nor did the brown birds fear the
sunny day,
For with their quivering song the air
was sweet;
Thick grew the field-flowers
underneath his feet,
And on his head the blossoms down
did rain,
Yet mid these fair things slowly and
with pain
He 'gan to go, yea, even when his
foot
First touched the flowery sod, to his
heart's root

A coldness seemed to strike, and now
each limb
Was growing stiff, his eyes waxed
bleared and dim,
And all his stored-up memory 'gan to
fail,
Nor yet would his once mighty heart
avail
For lamentations o'er his changed lot;
Yet urged by some desire, he knew
not what,
Along a little path 'twixt hedges
sweet,
Drawn sword in hand, he dragged his
faltering feet,
For what then seemed to him a weary
way,
Whereon his steps he needs must
often stay
And lean upon the mighty well-worn
sword
That in those hands, grown old, for
king or lord
Had small respect in glorious days
long past.

But still he crept along, and at
the last
Came to a gilded wicket, and through
this
Entered a garden fit for utmost bliss,
If that might last which needs must
soon go by:
There 'gainst a tree he leaned, and
with a sigh
He said, "O God, a sinner I have
been,

And good it is that I these things have
seen
Before I meet what Thou hast set
apart
To cleanse the earthly folly from my
heart;
But who within this garden now can
dwell
Wherein guilt first upon the world
befell?"
A little further yet he staggered
on,
Till to a fountain-side at last he won,
O'er which two white-thorns their
sweet blossoms shed,
There he sank down, and laid his
weary head
Beside the mossy roots, and in a
while
He slept, and dreamed himself within
the isle;
That splashing fount the weary sea
did seem,
And in his dream the fair place but a
dream;
But when again to feebleness he
woke
Upon his ears that heavenly music
broke,
Not faint or far as in the isle it was,
But e'en as though the minstrels now
did pass
Anigh his resting-place; then fallen in
doubt,
E'en as he might, he rose and gazed
about,

Leaning against the hawthorn stem
with pain;
And yet his straining gaze was but in
vain,
Death stole so fast upon him, and no
more
Could he behold the blossoms as
before,
No more the trees seemed rooted to
the ground,
A heavy mist seemed gathering all
around,
And in its heart some bright thing
seemed to be,
And round his head there breathed
deliciously
Sweet odours, and that music never
ceased.
But as the weight of Death's strong
hand increased
Again he sank adown, and Courtain's
noise
Within the scabbard seemed a
farewell voice
Sent from the world he loved so well
of old,
And all his life was as a story told,
And as he thought thereof he 'gan to
smile
E'en as a child asleep, but in a while
It was as though he slept, and
sleeping dreamed,
For in his half-closed eyes a glory
gleamed,
As though from some sweet face and
golden hair,

And on his breast were laid soft
 hands and fair,
And a sweet voice was ringing in his
 ears,
Broken as if with flow of joyous
 tears;
 "Ogier, sweet friend, hast thou
 not tarried long?
Alas! thine hundred years of strife
 and wrong!"
Then he found voice to say, "Alas!
 dear Lord,
Too long, too long; and yet one little
 word
Right many a year ago had brought
 me here."
Then to his face that face was drawn
 anear,
He felt his head raised up and gently
 laid
On some kind knee, again the sweet
 voice said,
"Nay, Ogier, nay, not yet, not yet,
 dear friend!
Who knoweth when our linked life
 shall end,
Since thou art come unto mine arms
 at last,
And all the turmoil of the world is
 past?
Why do I linger ere I see thy face
As I desired it in that mourning place
So many years ago—so many years,
Thou knewest not thy love and all her
 fears?"
 "Alas!" he said, "what mockery
 is this

That thou wilt speak to me of earthly
bliss?

No longer can I think upon the earth,
Have I not done with all its grief and
mirth?

Yes, I was Ogier once, but if my love
Should come once more my dying
heart to move,

Then must she come from 'neath the
milk-white walls

Whereon to-day the hawthorn
blossom falls

Outside St. Omer's—art thou she? her
name

I could remember once mid death and
fame

Is clean forgotten now; but yesterday,
Meseems, our son, upon her bosom
lay:

Baldwin the fair—what hast thou
done with him

Since Charlot slew him? Ah, mine
eyes wax dim;

Woman, forbear! wilt thou not let me
die?

Did I forget thee in the days gone by?
Then let me die, that we may meet
again!"

He tried to move from her, but
all in vain,

For life had well-nigh left him, but
withal

He felt a kiss upon his forehead fall,
And could not speak; he felt slim
fingers fair

Move to his mighty sword-worn
hand, and there
Set on some ring, and still he could
not speak,
And once more sleep weighed down
his eyelids weak.

But, ah! what land was this he woke
unto?
What joy was this that filled his heart
anew?
Had he then gained the very
Paradise?
Trembling, he durst not at the first
arise,
Although no more he felt the pain of
eld,
Nor durst he raise his eyes that now
beheld
Beside him the white flowers and
blades of grass;
He durst not speak, lest he some
monster was.
But while he lay and hoped, that
gentle voice
Once more he heard; "Yea, thou
mayst well rejoice!
Thou livest still, my sweet, thou
livest still,
Apart from every earthly fear and ill;
Wilt thou not love me, who have
wrought thee this,
That I like thee may live in double
bliss?"

Then Ogier rose up, nowise like
to one
Whose span of earthly life is nigh
outrun,
But as he might have risen in old
days
To see the spears cleave the fresh
morning haze;
But, looking round, he saw no change
there was
In the fair place wherethrough he first
did pass,
Though all, grown clear and joyous to
his eyes,
Now looked no worse than very
Paradise;
Behind him were the thorns, the
fountain fair
Still sent its glittering stream forth
into air,
And by its basin a fair woman stood,
And as their eyes met his renewed
blood
Rushed to his face; with unused
thoughts and sweet
And hurrying hopes, his heart began
to beat.
The fairest of all creatures did
she seem;
So fresh and delicate you well might
deem
That scarce for eighteen summers had
she blessed
The happy, longing world; yet, for the
rest,
Within her glorious eyes such
wisdom dwelt

A child before her had the wise man
felt,
And with the pleasure of a thousand
years
Her lips were fashioned to move joy
or tears
Among the longing folk where she
might dwell,
To give at last the kiss unspeakable.
In such wise was she clad as folk
may be,
Who, for no shame of their humanity,
For no sad changes of the imperfect
year,
Rather for added beauty, raiment
wear;
For, as the heat-foretelling grey-blue
haze
Veils the green flowery morn of late
May-days,
Her raiment veiled her; where the
bands did meet
That bound the sandals to her dainty
feet,
Gems gleamed; a fresh rose-wreath
embraced her head,
And on her breast there lay a ruby
red.
So with a supplicating look she
turned
To meet the flame that in his own
eyes burned,
And held out both her white arms
lovingly,
As though to greet him as he drew
anigh.

Stammering he said, "Who art thou?
how am I
So cured of all my evils suddenly,
That certainly I felt no mightier,
when,
Amid the backward rush of beaten
men,
About me drooped the axe-torn
Oriflamme?
Alas! I fear that in some dream I am."
"Ogier," she said, "draw near,
perchance it is
That such a name God gives unto our
bliss;
I know not, but if thou art such an
one
As I must deem, all days beneath the
sun
That thou hast had, shall be but
dreams indeed
To those that I have given thee at thy
need.
For many years ago beside the sea
When thou wert born, I plighted troth
with thee:
Come near then, and make mirrors of
mine eyes,
That thou mayest see what these my
mysteries
Have wrought in thee; surely but
thirty years,
Passed amidst joy, thy new born body
bears,
Nor while thou art with me, and on
this shore
Art still full-fed of love, shalt thou
seem more.

Nay, love, come nigher, and let me
take thine hand,
The hope and fear of many a warring
land,
And I will show thee wherein lies the
spell,
Whereby this happy change upon
thee fell."

Like a shy youth before some
royal love,
Close up to that fair woman did he
move,
And their hands met; yet to his
changed voice
He dared not trust; nay, scarcely
could rejoice
E'en when her balmy breath he 'gan
to feel,
And felt strange sweetness o'er his
spirit steal
As her light raiment, driven by the
wind,
Swept round him, and, bewildered
and half-blind,
His lips the treasure of her lips did
press,
And round him clung her perfect
loveliness.

For one sweet moment thus they
stood, and then
She drew herself from out his arms
again,
And panting, lovelier for her love, did
stand
Apart awhile, then took her lover's
hand,

And, in a trembling voice, made haste
to say,—

"O Ogier, when thou earnest
here to-day,
I feared indeed, that in my sport with
fate,
I might have seen thee e'en one day
too late,
Before this ring thy finger should
embrace;
Behold it, love, and thy keen eyes
may trace
Faint figures wrought upon the ruddy
gold;
My father dying gave it me, nor told
The manner of its making, but I know
That it can make thee e'en as thou art
now
Despite the laws of God—shrink not
from me
Because I give an impious gift to thee
—

Has not God made me also, who do
this?
But I, who longed to share with thee
my bliss,
Am of the fays, and live their
changeless life,
And, like the gods of old, I see the
strife
That moves the world, unmoved if so
I will;
For we the fruit, that teaches good
and ill,
Have never touched like you of
Adam's race;

And while thou dwellest with me in
this place
Thus shalt thou be—ah, and thou
deem'st, indeed,
That thou shalt gain thereby no happy
meed
Reft of the world's joys? nor canst
understand
How thou art come into a happy
land?—
Love, in thy world the priests of
heaven still sing,
And tell thee of it many a joyous
thing;
But think'st thou, bearing the world's
joy and pain,
Thou couldst live there? nay, nay, but
born again
Thus wouldst be happy with the
angels' bliss;
And so with us no otherwise it is,
Nor hast thou cast thine old life quite
away
Even as yet, though that shall be to-
day.
"But for the love and country
thou hast won,
Know thou, that thou art come to
Avallon,
That is both thine and mine; and as
for me,
Morgan le Fay men call me
commonly
Within the world, but fairer names
than this
I have for thee and me, 'twixt kiss and
kiss."

Ah, what was this? and was it all
in vain,
That she had brought him here this
life to gain?
For, ere her speech was done, like one
turned blind
He watched the kisses of the
wandering wind
Within her raiment, or as some one
sees
The very best of well-wrought images
When he is blind with grief, did he
behold
The wandering tresses of her locks of
gold
Upon her shoulders; and no more he
pressed
The hand that in his own hand lay at
rest:
His eyes, grown dull with changing
memories,
Could make no answer to her
glorious eyes:
Cold waxed his heart, and weary and
distraught,
With many a cast-by, hateful, dreary
thought,
Unfinished in the old days; and
withal
He needs must think of what might
chance to fall
In this life new-begun; and good and
bad
Tormented him, because as yet he had
A worldly heart within his frame
made new,

And to the deeds that he was wont to
do
Did his desires still turn. But she a
while
Stood gazing at him with a doubtful
smile,
And let his hand fall down; but
suddenly
Sounded sweet music from some
close nearby,
And then she spoke again: "Come,
love, with me,
That thou thy new life and delights
mayst see."
And gently with that word she led
him thence,
And though upon him now there fell
a sense
Of dreamy and unreal bewilderment,
As hand in hand through that green
place they went,
Yet therewithal a strain of tender love
A little yet his restless heart did
move.

So through the whispering trees
they came at last
To where a wondrous house a shadow
cast
Across the flowers, and o'er the
daisied grass
Before it, crowds of lovely folk did
pass,
Playing about in carelessness and
mirth,
Unshadowed by the doubtful deeds of
earth;

And from the midst a band of fair
girls came,
With flowers and music, greeting him
by name,
And praising him; but ever like a
dream
He could not break, did all to Ogier
seem,
And he his old world did the more
desire,
For in his heart still burned
unquenched the fire,
That through the world of old so
bright did burn:
Yet was he fain that kindness to
return,
And from the depth of his full heart
he sighed.

Then toward the house the
lovely Queen did guide
His listless steps, and seemed to take
no thought
Of knitted brow or wandering eyes
distraught,
But still with kind love lighting up
her face
She led him through the door of that
fair place,
While round about them did the
damsels press;
And he was moved by all that
loveliness
As one might be, who, lying half
asleep
In the May morning, notes the light
wind sweep
Over the tulip-beds: no more to him

Were gleaming eyes, red lips, and
bodies slim,
Amidst that dream, although the first
surprise
Of hurried love wherewith the
Queen's sweet eyes
Had smitten him, still in his heart did
stir.

And so at last he came, led on by
her
Into a hall wherein a fair throne was,
And hand in hand thereto the twain
did pass;
And there she bade him sit, and when
alone
He took his place upon the double
throne,
She cast herself before him on her
knees,
Embracing his, and greatly did
increase
The shame and love that vexed his
troubled heart:
But now a line of girls the crowd did
part,
Lovelier than all, and Ogier could
behold
One in their midst who bore a crown
of gold
Within her slender hands and
delicate;
She, drawing nigh, beside the throne
did wait
Until the Queen arose and took the
crown,

Who then to Ogier's lips did stoop
adown
And kissed him, and said, "Ogier,
what were worth
Thy miserable days of strife on earth,
That on their ashes still thine eyes are
turned?"
Then, as she spoke these words,
his changed heart burned
With sudden memories, and thereto
had he
Made answer, but she raised up
suddenly
The crown she held and set it on his
head,
"Ogier," she cried, "those troublous
days are dead;
Thou wert dead with them also, but
for me;
Turn unto her who wrought these
things for thee!"
Then, as he felt her touch, a
mighty wave
Of love swept o'er his soul, as though
the grave
Did really hold his body; from his
seat
He rose to cast himself before her
feet;
But she clung round him, and in close
embrace
The twain were locked amidst that
thronging place.

Thenceforth new life indeed has
Ogier won,
And in the happy land of Avallon

Quick glide the years o'er his
 unchanging head;
There saw he many men the world
 thought dead,
Living like him in sweet forgetfulness
Of all the troubles that did once
 oppress
Their vainly-struggling lives—ah,
 how can I
Tell of their joy as though I had been
 nigh?
Suffice it that no fear of death they
 knew,
That there no talk there was of false
 or true,
Of right or wrong, for traitors came
 not there;
That everything was bright and soft
 and fair,
And yet they wearied not for any
 change,
Nor unto them did constancy seem
 strange.
Love knew they, but its pain they
 never had,
But with each other's joy were they
 made glad;
Nor were their lives wasted by hidden
 fire,
Nor knew they of the unfulfilled
 desire
That turns to ashes all the joys of
 earth,
Nor knew they yearning love amidst
 the dearth
Of kind and loving hearts to spend it
 on,

Nor dreamed or discontent when all
 was won;
Nor need they struggle after wealth
 and fame;
Still was the calm flow of their lives
 the same,
And yet, I say, they wearied not of it
 —
So did the promised days by Ogier
 flit.

 THINK that a hundred years have
 now passed by,
Since ye beheld Ogier lie down to die
Beside the fountain; think that now
 ye are
In France, made dangerous with
 wasting war;
In Paris, where about each guarded
 gate,
Gathered in knots, the anxious people
 wait,
And press around each new-come
 man to learn
If Harfleur now the pagan wasters
 burn,
Or if the Rouen folk can keep their
 chain,
Or Pont de l'Arche unburnt still
 guards the Seine?
Or if 'tis true that Andelys succour
 wants?
That Vernon's folk are fleeing east to
 Mantes?
When will they come? or rather is it
 true

That a great band the Constable
o'erthrew
Upon the marshes of the lower Seine,
And that their long ships, turning
back again,
Caught by the high-raised waters of
the bore
Were driven here and there and cast
ashore?
Such questions did they ask,
and, as fresh men
Came hurrying in, they asked them
o'er again,
And from scared folk, or fools, or
ignorant,
Still got new lies, or tidings very
scant.

But now amidst these men at last
came one,
A little ere the setting of the sun,
With two stout men behind him,
armed right well,
Who ever as they rode on, sooth to
tell,
With doubtful eyes upon their master
stared,
Or looked about like troubled men
and scared.
And he they served was noteworthy
indeed;
Of ancient fashion were his arms and
weed,
Rich past the wont of men in those
sad times;
His face was bronzed, as though by
burning climes,

But lovely as the image of a god
Carved in the days before on earth
Christ trod;
But solemn were his eyes, and grey
as glass,
And like to ruddy gold his fine hair
was:
A mighty man he was, and taller far
Than those who on that day must bear
the war
The pagans waged: he by the warders
stayed
Scarce looked on them, but straight
their words obeyed
And showed his pass; then, asked
about his name
And from what city of the world he
came,
Said, that men called him now the
Ancient Knight,
That he was come midst the king's
men to fight
From St. Omer's; and as he spoke, he
gazed
Down on the thronging street as one
amazed,
And answered no more to the
questioning
Of frightened folk of this or that sad
thing;
But, ere he passed on, turned about at
last
And on the wondering guard a
strange look cast,
And said, "St. Mary! do such men as
ye

Fight with the wasters from across
the sea?

Then, certes, are ye lost, however
good

Your hearts may be; not such were
those who stood

Beside the Hammer-bearer years
agone."

So said he, and as his fair
armour shone

With beauty of a time long passed
away,

So with the music of another day

His deep voice thrilled the awe-
struck, listening folk.

Yet from the crowd a mocking
voice outbroke,

That cried, "Be merry, masters, fear
ye nought,

Surely good succour to our side is
brought;

For here is Charlemaine come off his
tomb

To save his faithful city from its
doom."

"Yea," said another, "this is
certain news,

Surely ye know how all the carvers
use

To carve the dead man's image at the
best,

That guards the place where he may
lie at rest;

Wherefore this living image looks
indeed,

Spite of his ancient tongue and
marvellous weed,
To have but thirty summers."
At the name
Of Charlemaine, he turned to whence
there came
The mocking voice, and somewhat
knit his brow,
And seemed as he would speak, but
scarce knew how;
So with a half-sigh soon sank back
again
Into his dream, and shook his well-
wrought rein,
And silently went on upon his way.

And this was Ogier: on what evil
day
Has he then stumbled, that he needs
must come,
Midst war and ravage, to the ancient
home
Of his desires? did he grow weary
then,
And wish to strive once more with
foolish men
For worthless things? or is fair
Avallon
Sunk in the sea, and all that glory
gone?
Nay, thus it happed—One day
she came to him
And said, "Ogier, thy name is waxen
dim
Upon the world that thou
rememberest not;

The heathen men are thick on many a
spot
Thine eyes have seen, and which I
love therefore;
And God will give His wonted help
no more.
Wilt thou, then, help? canst thou have
any mind
To give thy banner once more to the
wind?
Since greater glory thou shalt win for
this
Than erst thou gatheredst ere thou
cam'st to bliss:
For men are dwindled both in heart
and frame,
Nor holds the fair land any such a
name
As thine, when thou wert living midst
thy peers:
The world is worser for these
hundred years."
From his calm eyes there
gleamed a little fire,
And in his voice was something of
desire,
To see the land where he was used to
be,
As now he answered: "Nay, choose
thou for me,
Thou art the wisest; it is more than
well
Within this peaceful place with thee
to dwell:
Nor ill perchance in that old land to
die,
If, dying, I keep not the memory

Of this fair life of ours." "Nay, nay,"
said she,
"As to thy dying, that shall never be,
Whiles that thou keep'st my ring—
and now, behold,
I take from thee thy charmed crown
of gold,
And thou wilt be the Ogier that thou
wast
Ere on the loadstone rock thy ship
was cast:
Yet thou shalt have thy youthful body
still,
And I will guard thy life from every
ill."

So was it done, and Ogier,
armed right well,
Sleeping, was borne away by some
strong spell,
And set upon the Flemish coast; and
thence
Turned to St. Omer's, with a doubtful
sense
Of being in some wild dream, the
while he knew
That great delight forgotten was his
due,
That all which there might hap was of
small worth.

So on he went, and sometimes
unto mirth
Did his attire move the country-folk,
But oftener when strange speeches
from him broke
Concerning men and things for long
years dead,

He filled the listeners with great awe
and dread;
For in such wild times as these people
were
Are men soon moved to wonder and
to fear.

Now through the streets of Paris
did he ride,
And at a certain hostel did abide
Throughout that night, and ere he
went next day
He saw a book that on a table lay,
And opening it 'gan read in lazy
mood:
But long before it in that place he
stood,
Noting nought else; for it did
chronicle
The deeds of men of old he knew
right well,
When they were living in the flesh
with him:
Yea, his own deeds he saw, grown
strange and dim
Already, and true stories mixed with
lies,
Until, with many thronging memories
Of those old days, his heart was so
oppressed,
He 'gan to wish that he might lie at
rest,
Forgetting all things: for indeed by
this
Little remembrance had he of the
bliss

That wrapped his soul in peaceful
Avallon.

But his changed life he needs
must carry on;
For ye shall know the Queen was
gathering men
To send unto the good King, who as
then
In Rouen lay, beset by many a band
Of those who carried terror through
the land,
And still by messengers for help he
prayed:
Therefore a mighty muster was being
made,
Of weak and strong, and brave and
timorous,
Before the Queen anigh her royal
house.
So thither on this morn did Ogier
turn,
Some certain news about the war to
learn;
And when he came at last into the
square,
And saw the ancient palace great and
fair
Rise up before him as in other days,
And in the merry morn the bright
sun's rays
Glittering on gathering helms and
moving spears,
He 'gan to feel as in the long-past
years,
And his heart stirred within him. Now
the Queen

Came from within, right royally
 beseen,
And took her seat beneath a canopy,
With lords and captains of the war
 anigh;
And as she came a mighty shout
 arose,
And round about began the knights to
 close,
Their oath of fealty there to swear
 anew,
And learn what service they had got
 to do.
But so it was, that some their shouts
 must stay
To gaze at Ogier as he took his way
Through the thronged place; and
 quickly too he gat
Unto the place whereas the Lady sat,
For men gave place unto him, fearing
 him:
For not alone was he most huge of
 limb,
And dangerous, but something in his
 face,
As his calm eyes looked o'er the
 crowded place,
Struck men with awe; and in the
 ancient days,
When men might hope alive on gods
 to gaze,
They would have thought, "The gods
 yet love our town
And from the heavens have sent a
 great one down."
 Withal unto the throne he came
 so near,

That he the Queen's sweet measured
voice could hear;
And swiftly now within him wrought
the change
That first he felt amid those faces
strange;
And his heart burned to taste the
hurrying life
With such desires, such changing
sweetness rife.
And yet, indeed, how should he live
alone,
Who in the old past days such friends
had known?
Then he began to think of Caraheu,
Of Bellicent the fair, and once more
knew
The bitter pain of rent and ended
love.
But while with hope and vain regret
he strove,
He found none 'twixt him and the
Queen's high seat,
And, stepping forth, he knelt before
her feet
And took her hand to swear, as was
the way
Of doing fealty in that ancient day,
And raised his eyes to hers; as fair
was she
As any woman of the world might be
Full-limbed and tall, dark haired,
from her deep eyes,
The snare of fools, the ruin of the
wise,
Love looked unchecked; and now her
dainty hand,

The well-knit holder of the golden
wand,
Trembled in his, she cast her eyes
adown,
And her sweet brow was knitted to a
frown,
As he, the taker of such oaths of yore,
Now unto her all due obedience
swore,
Yet gave himself no name; and now
the Queen,
Awed by his voice as other folk had
been,
Yet felt a trembling hope within her
rise
Too sweet to think of, and with love's
surprise
Her cheek grew pale; she said, "Thy
style and name
Thou tellest not, nor what land of thy
fame
Is glad; for, certes, some land must be
glad,
That in its bounds her house thy
mother had."
"Lady," he said, "from what far
land I come
I well might tell thee, but another
home
Have I long dwelt in, and its name
have I
Forgotten now, forgotten utterly
Who were my fellows, and what
deeds they did;
Therefore, indeed, shall my first
name be hid

And my first country; call me on this
day
The Ancient Knight, and let me go
my way."
He rose withal, for she her fingers
fair
Had drawn aback, and on him 'gan to
stare
As one afeard; for something terrible
Was in his speech, and that she knew
right well,
Who 'gan to love him, and to fear that
she,
Shut out by some strange deadly
mystery,
Should never gain from him an equal
love;
Yet, as from her high seat he 'gan to
move,
She said, "O Ancient Knight, come
presently,
When we have done this muster, unto
me,
And thou shalt have thy charge and
due command
For freeing from our foes this
wretched land!"
Then Ogier made his reverence
and went,
And somewhat could perceive of her
intent;
For in his heart life grew, and love
with life
Grew, and therewith, 'twixt love and
fame, was strife.
But, as he slowly gat him from
the square,

Gazing at all the people gathered
there,
A squire of the Queen's behind him
came,
And breathless, called him by his
new-coined name,
And bade him turn because the
Queen now bade,
Since by the muster long she might
be stayed,
That to the palace he should bring
him straight,
Midst sport and play her coming back
to wait;
Then Ogier turned, nought loath, and
with him went,
And to a postern-gate his steps he
bent,
That Ogier knew right well in days of
old;
Worn was it now, and the bright hues
and gold
Upon the shields above, with lapse of
days,
Were faded much: but now did Ogier
gaze
Upon the garden where he walked of
yore,
Holding the hands that he should see
no more;
For all was changed except the palace
fair,
That Charlemaine's own eyes had
seen built there
Ere Ogier knew him; there the squire
did lead

The Ancient Knight, who still took
 little heed
Of all the things that by the way he
 said,
For all his thoughts were on the days
 long dead.
 There in the painted hall he sat
 again,
And 'neath the pictured eyes of
 Charlemaine
He ate and drank, and felt it like a
 dream;
And midst his growing longings yet
 might deem
That he from sleep should wake up
 presently
In some fair city on the Syrian sea,
Or on the brown rocks of the
 loadstone isle.
But fain to be alone, within a while
He gat him to the garden, and there
 passed
By wondering squires and damsels,
 till at last,
Far from the merry folk who needs
 must play,
If on the world were coming its last
 day,
He sat him down, and through his
 mind there ran
Faint thoughts of that day, when,
 outworn and wan,
He lay down by the fountain-side to
 die.
But when he strove to gain clear
 memory

Of what had happed since on the isle
 he lay
Waiting for death, a hopeless
 castaway,
Thought failing him, would rather
 bring again
His life among the peers of
 Charlemaine,
And vex his soul with hapless
 memories;
Until at last, worn out by thought of
 these,
And hopeless striving to find what
 was true,
And pondering on the deeds he had to
 do
Ere he returned, whereto he could not
 tell,
Sweet sleep upon his wearied spirit
 fell.
And on the afternoon of that fair day,
Forgetting all, beneath the trees he
 lay.

 Meanwhile the Queen, affairs of
 state being done,
Went through the gardens with one
 dame alone
Seeking for Ogier, whom at last she
 found
Laid sleeping on the daisy-sprinkled
 ground,
Dreaming, I know not what, of other
 days.
Then on him for a while the Queen
 did gaze,

Drawing sweet poison from the
lovely sight,
Then to her fellow turned, "The
ancient Knight—
What means he by this word of his?"
she said;
"He were well mated with some
lovely maid
Just pondering on the late-heard name
of love."
"Softly, my lady, he begins to
move,"
Her fellow said, a woman old and
grey;
"Look now, his arms are of another
day;
None know him or his deeds; thy
squire just said
He asked about the state of men long
dead;
I fear what he may be; look, seest
thou not
That ring that on one finger he has
got,
Where figures strange upon the gold
are wrought:
God grant that he from hell has not
been brought
For our confusion, in this doleful war,
Who surely in enough of trouble are
Without such help;" then the Queen
turned aside
Awhile, her drawn and troubled face
to hide,
For lurking dread this speech within
her stirred;

But yet she said, "Thou sayest a
foolish word,
This man is come against our
enemies
To fight for us." Then down upon her
knees
Fell the old woman by the sleeping
knight,
And from his hand she drew with
fingers light
The wondrous ring, and scarce again
could rise
Ere 'neath the trembling Queen's
bewildered eyes
The change began; his golden hair
turned white,
His smooth cheek wrinkled, and his
breathing light
Was turned to troublous struggling
for his breath,
And on his shrunk lips lay the hand
of death;
And, scarce less pale than he, the
trembling Queen
Stood thinking on the beauty she had
seen
And longed for but a little while ago,
Yet with her terror still her love did
grow,
And she began to weep as though she
saw
Her beauty e'en to such an ending
draw.
And 'neath her tears waking he oped
his eyes,
And strove to speak, but nought but
gasping sighs

His lips could utter; then he tried to
reach
His hand to them, as though he would
beseech
The gift of what was his: but all the
while
The crone gazed on them with an evil
smile,
Then holding toward the Queen that
wondrous ring,
She said, "Why weep'st thou? having
this fair thing,
Thou, losing nought the beauty that
thou hast,
May'st watch the vainly struggling
world go past,
Thyself unchanged." The Queen put
forth her hand
And took the ring, and there awhile
did stand
And strove to think of it, but still in
her
Such all-absorbing longings love did
stir,
So young she was, of death she could
not think,
Or what a cup eld gives to man to
drink;
Yet on her finger had she set the ring
When now the life that hitherto did
cling
To Ogier's heart seemed fading quite
away,
And scarcely breathing with shut eyes
he lay.
Then, kneeling down, she murmured
piteously,

"Ah, wilt thou love me if I give it
thee,
And thou grow'st young again? what
should I do
If with the eyes thou thus shalt gain
anew
Thou shouldst look scorn on me?"
But with that word
The hedge behind her, by the west
wind stirred,
Cast fear into her heart of some one
nigh,
And therewith on his finger hastily
She set the ring, then rose and stood
apart
A little way, and in her doubtful heart
With love and fear was mixed desire
of life.
But standing so, a look with
great scorn rife
The elder woman, turning, cast on
her,
Pointing to Ogier, who began to stir;
She looked, and all she erst saw now
did seem
To have been nothing but a hideous
dream,
As fair and young he rose from off
the ground
And cast a dazed and puzzled look
around,
Like one just waked from sleep in
some strange place;
But soon his grave eyes rested on her
face,
And turned yet graver seeing her so
pale,

And that her eyes were pregnant with
some tale
Of love and fear; she 'neath his eyes
the while
Forced her pale lips to semblance of a
smile,
And said, "O Ancient Knight, thou
sleepest then?
While through this poor land range
the heathen men,
Unmet of any but my King and Lord:
Nay, let us see the deeds of thine old
sword."
"Queen," said he, "bid me then
unto this work,
And certes I behind no wall would
lurk,
Nor send for succour, while a scanty
folk
Still followed after me to break the
yoke:
I pray thee grace for sleeping, and
were fain
That I might rather never sleep again
Than have such wretched dreams as I
e'en now
Have waked from."

Lovelier she
seemed to
grow
Unto him as he spoke; fresh colour
came
Into her face, as though for some
sweet shame,
While she with tearful eyes beheld
him so,

That somewhat even must his burnt
cheek glow,
His heart beat faster. But again she
said,
"Nay, will dreams burden such a
mighty head?
Then may I too have pardon for a
dream:
Last night in sleep I saw thee, who
didst seem
To be the King of France; and thou
and I
Were sitting at some great festivity
Within the many-peopled gold-hung
place."
The blush of shame was gone as
on his face
She gazed, and saw him read her
meaning clear
And knew that no cold words she had
to fear,
But rather that for softer speech he
yearned.
Therefore, with love alone her
smooth cheek burned;
Her parted lips were hungry for his
kiss,
She trembled at the near approaching
bliss;
Nathless, she checked her love a
little while,
Because she felt the old dame's
curious smile
Upon her, and she said, "O Ancient
Knight,
If I then read my last night's dream
aright,

Thou art come here our very help to
be,
Perchance to give my husband back
to me;
Come then, if thou this land art fain
to save,
And show the wisdom thou must
surely have
Unto my council; I will give thee then
What charge I may among my valiant
men;
And certes thou wilt do so well
herein,
That, ere long, something greater
shalt thou win:
Come, then, deliverer of my throne
and land,
And let me touch for once thy mighty
hand
With these weak fingers."

As she spoke, she
met
His eager hand, and all things did
forget
But for one moment, for too wise
were they
To cast the coming years of joy away;
Then with her other hand her gown
she raised
And led him thence, and o'er her
shoulder gazed
At her old follower with a doubtful
smile,
As though to say, "Be wise, I know
thy guile!"
But slowly she behind the lovers
walked,

Muttering, "So be it! thou shalt not be
balked
Of thy desire; be merry! I am wise,
Nor will I rob thee of thy Paradise
For any other than myself; and thou
May'st even happen to have had enow
Of this new love, before I get the
ring,
And I may work for thee no evil
thing."

Now ye shall know that the old
chronicle,
Wherein I read all this, doth duly tell
Of all the gallant deeds that Ogier
did,
There may ye read them; nor let me
be chid
If I therefore say little of these things,
Because the thought of Avallon still
clings
Unto my heart, and scarcely can I
bear
To think of that long, dragging
useless year,
Through which, with dulled and
glimmering memory,
Ogier was grown content to live and
die
Like other men; but this I have to say,
That in the council chamber on that
day
The Old Knight showed his wisdom
well enow,
While fainter still with love the
Queen did grow

Hearing his words, beholding his
 grey eyes
Flashing with fire of warlike
 memories;
Yea, at the last he seemed so wise
 indeed
That she could give him now the
 charge, to lead
One wing of the great army that set
 out
From Paris' gates, midst many a
 wavering shout
Midst trembling prayers, and
 unchecked wails and tears,
And slender hopes and unresisted
 fears.

Now ere he went, upon his bed
 he lay,
Newly awakened at the dawn of day,
Gathering perplexed thoughts of
 many a thing,
When, midst the carol that the birds
 did sing
Unto the coming of the hopeful sun,
He heard a sudden lovesome song
 begun
'Twixt two young voices in the
 garden green,
That seemed indeed the farewell of
 the Queen.

SONG.

HÆC.

*In the white-flowered hawthorn
brake,
Love, be merry for my sake;
Twine the blossoms in my hair,
Kiss me where I am most fair—
Kiss me, love! for who knoweth
What thing cometh after death?*

ILLE.

*Nay, the garlanded gold hair
Hides thee where thou art most fair;
Hides the rose-tinged hills of snow—
Ah, sweet love, I have thee now!
Kiss me, love! for who knoweth
What thing cometh after death?*

HÆC.

*Shall we weep for a dead day,
Or set Sorrow in our way?
Hidden by my golden hair,
Wilt thou weep that sweet days wear?
Kiss me, love! for who knoweth
What thing cometh after death?*

ILLE.

*Weep, O Love, the days that flit,
Now, while I can feel thy breath;*

*Then may I remember it
Sad and old, and near my death.
Kiss me, love! for who knoweth
What thing cometh after death?*

Soothed by the pleasure that the
music brought
And sweet desire, and vague and
dreamy thought
Of happiness it seemed to promise
him,
He lay and listened till his eyes grew
dim,
And o'er him 'gan forgetfulness to
creep
Till in the growing light he lay asleep,
Nor woke until the clanging trumpet-
blast
Had summoned him all thought away
to cast:
Yet one more joy of love indeed he
had
Ere with the battle's noise he was
made glad;
For, as on that May morning forth
they rode
And passed before the Queen's most
fair abode,
There at a window was she waiting
them
In fair attire with gold in every hem,
And as the ancient Knight beneath
her passed
A wreath of flowering white-thorn
down she cast,
And looked farewell to him, and forth
he set

Thinking of all the pleasure he should
get
From love and war, forgetting
Avallon
And all that lovely life so lightly
won;
Yea, now indeed the earthly life
o'erpast
Ere on the loadstone rock his ship
was cast
Was waxing dim, nor yet at all he
learned
To 'scape the fire that erst his heart
had burned.
And he forgot his deeds, forgot his
fame,
Forgot the letters of his ancient name
As one waked fully shall forget a
dream,
That once to him a wondrous tale did
seem.

Now I, though writing here no
chronicle
E'en as I said, must nathless shortly
tell
That, ere the army Rouen's gates
could gain
By a broad arrow had the King been
slain,
And helpless now the wretched
country lay
Beneath the yoke, until the glorious
day
When Ogier fell at last upon the foe,
And scattered them as helplessly as
though

They had been beaten men without a
name:
So when to Paris town once more he
came
Few folk the memory of the King did
keep
Within their hearts, and if the folk did
weep
At his returning, 'twas for joy indeed
That such a man had risen at their
need
To work for them so great
deliverance,
And loud they called on him for King
of France.

But if the Queen's heart were the
more a-flame
For all that she had heard of his great
fame,
I know not; rather with some hidden
dread
Of coming fate, she heard her lord
was dead,
And her false dream seemed coming
true at last,
For the clear sky of love seemed
overcast
With clouds of God's great
judgments, and the fear
Of hate and final parting drawing
near.
So now when he before her
throne did stand
Amidst the throng as saviour of the
land,

And she her eyes to his kind eyes did
raise,
And there before all her own love
must praise;
Then did she fall a-weeping, and folk
said,
"See, how she sorrows for the newly
dead!
Amidst our joy she needs must think
of him;
Let be, full surely shall her grief wax
dim
And she shall wed again."
So passed the
year,
While Ogier set himself the land to
clear
Of broken remnants of the heathen
men,
And at the last, when May-time came
again,
Must he be crowned King of the
twice-saved land,
And at the altar take the fair Queen's
hand
And wed her for his own. And now
by this
Had he forgotten clean the woe and
bliss
Of his old life, and still was he made
glad
As other men; and hopes and fears he
had
As others, and bethought him not at
all
Of what strange days upon him yet
should fall

When he should live and these again
be dead.

Now drew the time round when
he should be wed,
And in his palace on his bed he lay
Upon the dawning of the very day:
'Twixt sleep and waking was he, and
could hear
E'en at that hour, through the bright
morn and clear,
The hammering of the folk who
toiled to make
Some well-wrought stages for the
pageant's sake,
Though hardly yet the sparrows had
begun
To twitter o'er the coming of the sun,
Nor through the palace did a creature
move.

There in the sweet entanglement
of love
Midst languid thoughts of greater
bliss he lay,
Remembering no more of that other
day
Than the hot noon remembereth of
the night,
Than summer thinketh of the winter
white.

In that sweet hour he heard a
voice that cried,
"Ogier, Ogier!" then, opening his
eyes wide,
And rising on his elbow, gazed
around,

And strange to him and empty was
the sound
Of his own name; "Whom callest
thou?" he said.
"For I, the man who lies upon this
bed,
Am Charles of France, and shall be
King to-day,
But in a year that now is past away
The Ancient Knight they called me:
who is this,
Thou callest Ogier, then, what deeds
are his?
And who art thou?" But at that word
a sigh,
As of one grieved, came from some
place anigh
His bed-side, and a soft voice spake
again,
"This Ogier once was great amongst
great men;
To Italy a helpless hostage led;
He saved the King when the false
Lombard fled,
Bore forth the Oriflamme and gained
the day;
Charlot he brought back, whom men
led away,
And fought a day-long fight with
Caraheu.
The ravager of Rome his right hand
slew;
Nor did he fear the might of
Charlemaine,
Who for a dreary year beset in vain
His lonely castle; yet at last caught
then,

And shut in hold, needs must he
 come again
To give an unhop'd great deliverance
Unto the burdened helpless land of
 France:
Denmark he gained thereafter, and he
 wore
The crown of England drawn from
 trouble sore;
At Tyre then he reigned, and Babylon
With mighty deeds he from the
 foemen won;
And when scarce aught could give
 him greater fame,
He left the world still thinking on his
 name.

 "These things did Ogier, and
 these things didst thou,
Nor will I call thee by a new name
 now
Since I have spoken words of love to
 thee—
Ogier, Ogier, dost thou remember me,
E'en if thou hast no thought of that
 past time
Before thou earnest to our happy
 clime?"

 As this was said, his mazed eyes
 saw indeed
A lovely woman clad in dainty weed
Beside his bed, and many a thought
 was stirred
Within his heart by that last plaintive
 word,
Though nought he said, but waited
 what should come.

"Love," said she, "I am here to bring
thee home;
Well hast thou done all that thou
cam'st to do,
And if thou bidest here, for
something new
Will folk begin to cry, and all thy
fame
Shall then avail thee but for greater
blame;
Thy love shall cease to love thee, and
the earth
Thou lovest now shall be of little
worth
While still thou keepest life,
abhorring it.
Behold, in men's lives that so quickly
flit
Thus is it, how then shall it be with
thee,
Who some faint image of eternity
Hast gained through me?—alas, thou
heedest not!
On all these changing things thine
heart is hot—
Take then this gift that I have brought
from far,
And then may'st thou remember what
we are;
The lover and the loved from long
ago."
He trembled, and more memory
seemed to grow
Within his heart as he beheld her
stand,
Holding a glittering crown in her
right hand:

"Ogier," she said, "arise and do on
thee
The emblems of thy worldly
sovereignty,
For we must pass o'er many a sea this
morn."

He rose, and in the glittering
tunic worn
By Charlemaine he clad himself, and
took
The ivory hand, that Charlemaine
once shook
Over the people's head in days of old;
Then on his feet he set the shoes of
gold,
And o'er his shoulders threw the
mantle fair,
And set the gold crown on his golden
hair:
Then on the royal chair he sat him
down,
As though he deemed the elders of
the town
Should come to audience; and in all
he seemed
To do these things e'en as a man who
dreamed.

And now adown the Seine the
golden sun
Shone out, as toward him drew that
lovely one
And took from off his head the royal
crown,
And, smiling, on the pillow laid it
down

And said, "Lie there, O crown of
Charlemaine,
Worn by a mighty man, and worn in
vain,
Because he died, and all the things he
did
Were changed before his face by
earth was hid;
A better crown I have for my love's
head,
Whereby he yet shall live, when all
are dead
His hand has helped." Then on his
head she set
The wondrous crown, and said,
"Forget, forget!
Forget these weary things, for thou
hast much
Of happiness to think of."
At that touch
He rose, a happy light gleamed in his
eyes;
And smitten by the rush of memories,
He stammered out, "O love! how
came we here?
What do we in this land of Death and
Fear?
Have I not been from thee a weary
while?
Let us return—I dreamed about the
isle;
I dreamed of other years of strife and
pain,
Of new years full of struggles long
and vain."
She took him by the hand and
said, "Come, love,

I am not changed;" and therewith did
they move
Unto the door, and through the
sleeping place
Swiftly they went, and still was
Ogier's face
Turned on her beauty, and no thought
was his
Except the dear returning of his bliss.
But at the threshold of the
palace-gate
That opened to them, she awhile did
wait,
And turned her eyes unto the rippling
Seine
And said, "O love, behold it once
again!"
He turned, and gazed upon the city
grey
Smit by the gold of that sweet morn
of May;
He heard faint noises as of wakening
folk
As on their heads his day of glory
broke;
He heard the changing rush of the
swift stream
Against the bridge-piers. All was
grown a dream.
His work was over, his reward was
come,
Why should he loiter longer from his
home?

A little while she watched him
silently,

Then beckoned him to follow with a
sigh,
And, raising up the raiment from her
feet,
Across the threshold stepped into the
street;
One moment on the twain the low sun
shone,
And then the place was void, and
they were gone
How I know not; but this I know
indeed,
That in whatso great trouble or sore
need
The land of France since that fair day
has been,
No more the sword of Ogier has she
seen.

SUCH was the tale he told of Avallon,
E'en such an one as in days past had
won
His youthful heart to think upon the
quest;
But to those old hearts nigh in reach
of rest,
Not much to be desired now it
seemed—
Perchance the heart that of such
things had dreamed
Had found no words in this death-
laden tongue
We speak on earth, wherewith they
might be sung;

Perchance the changing years that
 changed his heart
E'en in the words of that old tale had
 part,
Changing its sweet to bitter, to
 despair
The foolish hope that once had
 glittered there—
Or think, that in some bay of that far
 home
They then had sat, and watched the
 green waves come
Up to their feet with many promises;
Or the light wind midst blossom-
 laden trees,
In the sweet Spring had weighted
 many a word
Of no worth now, and many a hope
 had stirred
Long dead for ever.

 Howsoe'er that be
Among strange folk they now sat
 quietly,
As though that tale with them had
 nought to do,
As though its hopes and fears were
 something new.
But though, indeed, the outworn,
 dwindled band
Had no tears left for that once longed-
 for land,
The very wind must moan for their
 decay,
And from the sky, grown dull, and
 low, and grey,
Cold tears must fall upon the lonely
 field,

That such fair golden hopes erewhile
 did yield;
And on the blackening woods,
 wherein the doves
Sat silent now, forgetful of their
 loves.

Yet, since a little life at least was left,
They were not yet of every joy bereft,
For long ago was past the agony,
Midst which they found that they
 indeed must die;
And now well-nigh as much their
 pain was past
As though death's veil already had
 been cast
Over their heads—so, midst some
 little mirth,
They watched the dark night hide the
 gloomy earth.

THE GOLDEN APPLES.

This tale tells of the voyage of a ship of Tyre, that, against the will of the shipmen, bore Hercules to an unknown land of the West, that he might accomplish a task laid on him by the Fates.

As many as the leaves fall from
the tree,
From the world's life the years are
fallen away
Since King Eurystheus sat in majesty
In fair Mycenæ; midmost of whose
day
It once befell that in a quiet bay
A ship of Tyre was swinging nigh the
shore,
Her folk for sailing handling rope and
oar.

Fresh was the summer morn, a
soft wind stole
Down from the sheep-browsed slopes
the cliffs that crowned,
And ruffled lightly the long gleaming
roll
Of the peaceful sea, and bore along
the sound
Of shepherd-folk and sheep and
questing hound,
For in the first dip of the hillside
there
Lay bosomed 'mid its trees a
homestead fair.

Amid regrets for last night,
when the moon,
Risen on the soft dusk, shone on
maidens' feet
Brushing the gold-heart lilies to the
tune
Of pipes complaining, o'er the grass
down-beat
That mixed with dewy flowers its
odour sweet,
The shipmen laboured, till the sail
unfurled
Swung round the prow to meet
another world.

But ere the anchor had come
home, a shout
Rang from the strand, as though the
ship were hailed.
Whereat the master bade them stay, in
doubt
That they without some needful thing
had sailed;
When, lo! from where the cliff's steep
grey sides failed
Into a ragged stony slip, came twain
Who seemed in haste the ready keel
to gain.

Soon they drew nigh, and he
who first came down
Unto the surf was a man huge of
limb,
Grey-eyed, with crisp-curled hair
'twixt black and brown,
Who had a lion's skin cast over him,

So wrought with gold that the fell
showed but dim
Betwixt the threads, and in his hand
he bore
A mighty club with bands of steel
done o'er.

Panting there followed him a
grey old man,
Bearing a long staff, clad in gown of
blue,
Feeble of aspect, hollow-cheeked and
wan,
Who when unto his fellow's side he
drew,
Said faintly: "Now, do that which
thou shouldst do;
This is the ship." Then in the other's
eye
A smile gleamed, and he spake out
merrily:

"Masters, folk tell me that ye
make for Tyre,
And after that still nearer to the sun;
And since Fate bids me look to die by
fire,
Fain am I, ere my worldly day be
done,
To know what from earth's hottest
can be won;
And this old man, my kinsman,
would with me.
How say ye, will ye bear us o'er the
sea?"

"What is thy name?" the master
said: "And know
That we are merchants, and for
nought give nought;
What wilt thou pay?—thou seem'st
full rich, I trow."
The old man muttered, stooped
adown and caught
At something in the sand: "E'en so I
thought,"
The younger said, "when I set out
from home—
As to my name, perchance in days to
come

"Thou shalt know that—but
have heed, take this toy,
And call me the Strong Man." And as
he spake
The master's deep-brown eyes 'gan
gleam with joy,
For from his arm a huge ring did he
take,
And cast it on the deck, where it did
break
A water-jar, and in the wet shards lay
Golden, and gleaming like the end of
day.

But the old man held out a
withered hand,
Wherein there shone two pearls most
great and fair,
And said, "If any nigher I might
stand,
Then might'st thou see the things I
give thee here—

And for a name—a many names I
bear,
But call me Shepherd of the Shore
this tide,
And for more knowledge with a good
will bide."

From one to the other turned the
master's eyes;
The Strong Man laughed as at some
hidden jest,
And wild doubts in the shipman's
heart did rise;
But thinking on the thing, he deemed
it best
To bid them come aboard, and take
such rest
As they might have of the untrusty
sea,
'Mid men who trusty fellows still
should be.

Then no more words the Strong
Man made, but straight
Caught up the elder in his arms, and
so,
Making no whit of all that added
weight,
Strode to the ship, right through the
breakers low,
And catching at the rope that they did
throw
Out toward his hand, swung up into
the ship;
Then did the master let the hawser
slip.

The shapely prow cleft the wet
mead and green,
And wondering drew the shipmen
round to gaze
Upon those limbs, the mightiest ever
seen;
And many deemed it no light thing to
face
The splendour of his eyen, though
they did blaze
With no wrath now, no hate for them
to dread,
As seaward 'twixt the summer isles
they sped.

Freshened the wind, but ever fair
it blew
Unto the south-east; but as failed the
land,
Unto the plunging prow the Strong
Man drew,
And silent, gazing with wide eyes did
stand,
As though his heart found rest; but
'mid the band
Of shipmen in the stern the old man
sat,
Telling them tales that no man there
forgot.

As one who had beheld, he told
them there
Of the sweet singer, whom, for his
song's sake,
The dolphins back from choking
death did bear;

How in the mid sea did the vine
 outbreak
O'er that ill bark when Bacchus 'gan
 to wake;
How anigh Cyprus, ruddy with the
 rose
The cold sea grew as any June-loved
 close;

 While on the flowery shore all
 things alive
Grew faint with sense of birth of
 some delight,
And the nymphs waited trembling
 there, to give
Glad welcome to the glory of that
 sight:
He paused then, ere he told how, wild
 and white,
Rose ocean, breaking o'er a race
 accurst,
A world once good, now come unto
 its worst.

 And then he smiled, and said,
 "And yet ye won,
Ye men, and tremble not on days like
 these,
Nor think with what a mind
 Prometheus' son
Beheld the last of the torn reeling
 trees
From high Parnassus: slipping
 through the seas
Ye never think, ye men-folk, how ye
 seem

From down below through the green
waters' gleam."

Dusk was it now when these last
words he said,
And little of his visage might they
see,
But o'er their hearts stole vague and
troublous dread,
They knew not why; yet ever quietly
They sailed that night; nor might a
morning be
Fairer than was the next morn; and
they went
Along their due course after their
intent.

The fourth day, about sunrise,
from the mast
The watch cried out he saw
Phoenician land;
Whereat the Strong Man on the elder
cast
A look askance, and he straight took
his stand
Anigh the prow, and gazed beneath
his hand
Upon the low sun and the scarce-seen
shore,
Till cloud-flecks rose, and gathered
and drew o'er.

The morn grown cold; then
small rain 'gan to fall,
And all the wind dropped dead, and
hearts of men

Sank, and their bark seemed helpless
now and small;
Then suddenly the wind 'gan moan
again;
Sails flapped, and ropes beat wild
about; and then
Down came the great east wind; and
the ship ran
Straining, heeled o'er, through seas all
changed and wan.

Westward, scarce knowing night
from day, they drave
Through sea and sky grown one; the
Strong Man wrought
With mighty hands, and seemed a god
to save;
But on the prow, heeding all weather
nought,
The elder stood, nor any prop he
sought,
But swayed to the ship's wallowing,
as on wings
He there were set above the wrack of
things.

And westward still they drave;
and if they saw
Land upon either side, as on they
sped,
'Twas but as faces in a dream may
draw
Anigh, and fade, and leave nought in
their stead;
And in the shipmen's hearts grew
heavy dread

To sick despair; they deemed they
should drive on
Till the world's edge and empty space
were won.

But 'neath the Strong Man's eyes
e'en as they might
They toiled on still; and he sang to
the wind,
And spread his arms to meet the
waters white,
As o'er the deck they tumbled,
making blind
The brine-drenched shipmen; nor
with eye unkind
He gazed up at the lightning; nor
would frown
When o'er the wet waste Jove's bolt
rattled down.

And they, who at the last had
come to think
Their guests were very gods, with all
their fear
Feared nought belike that their good
ship would sink
Amid the storm; but rather looked to
hear
The last moan of the wind that them
should bear
Into the windless stream of ocean
grey,
Where they should float till dead was
every day.

Yet their fear mocked them; for
the storm 'gan die

About the tenth day, though unto the
west
They drave on still; soon fair and
quietly
The morn would break: and though
amid their rest
Nought but long evil wandering
seemed the best
That they might hope for; still,
despite their dread,
Sweet was the quiet sea and
goodlihead

Of the bright sun at last come
back again;
And as the days passed, less and less
fear grew,
If without cause, till faded all their
pain;
And they 'gan turn unto their guests
anew,
Yet durst ask nought of what that evil
drew
Upon their heads; or of returning
speak.
Happy they felt, but listless, spent,
and weak.

And now as at the first the elder
was,
And sat and told them tales of yore
agone;
But ever the Strong Man up and
down would pass
About the deck, or on the prow alone
Would stand and stare out westward;
and still on

Through a fair summer sea they went,
nor thought
Of what would come when these days
turned to nought.

And now when twenty days
were well passed o'er
They made a new land; cloudy
mountains high
Rose from the sea at first; then a
green shore
Spread fair below them: as they drew
anigh
No sloping, stony strand could they
espy,
And no surf breaking; the green sea
and wide
Wherethrough they slipped was
driven by no tide.

Dark fell ere they might set their
eager feet
Upon the shore; but night-long their
ship lay
As in a deep stream, by the blossoms
sweet
That flecked the grass whence
flowers ne'er passed away.
But when the cloud-barred east
brought back the day,
And turned the western mountain-
tops to gold,
Fresh fear the shipmen in their bark
did hold.

For as a dream seemed all; too
fair for those

Who needs must die; moreover they
could see,
A furlong off, 'twixt apple-tree and
rose,
A brazen wall that gleamed out
wondrously
In the young sun, and seemed right
long to be;
And memory of all marvels lay upon
Their shrinking hearts now this sweet
place was won.

But when unto the nameless
guests they turned,
Who stood together nigh the plank
shot out
Shoreward, within the Strong Man's
eyes there burned
A wild light, as the other one in doubt
He eyed a moment; then with a great
shout
Leaped into the blossomed grass; the
echoes rolled
Back from the hills, harsh still and
over-bold.

Slowly the old man followed
him, and still
The crew held back: they knew now
they were brought
Over the sea the purpose to fulfil
Of these strange men; and in their
hearts they thought,
"Perchance we yet shall live, if,
meddling nought
With dreams, we bide here till these
twain come back;

But prying eyes the fire-blast seldom
lack."

Yet 'mongst them were two
fellows bold and young,
Who, looking each upon the other's
face,
Their hearts to meet the unknown
danger strung,
And went ashore, and at a gentle pace
Followed the strangers, who unto the
place
Where the wall gleamed had turned;
peace and desire
Mingled together in their hearts, as
nigher

They drew unto that wall, and
dulled their fear:
Fair wrought it was, as though with
bricks of brass;
And images upon its face there were,
Stories of things a long while come to
pass:
Nor that alone—as looking in a glass
Its maker knew the tales of what
should be,
And wrought them there for bird and
beast to see.

So on they went; the many birds
sang sweet
Through all that blossomed thicket
from above,
And unknown flowers bent down
before their feet;

The very air, cleft by the grey-winged
dove,
Throbbled with sweet scent, and
smote their souls with love.
Slowly they went till those twain
stayed before
A strangely-wrought and iron-
covered door.

They stayed, too, till o'er noise
of wind, and bird,
And falling flower, there rang a
mighty shout
As the Strong Man his steel-bound
club upreared,
And drave it 'gainst the hammered
iron stout,
Where 'neath his blows flew bolt and
rivet out,
Till shattered on the ground the great
door lay,
And into the guarded place bright
poured the day.

The Strong Man entered, but his
fellow stayed,
Leaning against a tree-trunk as they
deemed.
They faltered now, and yet all things
being weighed
Went on again; and thought they must
have dreamed
Of the old man, for now the sunlight
streamed
Full on the tree he had been leaning
on,

And him they saw not go, yet was he
gone:

Only a slim green lizard flitted
there
Amidst the dry leaves; him they
noted nought,
But trembling, through the doorway
'gan to peer,
And still of strange and dreadful saw
not aught,
Only a garden fair beyond all
thought.
And there, 'twixt sun and shade, the
Strong Man went
On some long-sought-for end belike
intent.

They 'gan to follow down a
narrow way
Of green-sward that the lilies
trembled o'er,
And whereon thick the scattered rose-
leaves lay;
But a great wonder weighed upon
them sore,
And well they thought they should
return no more,
Yet scarce a pain that seemed; they
looked to meet
Before they died things strange and
fair and sweet.

So still to right and left the
Strong Man thrust
The blossomed boughs, and passed
on steadily,

As though his hardy heart he well did
trust,
Till in a while he gave a joyous cry,
And hastened on, as though the end
drew nigh;
And women's voices then they
deemed they heard,
Mixed with a noise that made desire
afeard.

Yet through sweet scents and
sounds on did they bear
Their panting hearts, till the path
ended now
In a wide space of green, a streamlet
clear
From out a marble basin there did
flow,
And close by that a slim-trunked tree
did grow,
And on a bough low o'er the water
cold
There hung three apples of red-
gleaming gold.

About the tree, new risen e'en
now to meet
The shining presence of that mighty
one,
Three damsels stood, naked from
head to feet
Save for the glory of their hair, where
sun
And shadow flickered, while the
wind did run
Through the grey leaves o'erhead, and
shook the grass

Where nigh their feet the wandering
bee did pass.

But 'midst their delicate limbs
and all around
The tree-roots, gleaming blue black
could they see
The spires of a great serpent, that,
enwound
About the smooth bole, looked forth
threateningly,
With glittering eyes and raised crest,
o'er the three
Fair heads fresh crowned, and hissed
above the speech
Wherewith they murmured softly
each to each.

Now the Strong Man amid the
green space stayed,
And leaning on his club, with eager
eyes
But brow yet smooth, in voice yet
friendly said:
"O daughters of old Hesperus the
Wise,
Well have ye held your guard here;
but time tries
The very will of gods, and to my
hand
Must give this day the gold fruit of
your land."

Then spake the first maid—
sweet as the west wind
Amidst of summer noon her sweet
voice was:

"Ah, me! what knows this place of
changing mind
Of men or gods; here shall long ages
pass,
And clean forget thy feet upon the
grass,
Thy hapless bones amid the fruitful
mould;
Look at thy death envenomed swift
and cold!"

Hiding new flowers, the dull
coils, as she spake,
Moved near her limbs: but then the
second one,
In such a voice as when the morn
doth wake
To song of birds, said, "When the
world foredone
Has moaned its last, still shall we
dwell alone
Beneath this bough, and have no tales
to tell
Of things deemed great that on the
earth befell."

Then spake the third, in voice as
of the flute
That wakes the maiden to her
wedding morn:
"If any god should gain our golden
fruit,
Its curse would make his deathless
life forlorn.
Lament thou, then, that ever thou
wert born;

Yet all things, changed by joy or loss
or pain,
To what they were shall change and
change again."

"So be it," he said, "the Fates
that drive me on
Shall slay me or shall save; blessing
or curse
That followeth after when the thing is
won
Shall make my work no better now
nor worse;
And if it be that the world's heart
must nurse
Hatred against me, how then shall I
choose
To leave or take?—let your dread
servant loose!"

E'en therewith, like a pillar of
black smoke,
Swift, shifting ever, drave the worm
at him;
In deadly silence now that nothing
broke,
Its folds were writhing round him
trunk and limb,
Until his glittering gear was nought
but dim
E'en in that sunshine, while his head
and side
And breast the fork-tongued, pointed
muzzle tried.

Closer the coils drew, quicker all
about

The forked tongue darted, and yet
stiff he stood,
E'en as an oak that sees the straw
flare out
And lick its ancient bole for little
good:
Until the godlike fury of his mood
Burst from his heart in one great
shattering cry,
And rattling down the loosened coils
did lie;

And from the torn throat and
crushed dreadful head
Forth flowed a stream of blood along
the grass;
Bright in the sun he stood above the
dead,
Panting with fury; yet as ever was
The wont of him, soon did his anger
pass,
And with a happy smile at last he
turned
To where the apples o'er the water
burned.

Silent and moveless ever stood
the three;
No change came o'er their faces, as
his hand
Was stretched aloft unto the sacred
tree;
Nor shrank they aught aback, though
he did stand
So close that tresses of their bright
hair, fanned

By the sweet garden breeze, lay light
on him,
And his gold fell brushed by them
breast and limb.

He drew adown the wind-stirred
bough, and took
The apples thence; then let it spring
away,
And from his brow the dark hair
backward shook,
And said: "O sweet, O fair, and shall
this day
A curse upon my life henceforward
lay—
This day alone? Methinks of coming
life
Somewhat I know, with all its loss
and strife.

"But this I know, at least: the
world shall wend
Upon its way, and, gathering joy and
grief
And deeds done, bear them with it to
the end;
So shall it, though I lie as last year's
leaf
Lies 'neath a summer tree, at least
receive
My life gone by, and store it, with the
gain
That men alive call striving, wrong,
and pain.

"So for my part I rather bless
than curse,

And bless this fateful land; good be
with it;
Nor for this deadly thing's death is it
worse,
Nor for the lack of gold; still shall ye
sit
Watching the swallow o'er the daisies
flit;
Still shall your wandering limbs ere
day is done
Make dawn desired by the sinking
sun.

"And now, behold! in memory
of all this
Take ye this girdle that shall waste
and fade
As fadeth not your fairness and your
bliss,
That when hereafter 'mid the
blossoms laid
Ye talk of days and men now nothing
made,
Ye may remember how the Theban
man,
The son of Jove, came o'er the waters
wan."

Their faces changed not aught
for all they heard;
As though all things now fully told
out were,
They gazed upon him without any
word:
Ah! craving kindness, hope, or loving
care,

Their fairness scarcely could have
 made more fair,
As with the apples folded in his fell
He went, to do more deeds for folk to
 tell.

Now as the girdle on the ground
 was cast
Those fellows turned and hurried
 toward the door,
And as across its broken leaves they
 passed
The old man saw they not, e'en as
 before;
But an unearthed blind mole
 bewildered sore
Was wandering there in fruitless,
 aimless wise,
That got small heed from their full-
 sated eyes.

Swift gat they to their anxious
 folk; nor had
More time than just to say, "Be of
 good cheer,
For in our own land may we yet be
 glad,"
When they beheld the guests a-
 drawing near;
And much bewildered the two
 fellows were
To see the old man, and must even
 deem
That they should see things stranger
 than a dream.

But when they were aboard the
elder cried,
"Up sails, my masters, fair now is the
wind;
Nor good it is too long here to abide,
Lest what ye may not loose your
souls should bind."
And as he spake, the tall trees left
behind
Stirred with the rising land-wind, and
the crew,
Joyous thereat, the hawsers shipward
drew.

Swift sped the ship, and glad at
heart were all,
And the Strong Man was merry with
the rest,
And from the elder's lips no word did
fall
That did not seem to promise all the
best;
Yet with a certain awe were men
oppressed,
And felt as if their inmost hearts were
bare,
And each man's secret babbled
through the air.

Still oft the old man sat with
them and told
Tales of past time, as on the outward
way;
And now would they the face of him
behold
And deem it changed; the years that
on him lay

Seemed to grow nought, and no more
wan and grey
He looked, but ever glorious, wise
and strong,
As though no lapse of time for him
were long.

At last, when six days through
the kindly sea
Their keel had slipped, he said:
"Come hearken now,
For so it is that things fare
wondrously
E'en in these days; and I a tale can
show
That, told by you unto your sons shall
grow
A marvel of the days that are to
come:
Take heed and tell it when ye reach
your home.

"Yet living in the world a man
there is
Men call the Theban King
Amphitryon's son,
Although perchance a greater sire
was his;
But certainly his lips have hung upon
Alcmena's breasts: great deeds this
man hath won
Already, for his name is Hercules,
And e'en ye Asian folk have heard of
these.

"Now ere the moon, this eve in
his last wane,

Was born, this Hercules, the fated
thrall
Of King Eurystheus, was straight bid
to gain
Gifts from a land whereon no foot
doth fall
Of mortal man, beyond the misty wall
Of unknown waters; pensively he
went
Along the sea on his hard life intent.

"And at the dawn he came into a
bay
Where the sea, ebb'd far down, left
wastes of sand,
Walled from the green earth by great
cliffs and grey;
Then he looked up, and wondering
there did stand,
For strange things lay in slumber on
the strand;
Strange counterparts of what the firm
earth hath
Lay scattered all about his weary
path:

"Sea-lions and sea-horses and
sea-kine,
Sea-boars, sea-men strange-skinned,
of wondrous hair;
And in their midst a man who seemed
divine
For changeless eld, and round him
women fair,
Clad in the sea-webs glassy green and
clear

With gems on head and girdle, limb
and breast,
Such as earth knoweth not among her
best.

"A moment at the fair and
wondrous sight
He stared, then, since the heart in him
was good,
He went about with careful steps and
light
Till o'er the sleeping sea-god now he
stood;
And if the white-foot maids had
stirred his blood
As he passed by, now other thoughts
had place
Within his heart when he beheld that
face.

"For Nereus now he knew, who
knows all things;
And to himself he said, 'If I prevail,
Better than by some god-wrought
eagle-wings
Shall I be holpen;' then he cried out:
'Hail,
O Nereus! lord of shifting hill and
dale!
Arise and wrestle; I am Hercules!
Not soon now shalt thou meet the
ridgy seas.'

"And mightily he cast himself on
him;
And Nereus cried out shrilly; and
straightway

That sleeping crowd, fair maid with
half-hid limb,
Strange man and green-haired beast,
made no delay,
But glided down into the billows
grey,
And, by the lovely sea embraced,
were gone,
While they two wrestled on the sea
strand lone.

"Soon found the sea-god that his
bodily might
Was nought in dealing with Jove's
dear one there;
And soon he 'gan to use his magic
sleight:
Into a lithe leopard, and a hugging
bear
He turned him; then the smallest fowl
of air
The straining arms of Hercules must
hold,
And then a mud-born wriggling eel
and cold.

"Then as the firm hands
mastered this, forth brake
A sudden rush of waters all around,
Blinding and choking: then a thin
green snake
With golden eyes; then o'er the shell-
strewn ground
Forth stole a fly the least that may be
found;
Then earth and heaven seemed
wrapped in one huge flame,

But from the midst thereof a voice
there came:

"Kinsman and stout-heart, thou
hast won the day,
Nor to my grief: what wouldst thou
have of me?'
And therewith to an old man small
and grey
Faded the roaring flame, who wearily
Sat down upon the sand and said, 'Let
be!
I know thy tale; worthy of help thou
art;
Come now, a short way hence will
there depart

"A ship of Tyre for the warm
southern seas,
Come we a-board; according to my
will
Her way shall be.' Then up rose
Hercules,
Merry of face, though hot and panting
still;
But the fair summer day his heart did
fill
With all delight; and so forth went the
twain,
And found those men desirous of all
gain.

"Ah, for these gainful men—
somewhat indeed
Their sails are rent, their bark beat;
kin and friend

Are wearying for them; yet a friend in
 need
They yet shall gain, if at their
 journey's end,
Upon the last ness where the wild
 goats wend
To lick the salt-washed stones, a
 house they raise
Bedight with gold in kindly Nereus'
 praise."

Breathless they waited for these
 latest words,
That like the soft wind of the
 gathering night
Were grown to be: about the mast
 flew birds
Making their moan, hovering long-
 winged and white;
And now before their straining
 anxious sight
The old man faded out into the air,
And from his place flew forth a sea-
 mew fair.

Then to the Mighty Man,
 Alcmena's son,
With yearning hearts they turned till
 he should speak,
And he spake softly: "Nought ill have
 ye done
In helping me to find what I did seek:
The world made better by me knows
 if weak
My hand and heart are: but now, light
 the fire

Upon the prow and worship the grey
sire."

So did they; and such gifts as
there they had
Gave unto Nereus; yea, and sooth to
say,
Amid the tumult of their hearts made
glad,
Had honoured Hercules in e'en such
way;
But he laughed out amid them, and
said, "Nay,
Not yet the end is come; nor have I
yet
Bowed down before vain longing and
regret.

"It may be—who shall tell, when
I go back
There whence I came, and looking
down behold
The place that my once eager heart
shall lack,
And all my dead desires a-lying cold,
But I may have the might then to
enfold
The hopes of brave men in my heart?
—but long
Life lies before first with its change
and wrong."

So fair along the watery ways
they sped
In happy wise, nor failed of their
return;

Nor failed in ancient Tyre the ways to
tread,
Teaching their tale to whomsoever
would learn,
Nor failed at last the flesh of beasts to
burn
In Nereus' house, turned toward the
bright day's end
On the last ness, round which the
wild goats wend.

L'ENVOI.

Here are we for the last time
face to face,
Thou and I, Book, before I bid thee
speed
Upon thy perilous journey to that
place
For which I have done on thee
pilgrim's weed,
Striving to get thee all things for thy
need—
—I love thee, whatso time or men
may say
Of the poor singer of an empty day.

Good reason why I love thee,
e'en if thou
Be mocked or clean forgot as time
wears on;
For ever as thy fashioning did grow,
Kind word and praise because of thee
I won
From those without whom were my
world all gone,
My hope fallen dead, my singing cast
away,
And I set soothly in an empty day.

I love thee; yet this last time
must it be,
That thou must hold thy peace and I
must speak,
Lest if thou babble I begin to see

Thy gear too thin, thy limbs and heart
too weak,
To find the land thou goest forth to
seek—
—Though what harm if thou die upon
the way,
Thou idle singer of an empty day?

But though this land desired
thou never reach,
Yet folk who know it mayst thou
meet or death;
Therefore a word unto thee would I
teach
To answer these, who, noting thy
weak breath,
Thy wandering eyes, thy heart of
little faith,
May make thy fond desire a sport and
play,
Mocking the singer of an empty day.

That land's name, say'st thou?
and the road thereto?
Nay, Book, thou mockest, saying thou
know'st it not;
Surely no book of verse I ever knew
But ever was the heart within him hot
To gain the Land of Matters Unforgot
—
—There, now we both laugh—as the
whole world may,
At us poor singers of an empty day.

Nay, let it pass, and hearken!
Hast thou heard
That therein I believe I have a friend,

Of whom for love I may not be
 afeard?
It is to him indeed I bid thee wend;
Yea, he perchance may meet thee ere
 thou end,
Dying so far off from the hedge of
 bay,
Thou idle singer of an empty day!

Well, think of him, I bid thee, on
 the road,
And if it hap that midst of thy defeat,
Fainting beneath thy follies' heavy
 load,
My Master, GEOFFREY CHAUCER, thou
 do meet,
Then shalt thou win a space of rest
 full sweet;
Then be thou bold, and speak the
 words I say,
The idle singer of an empty day!

"O Master, O thou great of heart
 and tongue,
Thou well mayst ask me why I
 wander here,
In raiment rent of stories oft besung!
But of thy gentleness draw thou
 anear,
And then the heart of one who held
 thee dear
Mayst thou behold! So near as that I
 lay
Unto the singer of an empty day.

"For this he ever said, who sent
 me forth

To seek a place amid thy company;
That howsoever little was my worth,
Yet was he worth e'en just so much as
I;
He said that rhyme hath little skill to
lie:
Nor feigned to cast his worser part
away
In idle singing for an empty day.

"I have beheld him tremble oft
enough
At things he could not choose but
trust to me,
Although he knew the world was
wise and rough:
And never did he fail to let me see
His love,—his folly and faithlessness,
may be;
And still in turn I gave him voice to
pray
Such prayers as cling about an empty
day.

"Thou, keen-eyed, reading me,
mayst read him through,
For surely little is there left behind;
No power great deeds unnameable to
do;
No knowledge for which words he
may not find,
No love of things as vague as autumn
wind—
—Earth of the earth lies hidden by
my clay,
The idle singer of an empty day!

"Children we twain are, saith he,
late made wise
In love, but in all else most childish
still,
And seeking still the pleasure of our
eyes,
And what our ears with sweetest
sounds may fill;
Not fearing Love, lest these things he
should kill;
Howe'er his pain by pleasure doth he
lay,
Making a strange tale of an empty
day.

"Death have we hated, knowing
not what it meant;
Life have we loved, through green
leaf and through sere,
Though still the less we knew of its
intent:
The Earth and Heaven through
countless year on year,
Slow changing, were to us but
curtains fair,
Hung round about a little room,
where play
Weeping and laughter of man's empty
day.

"O Master, if thine heart could
love us yet,
Spite of things left undone, and
wrongly done,
Some place in loving hearts then
should we get,

For thou, sweet-souled, didst never
stand alone,
But knew'st the joy and woe of many
an one—
—By lovers dead, who live through
thee we pray,
Help thou us singers of an empty
day!"

Fearest thou, Book, what answer
thou mayst gain
Lest he should scorn thee, and thereof
thou die?
Nay, it shall not be.—Thou mayst toil
in vain,
And never draw the House of Fame
anigh;
Yet he and his shall know whereof we
cry,
Shall call it not ill done to strive to
lay
The ghosts that crowd about life's
empty day.

Then let the others go! and if
indeed
In some old garden thou and I have
wrought,
And made fresh flowers spring up
from hoarded seed,
And fragrance of old days and deeds
have brought
Back to folk weary; all was not for
nought.
—No little part it was for me to play
—
The idle singer of an empty day.

FROM "LOVE IS ENOUGH."

INTERLUDES.

1.

LOVE IS ENOUGH; though the World be
a-waning
And the woods have no voice but the
voice of complaining,
Though the sky be too dark for
dim eyes to discover
The gold-cups and daisies fair
blooming thereunder,
Though the hills be held shadows,
and the sea a dark wonder,
And this day draw a veil over all
deeds, passed over,
Yet their hands shall not tremble,
their feet shall not falter;
The void shall not weary, the fear
shall not alter
These lips and these eyes of the
loved and the lover.

2.

LOVE IS ENOUGH: it grew up without
heeding
In the days when ye knew not its
name nor its measure,

And its leaflets untrodden by the
light feet of pleasure
Had no boast of the blossom, no sign
of the seeding,
As the morning and evening
passed over its treasure.

And what do ye say then?—that
Spring long departed
Has brought forth no child to the
softness and showers;
—That we slept and we dreamed
through the Summer of
flowers;
We dreamed of the Winter, and
waking dead-hearted
Found Winter upon us and waste
of dull hours.

Nay, Spring was o'er happy and knew
not the reason,
And Summer dreamed sadly, for
she thought all was
ended
In her fulness of wealth that
might not be amended;
But this is the harvest and the
garnering season,
And the leaf and the blossom in
the ripe fruit are blended.

It sprang without sowing, it grew
without heeding,
Ye knew not its name and ye
knew not its measure,
Ye noted it not mid your hope
and your pleasure;

There was pain in its blossom,
despair in its seeding,
But daylong your bosom now
nurseth its treasure.

3.

LOVE IS ENOUGH: draw near and
behold me
Ye who pass by the way to your
rest and your laughter,
And are full of the hope of the
dawn coming after
For the strong of the world have
bought me and sold me
And my house is all wasted from
threshold to rafter.
—Pass by me, and hearken,
and think of me not!

Cry out and come near; for my ears
may not hearken,
And my eyes are grown dim as
the eyes of the dying.
Is this the grey rack o'er the
sun's face a-flying?
Or is it your faces his brightness that
darken?
Comes a wind from the sea, or is
it your sighing?
—Pass by me and hearken,
and pity me not!

Ye know not how void is your hope
and your living:

Depart with your helping lest yet
ye undo me!
Ye know not that at nightfall she
draweth near to me,
There is soft speech between us and
words of forgiving
Till in dead of the midnight her
kisses thrill through me.
—Pass by me and hearken,
and waken me not!

Wherewith will ye buy it, ye rich who
behold me?
Draw out from your coffers your
rest and your laughter,
And the fair gilded hope of the
dawn coming after!
Nay this I sell not,—though ye
bought me and sold me,—
For your house stored with such
things from threshold to
rafter.
—Pass by me, I hearken,
and think of you
not!

4.

LOVE IS ENOUGH: ho ye who seek
saving,
Go no further; come hither; there
have been who have
found it,
And these know the House of
Fulfilment of Craving;

These know the Cup with the
roses around it;
These know the World's Wound
and the balm that hath
bound it:
Cry out, the World heedeth not,
"Love, lead us home!"

He leadeth, He hearkeneth, He
cometh to you-ward;
Set your faces as steel to the
fears that assemble
Round his goad for the faint, and his
scourge for the froward:
Lo! his lips, how with tales of
last kisses they tremble!
Lo! his eyes of all sorrow that
may not dissemble!
Cry out, for he heedeth, "O Love,
lead us home!"

O hearken the words of his voice of
compassion:
"Come cling round about me, ye
faithful who sicken
Of the weary unrest and the world's
passing fashion!
As the rain in mid-morning your
troubles shall thicken,
But surely within you some
Godhead doth quicken,
As ye cry to me heeding, and leading
you home.

"Come—pain ye shall have, and be
blind to the ending!

Come—fear ye shall have, mid
the sky's overcasting!
Come—change ye shall have, for far
are ye wending!
Come—no crown ye shall have
for your thirst and your
fasting,
But the kissed lips of Love and
fair life everlasting!
Cry out, for one heedeth, who leadeth
you home!"

Is he gone? was he with us?—ho ye
who seek saving,
Go no further; come hither; for
have we not found it?
Here is the House of Fulfilment of
Craving;
Here is the Cup with the roses
around it;
The World's Wound well healed,
and the balm that hath
bound it:
Cry out! for he heedeth, fair Love
that led home.

FROM

"THE STORY OF SIGURD THE VOLSUNG."

BOOK II.

REGIN.

Now this is the first book of the life and death of Sigurd the Volsung, and therein is told of the birth of him, and of his dealings with Regin the master of masters, and of his deeds in the waste places of the earth.

Of the birth of Sigurd the son of Sigmund.

PEACE lay on the land of the Helper
and the house of Elf his son;
There merry men went bedward when
their tide of toil was done,
And glad was the dawn's awakening,
and the noontide fair and glad:
There no great store had the franklin,
and enough the hireling had;
And a child might go unguarded the
length and breadth of the land
With a purse of gold at his girdle and
gold rings on his hand.
'Twas a country of cunning
craftsmen, and many a thing
they wrought,
That the lands of storm desired, and
the homes of warfare sought.
But men deemed it o'er-well warded
by more than its stems of
fight,
And told how its earth-born watchers
yet lived of plenteous might.
So hidden was that country, and few
men sailed its sea,
And none came o'er its mountains of
men-folk's company.

But fair-fruited, many-peopled, it lies
a goodly strip,
'Twixt the mountains cloudy-headed
and the sea-flood's surging lip,
And a perilous flood is its ocean, and
its mountains, who shall tell
What things in their dales deserted
and their wind-swept heaths
may dwell.
Now a man of the Kings, called
Gripir, in this land of peace
abode:
The son of the Helper's father, though
never lay his load
In the womb of the mother of Kings
that the Helper's brethren
bore;
But of Giant kin was his mother, of
the folk that are seen no more;
Though whiles as ye ride some fell-
road across the heath there
comes
The voice of their lone lamenting o'er
their changed and conquered
homes.
A long way off from the sea-strand
and beneath the mountains'
feet
Is the high-built hall of Gripir, where
the waste and the tillage meet;
A noble and plentiful house, that a
little men-folk fear,
But beloved of the crag-dwelling
eagles and the kin of the
woodland deer.
A man of few words was Gripir, but
he knew of all deeds that had

been,
And times there came upon him,
when the deeds to be were
seen:
No sword had he held in his hand
since his father fell to field,
And against the life of the slayer he
bore undinted shield:
Yet no fear in his heart abided, nor
desired he aught at all,
But he noted the deeds that had been,
and looked for what should
befall.

Again, in the house of the Helper
there dwelt a certain man
Beardless and low of stature, of
visage pinched and wan:
So exceeding old was Regin, that no
son of man could tell
In what year of the days passed over
he came to that land to dwell;
But the youth of King Elf had he
fostered, and the Helper's
youth thereto,
Yes and his father's father's: the lore
of all men he knew,
And was deft in every cunning, save
the dealings of the sword:
So sweet was his tongue-speech
fashioned, that men trowed
his every word;
His hand with the harp-strings
blended was the mingler of
delight
With the latter days of sorrow; all
tales he told aright;

The Master of the Masters in the
smithying craft was he;
And he dealt with the wind and the
weather and the stilling of the
sea;
Nor might any learn him leech-craft,
for before that race was made,
And that man-folk's generation, all
their life-days had he
weighed.

In this land abideth Hiordis amid all
people's praise
Till cometh the time appointed: in the
fulness of the days
Through the dark and the dusk she
travailed, till at last in the
dawning hour
Have the deeds of the Volsungs
blossomed, and born their
latest flower;
In the bed there lieth a man child, and
his eyes look straight on the
sun,
And lo, the hope of the people, and
the days of a king are begun.

Men say of the serving-women, when
they cried on the joy of the
morn,
When they handled the linen raiment,
and washed the king new-
born,
When they bore him back unto
Hiordis, and the weary and
happy breast,

And bade her be glad to behold it,
 how the best was sprung from
 the best,
Yet they shrank in their rejoicing
 before the eyes of the child,
So bright and dreadful were they; yea
 though the spring morn
 smiled,
And a thousand birds were singing
 round the fair familiar home,
And still as on other mornings they
 saw folk go and come,
Yet the hour seemed awful to them,
 and the hearts within them
 burned
As though of fateful matters their
 souls were newly learned.

But Hiordis looked on the Volsung,
 on her grief and her fond
 desire,
And the hope of her heart was
 quickened, and her joy was a
 living fire;
And she said: "Now one of the
 earthly on the eyes of my
 child hath gazed
Nor shrunk before their glory, nor
 stayed her love amazed:
I behold thee as Sigmund beholdeth,
 —and I was the home of thine
 heart—
Woe's me for the day when thou wert
 not, and the hour when we
 shall part!"

Then she held him a little season on
her weary and happy breast
And she told him of Sigmund and
Volsung and the best sprung
forth from the best:
She spake to the new-born baby as
one who might understand,
And told him of Sigmund's battle, and
the dead by the sea-flood's
strand,
And of all the wars passed over, and
the light with darkness blent.

So she spake, and the sun rose higher,
and her speech at last was
spent,
And she gave him back to the women
to bear forth to the people's
kings,
That they too may rejoice in her glory
and her day of happy things.

But there sat the Helper of Men with
King Elf and Earls in the hall,
And they spake of the deeds that had
been, and told of the times to
befall,
And they hearkened and heard sweet
voices and the sound of harps
draw nigh,
Till their hearts were exceeding merry
and they knew not wherefore
or why:
Then, lo, in the hall white raiment, as
thither the damsels came,
And amid the hands of the foremost
was the woven gold aflame.

"O daughters of earls," said the
Helper, "what tidings then do
ye bear?
Is it grief in the merry morning, or
joy or wonder or fear?"

Quoth the first: "It is grief for the
foemen that the Masters of
God-home would grieve."

Said the next: "'Tis a wonder of
wonders, that the hearkening
world shall believe."

"A fear of all fears," said the third,
"for the sword is uplifted on
men."

"A joy of all joys," said the fourth,
"once come, it comes not
again!"

"Lo, son," said the ancient Helper,
"glad sit the earls and the
lords!
Lookst thou not for a token of tidings
to follow such-like words?"

Saith King Elf: "Great words of
women! or great hath our
dwelling become."

Said the women: "Words shall be
greater, when all folk shall
praise our home."

"What then hath betid," said King Elf,
"do the high Gods stand in our
gate?"

"Nay," said they, "else were we silent,
and they should be telling of
fate."

"Is the bidding come," said the
Helper, "that we wend the
Gods to see?"

"Many summers and winters," they
said, "ye shall live on the
earth, it may be."

Said a young man: "Will ye be telling
that all we shall die no more?"

"Nay," they answered, "nay, who
knoweth but the change may
be hard at the door?"

"Come ships from the sea," said an
elder, "with all gifts of the
Eastland gold?"

"Was there less than enough," said the
women, "when last our
treasure was told?"

"Speak then," said the ancient Helper,
"let the worst and the best be
said."

Quoth they: "'Tis the Queen of the
Isle-folk, she is weary-sick on

her bed."

Said King Elf: "Yet ye come
rejoicing; what more lieth
under the tongue?"

They said: "The earth is weary; but
the tender blade hath sprung,
That shall wax till beneath its
branches fair bloom the
meadows green;
For the Gods and they that were
mighty were glad erewhile
with the Queen."

Said King Elf: "How say ye, women?
Of a King new-born do ye tell
By a God of the Heavens begotten in
our fathers' house to dwell?"

"By a God of the Earth," they
answered; "but greater yet is
the son,
Though long were the days of
Sigmund, and great are the
deeds he hath done."

Then she with the golden burden to
the kingly high-seat stepped
And away from the new-born baby
the purple cloths she swept,
And cried: "O King of the people,
long mayst thou live in bliss,
As our hearts to-day are happy!
Queen Hiordis sends thee this,
And she saith that the world shall call
it by the name that thou shalt

name;
Now the gift to thee is given, and to
thee is brought the fame."

Then e'en as a man astonied King Elf
the Volsung took,
While his feast-hall's ancient timbers
with the cry of the earl-folk
shook;
For the eyes of the child gleamed on
him till he was as one who
sees
The very Gods arising mid their
carven images:
To his ears there came a murmur of
far seas beneath the wind
And the tramp of fierce-eyed warriors
through the outland forest
blind;
The sound of hosts of battle, cries
round the hoisted shield,
Low talk of the gathered wise-ones in
the Goth-folk's holy field:
So the thought in a little moment
through King Elf the Mighty
ran
Of the years and their building and
burden, and toil of the sons of
man,
The joy of folk and their sorrow, and
the hope of deeds to do:
With the love of many peoples was
the wise king smitten through,

As he hung o'er the new-born
Volsung: but at last he raised
his head,
And looked forth kind o'er his people,
and spake aloud and said:

"O Sigmund King of Battle; O man of
many days,
Whom I saw mid the shields of the
fallen and the dead men's
silent praise,
Lo, how hath the dark tide perished
and the dawn of day begun!
And now, O mighty Sigmund,
wherewith shall we name thy
son?"

But there rose up a man most ancient,
and he cried: "Hail Dawn of
the Day!
How many things shalt thou quicken,
how many shalt thou slay!
How many things shalt thou waken,
how many lull to sleep!
How many things shalt thou scatter,
how many gather and keep!
O me, how thy love shall cherish,
how thine hate shall wither
and burn!
How the hope shall be sped from thy
right hand, nor the fear to thy
left return!
O thy deeds that men shall sing of! O
thy deeds that the Gods shall
see!
O SIGURD, Son of the Volsungs, O
Victory yet to be!"

Men heard the name and they knew
it, and they caught it up in the
air,
And it went abroad by the windows
and the doors of the feast-hall
fair,
It went through street and market;
o'er meadow and acre it went,
And over the wind-stirred forest and
the dearth of the sea-beat
bent,
And over the sea-flood's welter, till
the folk of the fishers heard,
And the hearts of the isle-abiders on
the sun-scorched rocks were
stirred.

But the Queen in her golden chamber,
the name she hearkened and
knew;
And she heard the flock of the
women, as back to the
chamber they drew,
And the name of Sigurd entered, and
the body of Sigurd was come,
And it was as if Sigmund were living
and she still in her lovely
home;
Of all folk of the world was she well,
and a soul fulfilled of rest
As alone in the chamber she wakened
and Sigurd cherished her
breast.

But men feast in the merry noontide,
and glad is the April green

That a Volsung looks on the sunlight
and the night and the darkness
have been.

Earls think of marvellous stories, and
along the golden strings

Flit words of banded brethren and
names of war-fain Kings:

All the days of the deeds of Sigmund
who was born so long ago;

All deeds of the glorious Signy, and
her tarrying-tide of woe;

Men tell of the years of Volsung, and
how long ago it was

That he changed his life in battle, and
brought the tale to pass:

Then goeth the word of the Giants,
and the world seems waxen
old

For the dimness of King Rerir and the
tale of his warfare told:

Yet unhushed are the singers' voices,
nor yet the harp-strings cease

While yet is left a rumour of the
mirk-wood's broken peace,

And of Sigi the very ancient, and the
unnamed Sons of God,

Of the days when the Lords of
Heaven full oft the world-
ways trod.

So stilleth the wind in the even and
the sun sinks down in the sea,

And men abide the morrow and the
Victory yet to be.

Sigurd getteth to him the horse that is called Greyfell.

Now waxeth the son of Sigmund in
 might and goodliness,
And soft the days win over, and all
 men his beauty bless.
But amidst the summer season was
 the Isle-queen Hiordis wed
To King Elf the son of the Helper,
 and fair their life-days sped.
Peace lay on the land for ever, and the
 fields gave good increase,
And there was Sigurd waxing mid the
 plenty and the peace.

Now hath the child grown greater,
 and is keen and eager of wit
And full of understanding, and oft
 hath the joy to sit
Amid talk of weighty matters when
 the wise men meet for speech;
And joyous he is moreover and blithe
 and kind with each.
But Regin the wise craftsman
 heedeth the youngling well,
And before the Kings he cometh, and
 saith such words to tell.

"I have fostered thy youth, King Elf,
 and thine O Helper of men,
And ye wot that such a master no
 king shall see again;
And now would I foster Sigurd; for,
 though he be none of thy
 blood,
Mine heart of his days that shall be
 speaketh abundant good."

Then spake the Helper of men-folk:
"Yea, do herein thy will:
For thou art the Master of Masters,
and hast learned me all my
skill:
But think how bright is this
youngling, and thy guile from
him withhold;
For this craft of thine hath shown me
that thy heart is grim and cold,
Though three men's lives thrice over
thy wisdom might not learn;
And I love this son of Sigmund, and
mine heart to him doth yearn."

Then Regin laughed, and answered:
"I doled out cunning to thee;
But nought with him will I measure:
yet no cold-heart shall he be,
Nor grim, nor evil-natured: for
whate'er my will might frame,
Gone forth is the word of the Norns,
that abideth ever the same.
And now, despite my cunning, how
deem ye I shall die?"

And they said he would live as he
listed, and at last in peace
should lie
When he listed to live no longer; so
mighty and wise he was.
But again he laughed and answered:
"One day it shall come to
pass,
That a beardless youth shall slay me:
I know the fateful doom;

But nought may I withstand it, as it
heaves up dim through the
gloom."

So is Sigurd now with Regin, and he
learns him many things;
Yea, all save the craft of battle, that
men learned the sons of kings:
The smithying sword and war-coat;
the carving runes aright;
The tongues of many countries, and
soft speech for men's delight;
The dealing with the harp-strings, and
the winding ways of song.
So wise of heart waxed Sigurd, and
of body wondrous strong:
And he chased the deer of the forest,
and many a wood-wolf slew,
And many a bull of the mountains:
and the desert dales he knew,
And the heaths that the wind sweeps
over; and seaward would he
fare,
Far out from the outer skerries, and
alone the sea-wights dare.

On a day he sat with Regin amidst the
unfashioned gold,
And the silver grey from the furnace;
and Regin spake and told
Sweet tales of the days that have
been, and the Kings of the
bold and wise;
Till the lad's heart swelled with
longing and lit his sunbright
eyes.

Then Regin looked upon him: "Thou
too shalt one day ride
As the Volsung Kings went faring
through the noble world and
wide.
For this land is nought and narrow,
and Kings of the carles are
these,
And their earls are acre-biders, and
their hearts are dull with
peace."

But Sigurd knit his brows, and in
wrathful wise he said:
"Ill words of those thou speakest that
my youth have cherished,
And the friends that have made me
merry, and the land that is fair
and good."

Then Regin laughed and answered:
"Nay, well I see by thy mood
That wide wilt thou ride in the world
like thy kin of the earlier
days:
And wilt thou be wroth with thy
master that he longs for thy
winning the praise?
And now if the sooth thou sayest, that
these King-folk cherish thee
well,
Then let them give thee a gift
whereof the world shall tell:
Yea hearken to this my counsel, and
crave for a battle-steed."

Yet wroth was the lad and answered:
 "I have many a horse to my
 need,
And all that the heart desireth, and
 what wouldst thou wish me
 more?"

Then Regin answered and said: "Thy
 kin of the Kings of yore
Were the noblest men of men-folk;
 and their hearts would never
 rest
Whatso of good they had gotten, if
 their hands held not the best.
Now do thou after my counsel, and
 crave of thy fosterers here
That thou choose of the horses of
 Gripir whichso thine heart
 holds dear."

He spake and his harp was with him,
 and he smote the strings full
 sweet,
And sang of the host of the Valkyrs,
 how they ride the battle to
 meet,
And the dew from the dear manes
 drippeth as they ride in the
 first of the sun,
And the tree-boughs open to meet it
 when the wind of the dawning
 is done:
And the deep dales drink its
 sweetness and spring into
 blossoming grass,
And the earth groweth fruitful of
 men, and bringeth their glory

to pass.

Then the wrath ran off from Sigurd,
and he left the smithying stead
While the song yet rang in the
doorway: and that eve to the
Kings he said:

"Will ye do so much for mine asking
as to give me a horse to my
will?

For belike the days shall come, that
shall all my heart fulfill,
And teach me the deeds of a king."

Then answered
King Elf
and spake:

"The stalls of the Kings are before
thee to set aside or to take,
And nought we begrudge thee the
best."

Yet answered
Sigurd
again;

For his heart of the mountains aloft
and the windy drift was fain:
"Fair seats for the knees of Kings! but
now do I ask for a gift
Such as all the world shall be
praising, the best of the strong
and the swift.

Ye shall give me a token for Gripir,
and bid him to let me choose
From out of the noble stud-beasts that
run in his meadow loose.
But if overmuch I have asked you,
forget this prayer of mine,

And deem the word unspoken, and
get ye to the wine."

Then smiled King Elf, and answered:

"A long way wilt thou ride,
To where unpeace and troubles and
the griefs of the soul abide,
Yea unto the death at the last: yet
surely shalt thou win
The praise of many a people: so have
thy way herein.
Forsooth no more may we hold thee
than the hazel copse may hold
The sun of the early dawning, that
turneth it all unto gold."

Then sweetly Sigurd thanked them;
and through the night he lay
Mid dreams of many a matter till the
dawn was on the way;
Then he shook the sleep from off
him, and that dwelling of
Kings he left
And wended his ways unto Gripir. On
a crag from the mountain reft
Was the house of the old King
builded; and a mighty house it
was,
Though few were the sons of men
that over its threshold would
pass:
But the wild ernes cried about it, and
the vultures toward it flew,
And the winds from the heart of the
mountains searched every
chamber through,

And about were meads wide-
 spreading; and many a beast
 thereon,
Yea some that are men-folk's terror,
 their sport and pasture won.
So into the hall went Sigurd; and
 amidst was Gripir set
In a chair of the sea-beast's tooth; and
 his sweeping beard nigh met
The floor that was green as the ocean,
 and his gown was of
 mountain-gold
And the kingly staff in his hand was
 knobbed with the crystal cold.

Now the first of the twain spake
 Gripir: "Hail King with the
 eyen bright!
Nought needest thou show the token,
 for I know of thy life and thy
 light.
And no need to tell of thy message; it
 was wafted here on the wind,
That thou wouldst be coming to-day a
 horse in my meadow to find:
And strong must he be for the bearing
 of those deeds of thine that
 shall be.
Now choose thou of all the way-
 wearers that are running loose
 in my lea,
And be glad as thine heart will have
 thee and the fate that leadeth
 thee on,
And I bid thee again come hither
 when the sword of worth is
 won,

And thy loins are girt for thy going
on the road that before thee
lies;
For a glimmering over its darkness is
come before mine eyes."

Then again gat Sigurd outward, and
adown the steep he ran
And unto the horse-fed meadow: but
lo, a grey-clad man,
One-eyed and seeming-ancient, there
met him by the way:
And he spake: "Thou hastest, Sigurd;
yet tarry till I say
A word that shall well bestead thee:
for I know of these mountains
well
And all the lea of Gripir, and the
beasts that thereon dwell."

"Wouldst thou have red gold for thy
tidings? art thou Gripir's
horse-herd then?
Nay sure, for thy face is shining like
battle-eager men
My master Regin tells of: and I love
thy cloud-grey gown
And thy visage gleams above it like a
thing my dreams have
known."

"Nay whiles have I heeded the horse-
kind," then spake that elder of
days,
"And sooth do the sages say, when
the beasts of my breeding they
praise.

There is one thereof in the meadow,
and, wouldst thou cull him
out,
Thou shalt follow an elder's counsel,
who hath brought strange
things about,
Who hath known thy father
aforetime, and other kings of
thy kin."

So Sigurd said, "I am ready; and what
is the deed to win?"

He said: "We shall drive the horses
adown to the water-side,
That cometh forth from the
mountains, and note what next
shall betide."

Then the twain sped on together, and
they drave the horses on
Till they came to a rushing river a
water wide and wan;
And the white mews hovered o'er it;
but none might hear their cry
For the rush and the rattle of waters,
as the downlong flood swept
by.
So the whole herd took the river and
strove the stream to stem,
And many a brave steed was there;
but the flood o'ermastered
them:
And some, it swept them down-ward,
and some won back to bank,
Some, caught by the net of the eddies,
in the swirling hubbub sank;

But one of all swam over, and they
saw his mane of grey
Toss over the flowery meadows, a
bright thing far away:
Wide then he wheeled about them,
then took the stream again
And with the waves' white horses
mingled his cloudy mane.

Then spake the elder of days:
"Hearken now, Sigurd, and
hear;
Time was when I gave thy father a
gift thou shalt yet deem dear,
And this horse is a gift of my giving:
—heed nought where thou
mayst ride:
For I have seen thy fathers in a
shining house abide,
And on earth they thought of its
threshold, and the gifts I had
to give;
Nor prayed for a little longer, and a
little longer to live."

Then forth he strode to the
mountains, and fain was
Sigurd now
To ask him many a matter: but dim
did his bright shape grow,
As a man from the litten doorway
fades into the dusk of night;
And the sun in the high-noon shone,
and the world was exceeding
bright.

So Sigurd turned to the river and
stood by the wave-wet strand,
And the grey horse swims to his feet
and lightly leaps aland,
And the youngling looks upon him,
and deems none beside him
good.
And indeed, as tells the story, he was
come of Sleipnir's blood,
The tireless horse of Odin: cloud-grey
he was of hue,
And it seemed as Sigurd backed him
that Sigmund's son he knew,
So glad he went beneath him. Then
the youngling's song arose
As he brushed through the noon-tide
blossoms of Gripir's mighty
close,
Then he singeth the song of Greyfell,
the horse that Odin gave,
Who swam through the sweeping
river, and back through the
toppling wave.

***Regin telleth Sigurd of his kindred, and of the Gold that was accursed
from ancient days.***

Now yet the days pass over, and more
than words may tell
Grows Sigurd strong and lovely, and
all children love him well.
But oft he looks on the mountains and
many a time is fain
To know of what lies beyond them,
and learn of the wide world's
gain.

And he saith: "I dwell in a land that is
ruled by none of my blood;
And my mother's sons are waxing,
and fair kings shall they be
and good;
And their servant or their betrayer—
not one of these will I be.
Yet needs must I wait for a little till
Odin calls for me."

Now again it happed on a day that he
sat in Regin's hall
And hearkened many tidings of what
had chanced to fall,
And of kings that sought their
kingdoms o'er many a waste
and wild,
And at last saith the crafty master:
"Thou art King
Sigmund's
child:
Wilt thou wait till these kings of the
carles shall die in a little land,
Or wilt thou serve their sons and
carry the cup to their hand;
Or abide in vain for the day that
never shall come about,
When their banners shall dance in the
wind and shake to the war-
gods' shout?"

Then Sigurd answered and said:
"Nought such do I look to be.
But thou, a deedless man, too much
thou eggest me:
And these folk are good and trusty,
and the land is lovely and

sweet,
And in rest and in peace it lieth as the
floor of Odin's feet:
Yet I know that the world is wide, and
filled with deeds unwrought;
And for e'en such work was I
fashioned, lest the song-craft
come to nought,
When the harps of God-home tinkle,
and the Gods are at stretch to
hearken;
Lest the hosts of the Gods be scanty
when their day hath begun to
darken,
When the bonds of the Wolf wax thin,
and Loki fretteth his chain.
And sure for the house of my fathers
full oft my heart is fain,
And meseemeth I hear them talking
of the day when I shall come,
And of all the burden of deeds, that
my hand shall bear them
home.
And so when the deed is ready,
nowise the man shall lack:
But the wary foot is the surest, and
the hasty oft turns back."

Then answered Regin the guileful:
"The deed is ready to hand,
Yet holding my peace is the best, for
well thou lovest the land;
And thou lovest thy life moreover,
and the peace of thy youthful
days,
And why should the full-fed feaster
his hand to the rye-bread

raise?
Yet they say that Sigmund begat thee
and he looked to fashion a
man.
Fear nought; he lieth quiet in his
mound by the sea-waves
wan."

So shone the eyes of Sigurd, that the
shield against him hung
Cast back their light as the sunbeams;
but his voice to the roof-tree
rung:
"Tell me, thou Master of Masters,
what deed is the deed I shall
do?
Nor mock thou the son of Sigmund
lest the day of his birth thou
rue."

Then answered the Master of Sleight:
"The deed is the righting of
wrong,
And the quelling a bale and a sorrow
that the world hath endured
o'erlong,
And the winning a treasure untold,
that shall make thee more than
the kings;
Thereof is the Helm of Aweing, the
wonder of earthly things,
And thereof is its very fellow, the
War-coat all of gold,
That has not its like in the heavens,
nor has earth of its fellow
told."

Then answered Sigurd the Volsung:
 "How long hereof hast thou
 known?
And what unto thee is this treasure,
 that thou seemest to give as
 thine own?"

"Alas!" quoth the smithying master,
 "it is mine, yet none of mine
Since my heart herein avails not, and
 my hand is frail and fine—
It is long since I first came hither to
 seek a man for my need;
For I saw by a glimmering light that
 hence would spring the deed,
And many a deed of the world: but
 the generations passed,
And the first of the days was as near
 to the end that I sought as the
 last;
Till I looked on thine eyes in the
 cradle: and now I deem
 through thee,
That the end of my days of waiting,
 and the end of my woes shall
 be."

Then Sigurd awhile was silent; but at
 last he answered and said:
"Thou shalt have thy will and the
 treasure, and shalt take the
 curse on thine head
If a curse the gold enwrappeth: but
 the deed will I surely do,
For to-day the dreams of my
 childhood have bloomed in
 my heart anew:

And I long to look on the world and
the glory of the earth

And to deal in the dealings of men,
and garner the harvest of
worth.

But tell me, thou Master of Masters,
where lieth this measureless
wealth;

Is it guarded by swords of the earl-
folk, or kept by cunning and
stealth?

Is it over the main sea's darkness, or
beyond the mountain wall?

Or e'en in these peaceful acres anigh
to the hands of all?"

Then Regin answered sweetly:

"Hereof must a tale be told:

Bide sitting, thou son of Sigmund, on
the heap of unwrought gold,

And hearken of wondrous matters,
and of things unheard, unsaid,

And deeds of my beholding ere the
first of Kings was made.

"And first ye shall know of a sooth,
that I never was born of the
race

Which the masters of God-home have
made to cover the fair earth's
face;

But I come of the Dwarfs departed;
and fair was the earth
whileome

Ere the short-lived thralls of the Gods
amidst its dales were come:—

And how were we worse than the
 Gods, though maybe we lived
 not as long?
Yet no weight of memory maimed us;
 nor aught we knew of wrong.
What felt our souls of shaming, what
 knew our hearts of love?
We did and undid at pleasure, and
 repented nought thereof.
—Yea we were exceeding mighty—
 bear with me yet, my son;
For whiles can I scarcely think it that
 our days are wholly done.
And trust not thy life in my hands in
 the day when most I seem
Like the Dwarfs that are long
 departed, and most of my
 kindred I dream.

"So as we dwelt came tidings that the
 Gods amongst us were,
And the people come from Asgard:
 then rose up hope and fear,
And strange shapes of things went
 flitting betwixt the night and
 the eve,
And our sons waxed wild and
 wrathful, and our daughters
 learned to grieve.
Then we fell to the working of metal,
 and the deeps of the earth
 would know,
And we dealt with venom and
 leechcraft, and we fashioned
 spear and bow,
And we set the ribs to the oak-keel,
 and looked on the landless

sea;
And the world began to be such-like
as the Gods would have it to
be.
In the womb of the woeful Earth had
they quickened the grief and
the gold.

"It was Reidmar the Ancient begat
me; and now was he waxen
old,
And a covetous man and a king; and
he bade, and I built him a hall,
And a golden glorious house; and
thereto his sons did he call,
And he bade them be evil and wise,
that his will through them
might be wrought.
Then he gave unto Fafnir my brother
the soul that feareth nought,
And the brow of the hardened iron,
and the hand that may never
fail,
And the greedy heart of a king, and
the ear that hears no wail.

"But next unto Otter my brother he
gave the snare and the net
And the longing to wend through the
wild-wood, and wade the
highways wet:
And the foot that never resteth, while
aught be left alive
That hath cunning to match man's
cunning or might with his
might to strive.

"And to me, the least and the
youngest, what gift for the
slaying of ease?
Save the grief that remembers the
past, and the fear that the
future sees;
And the hammer and fashioning-iron,
and the living coal of fire;
And the craft that createth a
semblance, and fails of the
heart's desire;
And the toil that each dawning
quickens and the task that is
never done,
And the heart that longeth ever, nor
will look to the deed that is
won.

"Thus gave my father the gifts that
might never be taken again;
Far worse were we now than the
Gods, and but little better than
men.
But yet of our ancient might one
thing had we left us still:
We had craft to change our
semblance, and could shift us
at our will
Into bodies of the beast-kind, or fowl,
or fishes cold;
For belike no fixed semblance we had
in the days of old,
Till the Gods were waxen busy, and
all things their form must take
That knew of good and evil, and
longed to gather and make.

"So dwelt we, brethren and father;
 and Fafnir my brother fared
As the scourge and compeller of all
 things, and left no wrong
 undared;
But for me, I toiled and I toiled; and
 fair grew my father's house;
But writhen and foul were the hands
 that had made it glorious;
And the love of women left me, and
 the fame of sword and shield:
And the sun and the winds of heaven,
 and the fowl and the grass of
 the field
Were grown as the tools of my
 smithy; and all the world I
 knew,
And the glories that lie beyond it, and
 whitherward all things drew;
And myself a little fragment amidst it
 all I saw,
Grim, cold-heart, and unmighty as the
 tempest-driven straw.
—Let be.—For Otter my brother saw
 seldom field or fold,
And he oftenest used that custom,
 whereof e'en now I told,
And would shift his shape with the
 wood-beasts and the things of
 land and sea;
And he knew what joy their hearts
 had, and what they longed to
 be,
And their dim-eyed understanding,
 and his wood-craft waxed so

great,
That he seemed the king of the
creatures and their very
mortal fate.

"Now as the years won over three
folk of the heavenly halls
Grew weary of sleepless sloth, and
the day that nought befalls;
And they fain would look on the
earth, and their latest
handiwork,
And turn the fine gold over, lest a
flaw therein should lurk.
And the three were the heart-wise
Odin, the Father of the Slain,
And Loki, the World's Begrudger,
who maketh all labour vain,
And Hænir, the Utter-Blameless, who
wrought the hope of man,
And his heart and inmost yearnings,
when first the work began;—
—The God that was aforetime, and
hereafter yet shall be
When the new light yet undreamed of
shall shine o'er earth and sea.

"Thus about the world they wended
and deemed it fair and good,
And they loved their life-days dearly:
so came they to the wood,
And the lea without a shepherd and
the dwellings of the deer,
And unto a mighty water that ran
from a fathomless mere.
Now that flood my brother Otter had
haunted many a day

For its plenteous fruit of fishes; and
there on the bank he lay
As the Gods came wandering thither;
and he slept, and in his
dreams
He saw the downlong river, and its
fishy-peopled streams,
And the swift smooth heads of its
forces, and its swirling wells
and deep,
Where hang the poisèd fishes, and
their watch in the rock-halls
keep.
And so, as he thought of it all, and its
deeds and its wanderings,
Whereby it ran to the sea down the
road of scaly things,
His body was changed with his
thought, as yet was the wont
of our kind,
And he grew but an Otter indeed; and
his eyes were sleeping and
blind
The while he devoured the prey, a
golden red-flecked trout.
Then passed by Odin and Hænir, nor
cumbered their souls with
doubt;
But Loki lingered a little, and guile in
his heart arose,
And he saw through the shape of the
Otter, and beheld a chief of
his foes,
A king of the free and the careless: so
he called up his baleful might,
And gathered his godhead together,
and tore a shard outright

From the rock-wall of the river, and
 across its green wells cast;
And roaring over the waters that bolt
 of evil passed,
And smote my brother Otter that his
 heart's life fled away,
And bore his man's shape with it, and
 beast-like there he lay,
Stark dead on the sun-lit blossoms:
 but the Evil God rejoiced,
And because of the sound of his
 singing the wild grew many-
 voiced.

"Then the three Gods waded the river,
 and no word Hænir spake,
For his thoughts were set on God-
 home, and the day that is ever
 awake.
But Odin laughed in his wrath, and
 murmured: 'Ah, how long,
Till the iron shall ring on the anvil for
 the shackles of thy wrong!'

"Then Loki takes up the quarry, and
 is e'en as a man again;
And the three wend on through the
 wild-wood till they come to a
 grassy plain
Beneath the untrodden mountains;
 and lo! a noble house,
And a hall with great craft fashioned,
 and made full glorious;
But night on the earth was falling; so
 scantly might they see
The wealth of its smooth-wrought
 stonework and its world of

imagery:

Then Loki bade turn thither since day
was at an end,
And into that noble dwelling the lords
of God-home wend;
And the porch was fair and mighty,
and so smooth-wrought was
its gold,
That the mirrored stars of heaven
therein might ye behold:
But the hall, what words shall tell it,
how fair it rose aloft,
And the marvels of its windows, and
its golden hangings soft,
And the forest of its pillars! and each
like the wave's heart shone
And the mirrored boughs of the
garden were dancing fair
thereon.
—Long years ago was it builded,
and where are its wonders
now?

"Now the men of God-home
marvelled, and gazed through
the golden glow,
And a man like a covetous king
amidst of the hall they saw;
And his chair was the tooth of the
whale, wrought smooth with
never a flaw;
And his gown was the sea-born
purple, and he bore a crown
on his head,
But never a sword was before him:
kind-seeming words he said,

And bade rest to the weary feet that
 had worn the wild so long.
So they sat, and were men by
 seeming; and there rose up
 music and song,
And they ate and drank and were
 merry: but amidst the glee of
 the cup
They felt themselves tangled and
 caught, as when the net
 cometh up
Before the folk of the 'firth, and the
 main sea lieth far off;
And the laughter of lips they
 hearkened, and that hall-
 abider's scoff,
As his face and his mocking eyes
 anigh to their faces drew,
And their godhead was caught in the
 net, and no shift of creation
 they knew
To escape from their man-like bodies;
 so great that day was the
 Earth.

"Then spake the hall-abider: 'Where
 then is thy guileful mirth,
And thy hall-glee gone, O Loki?
 Come, Hænir, fashion now
My heart for love and for hope, that
 the fear in my body may
 grow,
That I may grieve and be sorry, that
 the ruth may arise in me,
As thou dealtst with the first of men-
 folk, when a master-smith
 thou wouldst be.

And thou, Allfather Odin, hast thou
 come on a bastard brood?
Or hadst thou belike a brother, thy
 twin for evil and good,
That waked amidst thy slumber, and
 slumbered midst thy work?
Nay, Wise-one, art thou silent as a
 child amidst the mirk?
Ah, I know ye are called the Gods,
 and are mighty men at home,
But now with a guilt on your heads to
 no feeble folk are ye come,
To a folk that need you nothing: time
 was when we knew you not:
Yet e'en then fresh was the winter,
 and the summer sun was hot,
And the wood-meats stayed our
 hunger, and the water
 quenched our thirst,
Ere the good and the evil wedded and
 begat the best and the worst.
And how if to-day I undo it, that
 work of your fashioning,
If the web of the world run backward,
 and the high heavens lack a
 King?
—Woe's me! for your ancient mastery
 shall help you at your need:
If ye fill up the gulf of my longing
 and my empty heart of greed,
And slake the flame ye have
 quickened, then may ye go
 your ways
And get ye back to your kingship and
 the driving on of the days
To the day of the gathered war-hosts,
 and the tide of your Fateful

Gloom.
Now nought may ye gainsay it that
 my mouth must speak the
 doom,
For ye wot well I am Reidmar, and
 that there ye lie red-hand
From the slaughtering of my
 offspring, and the spoiling of
 my land;
For his death of my wold hath bereft
 me and every highway wet.
—Nay, Loki, naught avails it, well-
 fashioned is the net.
Come forth, my son, my war-god,
 and show the Gods their
 work,
And thou who mightst learn e'en
 Loki, if need were to lie or
 lurk!

"And there was I, I Regin, the
 smithier of the snare,
And high up Fafnir towered with the
 brow that knew no fear,
With the wrathful and pitiless heart
 that was born of my father's
 will,
And the greed that the Gods had
 fashioned the fate of the earth
 to fulfill.

"Then spake the Father of Men: 'We
 have wrought thee wrong
 indeed,
And, wouldst thou amend it with
 wrong, thine errand must we
 speed;

For I know of thine heart's desire, and
the gold thou shalt nowise
lack,
—Nor all the works of the gold. But
best were thy word drawn
back,
If indeed the doom of the Norns be
not utterly now gone forth.'

"Then Reidmar laughed and
answered: 'So much is thy
word of worth!
And they call thee Odin for this, and
stretch forth hands in vain,
And pray for the gifts of a God who
giveth and taketh again!
It was better in times past over, when
we prayed for nought at all,
When no love taught us beseeching,
and we had no troth to recall.
Ye have changed the world, and it
bindeth with the right and the
wrong ye have made,
Nor may ye be Gods henceforward
save the rightful ransom be
paid.
But perchance ye are weary of
kingship, and will deal no
more with the earth?
Then curse the world, and depart, and
sit in your changeless mirth;
And there shall be no more kings, and
battle and murder shall fail,
And the world shall laugh and long
not, nor weep, nor fashion the
tale.'

"So spake Reidmar the Wise; but the
 wrath burned through his
 word,
And wasted his heart of wisdom; and
 there was Fafnir the Lord,
And there was Regin the Wright, and
 they raged at their father's
 back:
And all these cried out together with
 the voice of the sea-storm's
 wrack;
'O hearken, Gods of the Goths! ye
 shall die, and we shall be
 Gods,
And rule your men beloved with
 bitter-heavy rods,
And make them beasts beneath us,
 save to-day ye do our will,
And pay us the ransom of blood, and
 our hearts with the gold
 fulfill.'

"But Odin spake in answer, and his
 voice was awful and cold:
'Give righteous doom, O Reidmar!
 say what ye will of the Gold!'

"Then Reidmar laughed in his heart,
 and his wrath and his wisdom
 fled,
And nought but his greed abided; and
 he spake from his throne and
 said:

""Now hearken the doom I shall
 speak! Ye stranger-folk shall
 be free

When ye give me the Flame of the
Waters, the gathered Gold of
the Sea,
That Andvari hideth rejoicing in the
wan realm pale as the grave;
And the Master of Sleight shall fetch
it, and the hand that never
gave,
And the heart that begrudgeth for
ever shall gather and give and
rue.
—Lo! this is the doom of the wise,
and no doom shall be spoken
anew.'

"Then Odin spake: 'It is well; the
Curser shall seek for the
curse;
And the Greedy shall cherish the evil
—and the seed of the Great
they shall nurse.'

"No word spake Reidmar the great,
for the eyes of his heart were
turned
To the edge of the outer desert, so
sore for the gold he yearned.
But Loki I loosed from the toils, and
he goeth his ways abroad;
And the heart of Odin he knoweth,
and where he shall seek the
Hoard.

"There is a desert of dread in the
uttermost part of the world,
Where over a wall of mountains is a
mighty water hurled,

Whose hidden head none knoweth,
nor where it meeteth the sea;
And that force is the Force of
Andvari, and an Elf of the
Dark is he.
In the cloud and the desert he
dwelleth amid that land alone;
And his work is the storing of
treasure within his house of
stone.
Time was when he knew of wisdom,
and had many a tale to tell
Of the days before the Dwarf-age,
and of what in that world
befell:
And he knew of the stars and the sun,
and the worlds that come and
go
On the nether rim of heaven, and
whence the wind doth blow,
And how the sea hangs balanced
betwixt the curving lands,
And how all drew together for the
first Gods' fashioning hands.
But now is all gone from him, save
the craft of gathering gold,
And he heedeth nought of the
summer, nor knoweth the
winter cold,
Nor looks to the sun nor the snowfall,
nor ever dreams of the sea,
Nor hath heard of the making of men-
folk, nor of where the high
Gods be:
But ever he gripeth and gathereth,
and he toileth hour by hour

Nor knoweth the noon from the
midnight as he looks on his
stony bower,
And saith: 'It is short, it is narrow for
all I shall gather and get;
For the world is but newly fashioned,
and long shall its years be yet.'

"There Loki fareth, and seeth in a
land of nothing good,
Far off o'er the empty desert, the reek
of the falling flood
Go up to the floor of heaven, and
thither turn his feet
As he weaveth the unseen meshes
and the snare of strong deceit;
So he cometh his ways to the water,
where the glittering foam-bow
glows,
And the huge flood leaps the rock-
wall and a green arch over it
throws.

There under the roof of water he
treads the quivering floor,
And the hush of the desert is felt
amid the water's roar,
And the bleak sun lighteth the wave-
vault, and tells of the fruitless
plain,
And the showers that nourish
nothing, and the summer
come in vain.

"There did the great Guile-master his
toils and his tangles set,
And as wide as was the water, so
wide was woven the net;

And as dim as the Elf's remembrance
did the meshes of it show;
And he had no thought of sorrow, nor
spared to come and go
On his errands of griping and getting
till he felt himself tangled and
caught:
Then back to his blinded soul was his
ancient wisdom brought,
And he saw his fall and his ruin, as a
man by the lightning's flame
Sees the garth all flooded by foemen;
and again he remembered his
name;
And e'en as a book well written the
tale of the Gods he knew,
And the tale of the making of men,
and much of the deeds they
should do.

"But Loki took his man-shape, and
laughed aloud and cried:
'What fish of the ends of the earth is
so strong and so feeble-eyed,
That he draweth the pouch of my net
on his road to the dwelling of
Hell?
What Elf that hath heard the gold
growing, but hath heard not
the light winds tell
That the Gods with the world have
been dealing and have
fashioned men for the earth?
Where is he that hath ridden the
cloud-horse and measured the
ocean's girth,

But seen nought of the building of
God-home nor the forging of
the sword:

Where then is the maker of nothing,
the earless and eyeless lord?

In the pouch of my net he lieth, with
his head on the threshold of
Hell!'

"Then the Elf lamented, and said:
'Thou knowst of my name full
well:

Andvari begotten of Oinn, whom the
Dwarf-kind called the Wise,
By the worst of the Gods is taken, the
forge and the father of lies.'

"Said Loki: 'How of the Elf-kind, do
they love their latter life,
When their weal is all departed, and
they lie alow in the strife?'

"Then Andvari groaned and
answered: 'I know what thou
wouldst have,
The wealth mine own hands gathered,
the gold that no man gave.'

"'Come forth,' said Loki, 'and give it,
and dwell in peace henceforth
—

Or die in the toils if thou listest, if thy
life be nothing worth.'

"Full sore the Elf lamented, but he
came before the God

And the twain went into the rock-
house and on fine gold they
trode,
And the walls shone bright, and
brighter than the sun of the
upper air.
How great was that treasure of
treasures: and the Helm of
Dread was there;
The world but in dreams had seen it;
and there was the hauberk of
gold;
None other is in the heavens, nor has
earth of its fellow told.

"Then Loki bade the Elf-king bring
all to the upper day,
And he dight himself with his
Godhead to bear the treasure
away:
So there in the dim grey desert,
before the God of Guile,
Great heaps of the hid-world's
treasure the weary Elf must
pile,
And Loki looked on laughing: but,
when it all was done,
And the Elf was hurrying homeward,
his finger gleamed in the sun:
Then Loki cried: 'Thou art guileful:
thou hast not learned the tale
Of the wisdom that Gods have gotten
and their might of all avail.
Hither to me! that I learn thee of a
many things to come;
Or despite of all wilt thou journey to
the dead man's deedless home.

Come hither again to thy master, and
give the ring to me;
For meseems it is Loki's portion, and
the Bale of Men shall it be.'

"Then the Elf drew off the gold-ring
and stood with empty hand
E'en where the flood fell over 'twixt
the water and the land,
And he gazed on the great Guile-
master, and huge and grim he
grew;
And his anguish swelled within him,
and the word of the Norns he
knew;
How that gold was the seed of gold to
the wise and the shapers of
things,
The hoarders of hidden treasure, and
the unseen glory of rings;
But the seed of woe to the world and
the foolish wasters of men,
And grief to the generations that die
and spring again:
Then he cried:

'There farest thou,
Loki, and
might I
load thee
worse

Than with what thine ill heart
beareth, then shouldst thou
bear my curse:
But for men a curse thou bearest:
entangled in my gold,
Amid my woe abideth another woe
untold.

Two brethren and a father, eight kings
my grief shall slay;
And the hearts of queens shall be
broken, and their eyes shall
loathe the day.
Lo, how the wilderness blossoms! Lo,
how the lonely lands
Are waving with the harvest that fell
from my gathering hands!

"But Loki laughed in silence, and
swift in Godhead went,
To the golden hall of Reidmar and the
house of our content.
But when that world of treasure was
laid within our hall
'Twas as if the sun were minded to
live 'twixt wall and wall,
And all we stood by and panted. Then
Odin spake and said:

"O Kings, O folk of the Dwarf-kind,
lo, the ransom duly paid!
Will ye have this sun of the ocean,
and reap the fruitful field,
And garner up the harvest that earth
therefrom shall yield?"

"So he spake; but a little season
nought answered Reidmar the
wise
But turned his face from the Treasure,
and peered with eager eyes
Endlong the hall and athwart it, as a
man may chase about
A ray of the sun of the morning that a
naked sword throws out;

And lo! from Loki's right-hand came
the flash of the fruitful ring,
And at last spake Reidmar scowling:

'Ye wait for my
yea-
saying

That your feet may go free on the
earth, and the fear of my toils
may be done;

That then ye may say in your
laughter: The fools of the time
agone!

The purblind eyes of the Dwarf-kind!
they have gotten the garnered
sheaf

And have let their Masters depart
with the Seed of Gold and of
Grief:

O Loki, friend of Allfather, cast down
Andvari's Ring,

Or the world shall yet turn backward
and the high heavens lack a
king.'

"Then Loki drew off the Elf-ring and
cast it down on the heap,

And forth as the gold met gold did
the light of its glory leap:

But he spake: 'It rejoiceth my heart
that no whit of all ye shall
lack,

Lest the curse of the Elf-king cleave
not, and ye 'scape the utter
wreck.'

"Then laughed and answered
Reidmar: 'I shall have it while

I live,
And that shall be long, meseemeth:
 for who is there may strive
With my sword, the war-wise Fafnir,
 and my shield that is Regin
 the Smith?
But if indeed I should die, then let
 men-folk deal therewith,
And ride to the golden glitter through
 evil deeds and good.
I will have my heart's desire, and do
 as the high Gods would.'

"Then I loosed the Gods from their
 shackles, and great they grew
 on the floor
And into the night they gat them; but
 Odin turned by the door,
And we looked not, little we heeded,
 for we grudged his mastery;
Then he spake, and his voice was
 waxen as the voice of the
 winter sea:

"O Kings, O folk of the Dwarfs, why
 then will ye covet and rue?
I have seen your fathers' fathers and
 the dust wherefrom they
 grew;
But who hath heard of my father or
 the land where first I sprung?
Who knoweth my day of repentance,
 or the year when I was
 young?
Who hath learned the names of the
 Wise-one or measured out his
 will?

Who hath gone before to teach him,
and the doom of days fulfill?
Lo, I look on the Curse of the Gold,
and wrong amended by
wrong,
And love by love confounded, and
the strong abased by the
strong;
And I order it all and amend it, and
the deeds that are done I see,
And none other beholdeth or
knoweth; and who shall be
wise unto me?
For myself to myself I offered, that
all wisdom I might know,
And fruitful I waxed of works, and
good and fair did they grow;
And I knew, and I wrought and fore-
ordered; and evil sat by my
side,
And myself by myself hath been
doomed, and I look for the
fateful tide;
And I deal with the generations, and
the men mine hand hath
made,
And myself by myself shall be
grieved, lest the world and its
fashioning fade.'

"They went and the Gold abided: but
the words Allfather spake,
I call them back full often for that
golden even's sake,
Yet little that hour I heard them, save
as wind across the lea;

For the gold shone up on Reidmar
and on Fafnir's face and on
me.
And sore I loved that treasure: so I
wrapped my heart in guile,
And sleeked my tongue with
sweetness, and set my face in
a smile,
And I bade my father keep it, the
more part of the gold,
Yet give good store to Fafnir for his
goodly help and bold,
And deal me a little handful for my
smithying-help that day.
But no little I desired, though for
little I might pray;
And prayed I for much or for little, he
answered me no more
Than the shepherd answers the wood-
wolf who howls at the yule-
tide door:
But good he ever deemed it to sit on
his ivory throne,
And stare on the red rings' glory, and
deem he was ever alone:
And never a word spake Fafnir, but
his eyes waxed red and grim
As he looked upon our father, and
noted the ways of him.

"The night waned into the morning,
and still above the Hoard
Sat Reidmar clad in purple; but Fafnir
took his sword,
And I took my smithying-hammer,
and apart in the world we
went;

But I came aback in the even, and my
heart was heavy and spent;
And I longed, but fear was upon me
and I durst not go to the Gold;
So I lay in the house of my toil mid
the things I had fashioned of
old;
And methought as I lay in my bed
'twixt waking and slumber of
night
That I heard the tinkling metal and
beheld the hall alight,
But I slept and dreamed of the Gods,
and the things that never have
slept,
Till I woke to a cry and a clashing
and forth from the bed I leapt,
And there by the heaped-up Elf-gold
my brother Fafnir stood,
And there at his feet lay Reidmar and
reddened the Treasure with
blood;
And e'en as I looked on his eyen they
glazed and whitened with
death,
And forth on the torch-litten hall he
shed his latest breath.

"But I looked on Fafnir and trembled
for he wore the Helm of
Dread,
And his sword was bare in his hand,
and the sword and the hand
were red
With the blood of our father Reidmar,
and his body was wrapped in
gold,

With the ruddy-gleaming mailcoat of
whose fellow hath nought
been told,
And it seemed as I looked upon him
that he grew beneath mine
eyes:
And then in the mid-hall's silence did
his dreadful voice arise:

"I have slain my father Reidmar, that
I alone might keep
The Gold of the darksome places, the
Candle of the Deep.
I am such as the Gods have made me,
lest the Dwarf-kind people the
earth,
Or mingle their ancient wisdom with
its short-lived latest birth.
I shall dwell alone henceforward, and
the Gold and its waxing curse,
I shall brood on them both together,
let my life grow better or
worse.
And I am a King henceforward and
long shall be my life,
And the Gold shall grow with my
longing, for I shall hide it
from strife,
And hoard up the Ring of Andvari in
the house thine hand hath
built.
O thou, wilt thou tarry and tarry, till I
cast thy blood on the guilt?
Lo, I am a King for ever, and alone
on the Gold shall I dwell
And do no deed to repent of and
leave no tale to tell.'

"More awful grew his visage as he
 spake the word of dread
And no more durst I behold him, but
 with heart a-cold I fled;
I fled from the glorious house my
 hands had made so fair,
As poor as the new-born baby with
 nought of raiment or gear:
I fled from the heaps of gold, and my
 goods were the eager will,
And the heart that remembereth all,
 and the hand that may never
 be still.

"Then unto this land I came, and that
 was long ago
As men-folk count the years; and I
 taught them to reap and to
 sow,
And a famous man I became: but that
 generation died,
And they said that Frey had taught
 them, and a God my name did
 hide.
Then I taught them the craft of
 metals, and the sailing of the
 sea,
And the taming of the horse-kind, and
 the yoke-beasts' husbandry,
And the building up of houses; and
 that race of men went by,
And they said that Thor had taught
 them; and a smithying-carle
 was I.
Then I gave their maidens the needle
 and I bade them hold the rock,

And the shuttle-race gaped for them
as they sat at the weaving-
stock.

But by then these were waxen crones
to sit dim-eyed by the door,
It was Freyia had come among them
to teach the weaving-lore.

"Then I taught them the tales of old,
and fair songs fashioned and
true,

And their speech grew into music of
measured time and due,
And they smote the harp to my
bidding, and the land grew
soft and sweet:

But ere the grass of their grave-
mounds rose up above my
feet,

It was Bragi had made them sweet-
mouthed, and I was the
wandering scald;

Yet green did my cunning flourish by
whatso name I was called,

And I grew the master of masters—

Think thou how strange it is
That the sword in the hands of a
stripling shall one day end all
this!

"Yet oft mid all my wisdom did I long
for my brother's part,

And Fafnir's mighty kingship
weighed heavy on my heart

When the Kings of the earthly
kingdoms would give me
golden gifts

From out of their scanty treasures,
 due pay for my cunning shifts.
And once—didst thou number the
 years thou wouldst think it
 long ago—
I wandered away to the country from
 whence our stem did grow.
There methought the fells grown
 greater, but waste did the
 meadows lie
And the house was rent and ragged
 and open to the sky.
But lo, when I came to the doorway,
 great silence brooded there,
Nor bat nor owl would haunt it, nor
 the wood-wolves drew anear.
Then I went to the pillared hall-stead,
 and lo, huge heaps of gold,
And to and fro amidst them a mighty
 Serpent rolled:
Then my heart grew chill with terror,
 for I thought on the wont of
 our race,
And I, who had lost their cunning,
 was a man in a deadly place,
A feeble man and a swordless in the
 lone destroyer's fold;
For I knew that the Worm was Fafnir,
 the Wallower on the Gold.

"So I gathered my strength and fled,
 and hid my shame again
Mid the foolish sons of men-folk; and
 the more my hope was vain,
The more I longed for the Treasure,
 and deliv'rance from the yoke:

And yet passed the generations, and I
dwelt with the short-lived
folk.

"Long years, and long years after the
tale of men-folk told
How up on the Glittering Heath was
the house and the dwelling of
gold,
And within that house was the
Serpent, and the Lord of the
Fearful Face:
Then I wondered sore of the desert;
for I thought of the golden
place
My hands of old had builded; for I
knew by many a sign
That the Fearful Face was my brother,
that the blood
of the Worm was mine.

"This was ages long ago, and yet in
that desert he dwells,
Betwixt him and men death lieth, and
no man of his semblance tells;
But the tale of the great Gold-
wallower is never the more
outworn.
Then came thy kin, O Sigurd, and thy
father's father was born,
And I fell to the dreaming of dreams,
and I saw thine eyes therein,
And I looked and beheld thy glory
and all that thy sword should
win;
And I thought that thou shouldst be
he, who should bring my heart

its rest,
That of all the gifts of the Kings thy
sword should give me the
best.

"Ah, I fell to the dreaming of dreams;
and oft the gold I saw,
And the golden-fashioned Hauberk,
clean-wrought without a flaw,
And the Helm that aweth the world;
and I knew of Fafnir's heart
That his wisdom was greater than
mine, because he had held
him apart,
Nor spilt on the sons of men-folk our
knowledge of ancient days,
Nor bartered one whit for their love,
nor craved for the people's
praise.

"And some day I shall have it all, his
gold and his craft and his
heart
And the gathered and garnered
wisdom he guards in the
mountains apart.
And then when my hand is upon it,
my hand shall be as the spring
To thaw his winter away and the
fruitful tide to bring.
It shall grow, it shall grow into
summer, and I shall be he that
wrought,
And my deeds shall be remembered,
and my name that once was
nought;

Yea I shall be Frey, and Thor, and
 Freyia, and Bragi in one:
Yea the God of all that is,—and no
 deed in the wide world done,
But the deed that my heart would
 fashion: and the songs of the
 freed from the yoke
Shall bear to my house in the heavens
 the love and the longing of
 folk;
And there shall be no more dying,
 and the sea shall be as the
 land,
And the world for ever and ever shall
 be young beneath my hand."

Then his eyelids fell, and he
 slumbered, and it seemed as
 Sigurd gazed
That the flames leapt up in the stithy
 and about the Master blazed,
And his hand in the harp-strings
 wandered and the sweetness
 from them poured.
Then unto his feet leapt Sigurd and
 drew his stripling's sword,
And he cried: "Awake, O Master, for,
 lo, the day goes by,
And this too is an ancient story, that
 the sons of men-folk die,
And all save fame departeth. Awake!
 for the day grows late,
And deeds by the door are passing,
 nor the Norns will have them
 wait."

Then Regin groaned and wakened,
sad-eyed and heavy-browed,
And weary and worn was he waxen,
as a man by a burden bowed:
And he spake: "Hast thou hearkened,
Sigurd, wilt thou help a man
that is old
To avenge him for his father? Wilt
thou win that Treasure of
Gold
And be more than the Kings of the
earth? Wilt thou rid the earth
of a wrong
And heal the woe and the sorrow my
heart hath endured o'erlong?"

Then Sigurd looked upon him with
steadfast eyes and clear,
And Regin drooped and trembled as
he stood the doom to hear:
But the bright child spake as
aforetime, and answered the
Master and said:
"Thou shalt have thy will, and the
Treasure, and take the curse
on thine head."

Of the forging of the Sword that is called The Wrath of Sigurd.

Now again came Sigurd to Regin, and
said: "Thou hast taught me a
task
Whereof none knoweth the ending:
and a gift at thine hands I
ask."

Then answered Regin the Master:

"The world must be wide
indeed

If my hand may not reach across it
for aught thine heart may
need."

"Yea wide is the world," said Sigurd,
"and soon spoken is thy word;
But this gift thou shalt nought
gainsay me: for I bid thee
forge me a sword."

Then spake the Master of Masters,
and his voice was sweet and
soft,

"Look forth abroad, O Sigurd, and
note in the heavens aloft
How the dim white moon of the
daylight hangs round as the
Goth-God's shield:

Now for thee first rang mine anvil
when she walked the heavenly
field

A slim and lovely lady, and the old
moon lay on her arm:

Lo, here is a sword I have wrought
thee with many a spell and
charm

And all the craft of the Dwarf-kind;
be glad thereof and sure;

Mid many a storm of battle full well
shall it endure."

Then Sigurd looked on the slayer, and
never a word would speak:

Gemmed were the hilts and golden,
and the blade was blue and
bleak,
And runes of the Dwarf-kind's
cunning each side the trench
were scored:
But soft and sweet spake Regin:
"How likest thou the sword?"

Then Sigurd laughed and answered:
"The work is proved by the
deed;
See now if this be a traitor to fail me
in my need."

Then Regin trembled and shrank, so
bright his eyes outshone
As he turned about to the anvil, and
smote the sword thereon;
But the shards fell shivering
earthward, and Sigurd's heart
grew wroth
As the steel-flakes tinkled about him:
"Lo, there the right-hand's
troth!
Lo, there the golden glitter, and the
word that soon is spilt."
And down amongst the ashes he cast
the glittering hilt,
And turned his back on Regin and
strode out through the door
And for many a day of spring-tide
came back again no more.
But at last he came to the stithy and
again took up the word:
"What hast thou done, O Master, in
the forging of the sword?"

Then sweetly Regin answered: "Hard
task-master art thou,
But lo, a blade of battle that shall
surely please thee now!
Two moons are clean departed since
thou lookedst toward the sky
And sawest the dim white circle amid
the cloud-flecks lie;
And night and day have I laboured;
and the cunning of old days
Hath surely left my right-hand if this
sword thou shalt not praise."

And indeed the hilts gleamed glorious
with many a dear-bought
stone,
And down the fallow edges the light
of battle shone;
Yet Sigurd's eyes shone brighter, nor
yet might Regin face
Those eyes of the heart of the
Volsungs; but trembled in his
place
As Sigurd cried: "O Regin, thy kin of
the days of old
Were an evil and treacherous folk,
and they lied and murdered
for gold;
And now if thou wouldst bewray me,
of the ancient curse beware,
And set thy face as the flint the bale
and the shame to bear:
For he that would win to the heavens,
and be as the Gods on high
Must tremble nought at the road, and
the place where men-folk

die."

White leaps the blade in his hand and
gleams in the gear of the wall,
And he smites, and the oft-smitten
edges on the beaten anvil fall:
But the life of the sword departed,
and dull and broken it lay
On the ashes and flaked-off iron, and
no word did Sigurd say,
But strode off through the door of the
stithy and went to the Hall of
Kings,
And was merry and blithe that even
mid all imaginings.

But when the morrow was come he
went to his mother and spake:
"The shards, the shards of the sword,
that thou gleanedst for my
sake
In the night on the field of slaughter,
in the tide when my father
fell,
Hast thou kept them through sorrow
and joyance? hast thou
warded them trusty and well?
Where hast thou laid them, my
mother?"

Then she looked
upon him
and said:

"Art thou wroth, O Sigurd my son,
that such eyes are in thine
head?
And wilt thou be wroth with thy
mother? do I withstand thee at

all?"

"Nay," said he, "nought am I
 wrathful, but the days rise up
 like a wall
Betwixt my soul and the deeds, and I
 strive to rend them through.
And why wilt thou fear mine eyen? as
 the sword lies baleful and blue
E'en 'twixt the lips of lovers, when
 they swear their troth thereon,
So keen are the eyes ye have
 fashioned, ye folk of the days
 agone;
For therein is the light of battle,
 though whiles it lieth asleep.
Now give me the sword, my mother,
 that Sigmund gave thee to
 keep."

She said: "I shall give it thee gladly,
 for fain shall I be of thy praise
When thou knowest my careful
 keeping of that hope of the
 earlier days."

So she took his hand in her hand, and
 they went their ways, they
 twain,
Till they came to the treasure of
 queen-folk, the guarded
 chamber of gain:
They were all alone with its riches,
 and she turned the key in the
 gold,
And lifted the sea-born purple, and
 the silken web unrolled,

And lo, 'twixt her hands and her
bosom the shards of
Sigmund's sword;
No rust-fleck stained its edges, and
the gems of the ocean's hoard
Were as bright in the hilts and
glorious, as when in the
Volsungs' hall
It shone in the eyes of the earl-folk
and flashed from the shielded
wall.

But Sigurd smiled upon it, and he
said: "O Mother of Kings,
Well hast thou warded the war-glaive
for a mirror of many things,
And a hope of much fulfilment: well
hast thou given to me
The message of my fathers, and the
word of things to be:
Trusty hath been thy warding, but its
hour is over now:
These shards shall be knit together,
and shall hear the war-wind
blow.
They shall shine through the rain of
Odin, as the sun come back to
the world,
When the heaviest bolt of the thunder
amidst the storm is hurled:
They shall shake the thrones of
Kings, and shear the walls of
war,
And undo the knot of treason when
the world is darkening o'er.
They have shone in the dusk and the
night-tide, they shall shine in

the dawn and the day;
They have gathered the storm
together, they shall chase the
clouds away;
They have sheared red gold asunder,
they shall gleam o'er the
garnered gold;
They have ended many a story, they
shall fashion a tale to be told:
They have lived in the wrack of the
people; they shall live in the
glory of folk:
They have stricken the Gods in battle,
for the Gods shall they strike
the stroke."

Then she felt his hands about her as
he took the fateful sword,
And he kissed her soft and sweetly;
but she answered never a
word:
So great and fair was he waxen, so
glorious was his face,
So young, as the deathless Gods are,
that long in the golden place
She stood when he was departed: as
some for-travailed one
Comes over the dark fell-ridges on
the birth-tide of the sun,
And his gathering sleep falls from
him mid the glory and the
blaze;
And he sees the world grow merry
and looks on the lightened
ways,
While the ruddy streaks are melting
in the day-flood broad and

white;
Then the morn-dusk he forgetteth,
and the moon-lit waste of
night,
And the hall whence he departed with
its yellow candles' flare:
So stood the Isle-king's daughter in
that treasure-chamber fair.

But swift on his ways went Sigurd,
and to Regin's house he came,
Where the Master stood in the
doorway and behind him leapt
the flame,
And dark he looked and little: no
more his speech was sweet,
No words on his lip were gathered the
Volsung child to greet,
Till he took the sword from Sigurd
and the shards of the days of
old;
Then he spake:
"Will nothing
serve thee
save this
blue steel
and cold,
The bane of thy father's father, the
fate of all his kin,
The baleful blade I fashioned, the
Wrath that the Gods would
win?"

Then answered the eye-bright Sigurd:
 "If thou thy craft wilt do
Nought save these battle-gleanings
 shall be my helper true:
And what if thou begrudgest, and my
 battle-blade be dull,
Yet the hand of the Norns is lifted and
 the cup is over-full.
Repentst thou ne'er so sorely that thy
 kin must lie alow,
How much soe'er thou longest the
 world to overthrow,
And, doubting the gold and the
 wisdom, wouldst even now
 appease
Blind hate and eyeless murder, and
 win the world with these;
O'er-late is the time for repenting the
 word thy lips have said:
Thou shalt have the Gold and the
 wisdom and take its curse on
 thine head.
I say that thy lips have spoken, and
 no more with thee it lies
To do the deed or leave it: since thou
 hast shown mine eyes
The world that was aforesaid, I see
 the world to be;
And woe to the tangling thicket, or
 the wall that hindereth me!
And short is the space I will tarry; for
 how if the Worm should die
Ere the first of my strokes be
 stricken? Wilt thou get to thy
 mastery
And knit these shards together that
 once in the Branstock stood?

But if not and a smith's hands fail me,
a king's hand yet shall be
good;
And the Norns have doomed thy
brother. And yet I deem this
sword
Is the slayer of the Serpent, and the
scatterer of the Hoard."

Great waxed the gloom of Regin, and
he said: "Thou sayest sooth
For none may turn him backward: the
sword of a very youth
Shall one day end my cunning, as the
Gods my joyance slew,
When nought thereof they were
deeming, and another thing
would do.
But this sword shall slay the Serpent;
and do another deed,
And many an one thereafter till it fail
thee in thy need.
But as fair and great as thou standest,
yet get thee from mine house,
For in me too might ariseth, and the
place is perilous
With the craft that was aforetime, and
shall never be again,
When the hands that have taught thee
cunning have failed from the
world of men.
Thou art wroth; but thy wrath must
slumber till fate its blossom
bear;
Not thus were the eyes of Odin when
I held him in the snare.

Depart! lest the end overtake us ere
thy work and mine be done,
But come again in the night-tide and
the slumber of the sun,
When the sharded moon of April
hangs round in the undark
May."

Hither and thither a while did the
heart of Sigurd sway
For he feared no craft of the Dwarf-
kind, nor heeded the ways of
Fate,
But his hand wrought e'en as his heart
would: and now was he weary
with hate
Of the hatred and scorn of the Gods,
and the greed of gold and of
gain,
And the weaponless hands of the
stripling of the wrath and the
rending were fain,
But there stood Regin the Master, and
his eyes were on Sigurd's
eyes,
Though nought belike they beheld
him, and his brow was sad
and wise;
And the greed died out of his visage
and he stood like an image of
old.

So the Norns drew Sigurd away, and
the tide was an even of gold,
And sweet in the April even were the
fowl-kind singing their best;

And the light of life smote Sigurd,
 and the joy that knows no rest,
And the fond unnamed desire, and the
 hope of hidden things;
And he wended fair and lovely to the
 house of the feasting Kings.

But now when the moon was at full
 and the undark May begun,
Went Sigurd unto Regin mid the
 slumber of the sun,
And amidst the fire-hall's pavement
 the King of the Dwarf-kind
 stood
Like an image of deeds departed and
 days that once were good;
And he seemed but faint and weary,
 and his eyes were dim and
 dazed
As they met the glory of Sigurd
 where the fitful candles
 blazed.

Then he spake:
 "Hail, Son of the Volsungs, the
 corner-stone is laid,
I have toiled and thou hast desired,
 and, lo, the fateful blade!"

Then Sigurd saw it lying on the ashes
 slaked and pale
Like the sun and the lightning
 mingled mid the even's cloudy
 bale;
For ruddy and great were the hilts,
 and the edges fine and wan,
And all adown to the blood-point a
 very flame there ran

That swallowed the runes of wisdom
wherewith its sides were
scored.

No sound did Sigurd utter as he
stooped adown for his sword,
But it seemed as his lips were moving
with speech of strong desire.
White leapt the blade o'er his head,
and he stood in the ring of its
fire

As hither and thither it played, till it
fell on the anvil's strength,
And he cried aloud in his glory, and
held out the sword full length,
As one who would show it the world;
for the edges were dulled no
whit,
And the anvil was cleft to the
pavement with the dreadful
dint of it.

But Regin cried to his harp-strings:
"Before the days of men
I smithied the Wrath of Sigurd, and
now is it smithied again:
And my hand alone hath done it, and
my heart alone hath dared
To bid that man to the mountain, and
behold his glory bared.
Ah, if the son of Sigmund might wot
of the thing I would,
Then how were the ages bettered, and
the world all waxen good!
Then how were the past forgotten and
the weary days of yore,
And the hope of man that dieth and
the waste that never bore!

How should this one live through the
winter and know of all
increase!

How should that one spring to the
sunlight and bear the blossom
of peace!

No more should the long-lived
wisdom o'er the waste of the
wilderness stray;

Nor the clear-eyed hero hasten to the
deedless ending of day.

And what if the hearts of the
Volsungs for this deed of
deeds were born,

How then were their life-days evil
and the end of their lives
forlorn?"

There stood Sigurd the Volsung, and
heard how the harp-strings
rang,

But of other things they told him than
the hope that the Master sang;

And his world lay far away from the
Dwarf-king's eyeless realm

And the road that leadeth nowhere,
and the ship without a helm:

But he spake: "How oft shall I say it,
that I shall work thy will?

If my father hath made me mighty,
thine heart shall I fulfill

With the wisdom and gold thou
wouldest, before I wend on
my ways;

For now hast thou failed me nought,
and the sword is the wonder
of days."

No word for a while spake Regin; but
 he hung his head adown
As a man that pondereth sorely, and
 his voice once more was
 grown
As the voice of the smithying-master
 as he spake: "This Wrath of
 thine
Hath cleft the hard and the heavy; it
 shall shear the soft and the
 fine:
Come forth to the night and prove it."
 So they twain
 went forth
 abroad,
And the moon lay white on the river
 and lit the sleepless ford,
And down to its pools they wended,
 and the stream was swift and
 full;
Then Regin cast against it a lock of
 fine-spun wool,
And it whirled about on the eddy till
 it met the edges bared,
And as clean as the careless water the
 laboured fleece was sheared.

Then Regin spake: "It is good, what
 the smithying-carle hath
 wrought:
Now the work of the King beginneth,
 and the end that my soul hath
 sought.
Thou shalt toil and I shall desire, and
 the deed shall be surely done:

For thy Wrath is alive and awake and
the story of bale is begun."

Therewith was the Wrath of Sigurd
laid soft in a golden sheath
And the peace-strings knit around it;
for that blade was fain of
death;
And 'tis ill to show such edges to the
broad blue light of day,
Or to let the hall-glare light them, if
ye list not play the play.

Of Gripir's Foretelling.

Now Sigurd backeth Greyfell on the
first of the morrow morn,
And he rideth fair and softly through
the acres of the corn;
The Wrath to his side is girded, but
hid are the edges blue,
As he wendeth his ways to the
mountains, and rideth the
horse-mead through.
His wide grey eyes are happy, and his
voice is sweet and soft,
As amid the mead-lark's singing he
casteth song aloft:
Lo, lo, the horse and the rider! So
once maybe it was,
When over the Earth unpeopled the
youngest God would pass;
But never again meseemeth shall
such a sight betide,
Till over a world unwrongful new-
born shall Baldur ride.

So he comes to that ness of the
 mountains, and Gripir's
 garden steep,
That bravely Greyfell breasteth, and
 adown by the door doth he
 leap
And his war-gear rattleth upon him;
 there is none to ask or forbid
As he wendeth the house clear-
 lighted, where no mote of the
 dust is hid,
Though the sunlight hath not entered:
 the walls are clear and bright,
For they cast back each to other the
 golden Sigurd's light;
Through the echoing ways of the
 house bright-eyed he wendeth
 along,
And the mountain-wind is with him,
 and the hovering eagles' song;
But no sound of the children of men
 may the ears of the Volsung
 hear,
And no sign of their ways in the
 world, or their will, or their
 hope or their fear.

So he comes to the hall of Gripir, and
 gleaming-green is it built
As the house of under-ocean where
 the wealth of the greedy is
 spilt;
Gleaming and green as the sea, and
 rich as its rock-strewn floor,
And fresh as the autumn morning
 when the burning of summer
 is o'er.

There he looks and beholdeth the
 high-seat, and he sees it
 strangely wrought,
Of the tooth of the sea-beast
 fashioned ere the Dwarf-kind
 came to nought;
And he looks, and thereon is Gripir,
 the King exceeding old,
With the sword of his fathers girded,
 and his raiment wrought of
 gold;
With the ivory rod in his right-hand,
 with his left on the crystal
 laid,
That is round as the world of men-
 folk, and after its image made,
And clear is it wrought to the eyen
 that may read therein of Fate
Though little indeed be its sea, and its
 earth not wondrous great.

There Sigurd stands in the hall, on the
 sheathed Wrath doth he lean,
All his golden light is mirrored in the
 gleaming floor and green;
But the smile in his face upriseth as
 he looks on the ancient King,
And their glad eyes meet and their
 laughter, and sweet is the
 welcoming:
And Gripir saith: "Hail Sigurd! for
 my bidding hast thou done,
And here in the mountain-dwelling
 are two Kings of men alone."

But Sigurd spake: "Hail father! I am
 girt with the fateful sword

And my face is set to the highway,
and I come for thy latest
word."

Said Gripir: "What wouldst thou
hearken ere we sit and drink
the wine?"

"Thy word and the Norns'," said
Sigurd, "but never a word of
mine."

"What sights wouldst thou see," said
Gripir, "ere mine hand shall
take thine hand?"

"As the Gods would I see," said
Sigurd, "though Death light
up the land."

"What hope wouldst thou hope, O
Sigurd, ere we kiss, we twain,
and depart?"

"Thy hope and the Gods'," said
Sigurd, "though the grief lie
hard on my heart."

Nought answered the ancient wise-
one, and not a whit had he
stirred
Since the clash of Sigurd's raiment in
his mountain-hall he heard;
But the ball that imaged the earth was
set in his hand grown old;
And belike it was to his vision, as the
wide-world's ocean rolled,

And the forests waved with the wind,
and the corn was gay with the
lark,
And the gold in its nether places grew
up in the dusk and the dark,
And its children built and departed,
and its King-folk conquered
and went,
As over the crystal image his all-wise
face was bent:
For all his desire was dead, and he
lived as a God shall live,
Who the prayers of the world hath
forgotten, and to whom no
hand may give.

But there stood the mighty Volsung,
and leaned on the hidden
Wrath;
As the earliest sun's uprising o'er the
sea-plain draws a path
Whereby men sail to the Eastward
and the dawn of another day,
So the image of King Sigurd on the
gleaming pavement lay.

Then great in the hall fair-pillared the
voice of Gripir arose,
And it ran through the glimmering
house-ways, and forth to the
sunny close;
There mid the birds' rejoicing went
the voice of an o'er-wise King
Like a wind of midmost winter come
back to talk with spring.

But the voice cried: "Sigurd, Sigurd!
O great, O early born!
O hope of the Kings first fashioned!
O blossom of the morn!
Short day and long remembrance, fair
summer of the North!
One day shall the worn world wonder
how first thou wentest forth!

"Arise, O Sigurd, Sigurd! in the night
arise and go,
Thou shalt smite when the day-dawn
glimmers through the folds of
God-home's foe:

"There the child in the noon-tide
smiteth; the young King
rendeth apart,
The old guile by the guile
encompassed, the heart made
wise by the heart.

"Bind the red rings, O Sigurd; bind
up to cast abroad!
That the earth may laugh before thee
rejoiced by the Waters' Hoard.

"Ride on, O Sigurd, Sigurd! for God's
word goes forth on the wind,
And he speaketh not twice over; nor
shall they loose that bind:
But the Day and the Day shall loosen,
and the Day shall awake and
arise,
And the Day shall rejoice with the
Dawning, and the wise heart
learn of the wise.

"O fair, O fearless, O mighty, how
green are the garths of Kings,
How soft are the ways before thee to
the heart of their war-farings!

"How green are the garths of King-
folk, how fair is the lily and
rose
In the house of the Cloudy People,
'neath the towers of kings and
foes!

"Smite now, smite now in the
noontide! ride on through the
hosts of men!
Lest the dear remembrance perish,
and today come not again.

"Is it day?—But the house is darkling
—But the hand would gather
and hold,
And the lips have kissed the cloud-
wreath, and a cloud the arms
enfold.

"In the dusk hath the Sower arisen; in
the dark hath he cast the seed,
And the ear is the sorrow of Odin and
the wrong, and the nameless
need!

"Ah the hand hath gathered and
garnered, and empty is the
hand,
Though the day be full and fruitful
mid the drift of the Cloudy

Land!

"Look, look on the drift of the clouds,
how the day and the even doth
grow
As the long-forgotten dawning that
was a while ago!

"Dawn, dawn, O mighty of men! and
why wilt thou never awake,
When the holy field of the Goth-folk
cries out for thy love and thy
sake?

"Dawn, now; but the house is silent,
and dark is the purple blood
On the breast of the Queen fair-
fashioned; and it riseth up as a
flood
Round the posts of the door belovèd;
and a deed there lieth therein:
The last of the deeds of Sigurd; the
worst of the Cloudy Kin—
The slayer slain by the slain within
the door and without.
—O dawn as the eve of the birth-day!
O dark world cumbered with
doubt!

"Shall it never be day any more, nor
the sun's uprising and growth?
Shall the kings of earth lie sleeping
and the war-dukes wander in
sloth
Through the last of the winter
twilight? is the word of the
wise-ones said

Till the five-fold winter be ended and
the trumpet waken the dead?

"Short day and long remembrance!
great glory for the earth!
O deeds of the Day triumphant! O
word of Sigurd's worth!
It is done, and who shall undo it of all
who were ever alive?
May the Gods or the high Gods'
masters 'gainst the tale of the
righteous strive,
And the deeds to follow after, and all
their deeds increase,
Till the uttermost field is foughten,
and Baldur riseth in peace!

"Cry out, O waste, before him! O
rocks of the wilderness, cry!
For to-morn shalt thou see the glory,
and the man not made to die!
Cry out, O upper heavens! O clouds
beneath the lift
For the golden King shall be riding
high-headed midst the drift:
The mountain waits and the fire;
there waiteth the heart of the
wise
Till the earthly toil is accomplished,
and again shall the fire arise;
And none shall be nigh in the ending
and none by his heart shall be
laid,
Save the world that he cherished and
quickened, and the Day that
he wakened and made."

So died the voice of Gripir from
 amidst the sunny close,
And the sound of hastening eagles
 from the mountain's feet
 arose,
But the hall was silent a little, for still
 stood Sigmund's son,
And he heard the words and
 remembered, and knew them
 one by one.
Then he turned on the ancient Gripir
 with eyes that knew no guile
And smiled on the wise of King-folk
 as the first of men might smile
On the God that hath fashioned him
 happy; and he spake:
 "Hast thou
 spoken
 and
 known
How there standeth a child before
 thee and a stripling scarcely
 grown?
Or hast thou told of the Volsungs, and
 the gathered heart of these,
And their still unquenched desire for
 garnering fame's increase?
E'en so do I hearken thy words: for I
 wot how they deem it long
Till a man from their seed be arisen to
 deal with the cumber and
 wrong.
Bid me therefore to sit by thy side,
 for behold I wend on my way,
And the gates swing to behind me,
 and each day of mine is a day

With deeds in the eve and the
morning, nor deeds shall the
noontide lack;
To the right and the left none calleth,
and no voice crieth aback."

"Come, kin of the Gods," said Gripir,
"come up and sit by my side
That we twain may be glad as the
fearless, and they that have
nothing to hide:
I have wrought out my will and abide
it, and I sit ungrieved and
alone,
I look upon men and I help not; to me
are the deeds long done
As those of to-day and to-morrow:
for these and for those am I
glad;
But the Gods and men are the
framers, and the days of my
life I have had."

Then Sigurd came unto Gripir, and he
kissed the wise-one's face,
And they sat in the high-seat together,
the child and the elder of
days;
And they drank of the wine of King-
folk, and were joyful each of
each,
And spake for a while of matters that
are meet for King-folk's
speech;
The deeds of men that have been and
Kin of the Kings of the earth;

And Gripir told of the outlands, and
the mid-world's billowy girth,
And tales of the upper heaven were
mingled with his talk,
And the halls where the Sea-Queen's
kindred o'er the gem-strewn
pavement walk,
And the innermost parts of the earth,
where they lie, the green and
the blue,
And the red and the glittering gem-
stones that of old the Dwarf-
kind knew.

Long Sigurd sat and marvelled at the
mouth that might not lie,
And the eyes no God had blinded,
and the lone heart raised on
high,
Then he rose from the gleaming high-
seat, and the rings of battle
rang
And the sheathèd Wrath was
hearkening and a song of war
it sang,
But Sigurd spake unto Gripir:
"Long and lovely
are thy
days,
And thy years fulfilled of wisdom,
and thy feet on the unhid
ways,
And the guileless heart of the great
that knoweth not anger nor
pain:
So once hath a man been fashioned
and shall not be again.

But for me hath been foaled the war-
horse, the grey steed swift as
the cloud,
And for me were the edges smithied,
and the Wrath cries out aloud;
And a voice hath called from the
darkness, and I ride to the
Glittering Heath;
To smite on the door of Destruction,
and waken the warder of
Death."

So they kissed, the wise and the wise,
and the child from the elder
turned;
And again in the glimmering house-
ways the golden Sigurd
burned;
He stood outside in the sunlight, and
tarried never a deal,
But leapt on the cloudy Greyfell with
the clank of gold and steel,
And he rode through the sinking day
to the walls of the kingly
stead,
And came to Regin's dwelling when
the wind was fallen dead,
And the great sun just departing: then
blood-red grew the west,
And the fowl flew home from the
sea-mead, and all things sank
to rest.

Sigurd rideth to the Glittering Heath.

Again on the morrow morning doth
Sigurd the Volsung ride,

And Regin, the Master of Masters, is
faring by his side,
And they leave the dwelling of kings
and ride the summer land,
Until at the eve of the day the hills
are on either hand:
Then they wend up higher and higher,
and over the heaths they fare
Till the moon shines broad on the
midnight, and they sleep
'neath the heavens bare;
And they waken and look behind
them, and lo, the dawning of
day
And the little land of the Helper and
its valley far away;
But the mountains rise before them, a
wall exceeding great.

Then spake the Master of Masters:
"We have come to the garth
and the gate:
There is youth and rest behind thee
and many a thing to do,
There is many a fond desire, and each
day born anew;
And the land of the Volsungs to
conquer, and many a people's
praise:
And for me there is rest it maybe, and
the peaceful end of days.
We have come to the garth and the
gate; to the hall-door now
shall we win,
Shall we go to look on the high-seat
and see what sitteth therein?"

"Yea and what else?" said Sigurd,
"was thy tale but mockeries
And have I been drifted hither on a
wind of empty lies?"

"It was sooth, it was sooth," said
Regin, "and more might I
have told
Had I heart and space to remember
the deeds of the days of old."

And he hung down his head as he
spoke it, and was silent a little
space;
And when it was lifted again there
was fear in the Dwarf-king's
face.

And he said: "Thou knowest my
thought, and wise-hearted art
thou grown:

It were well if thine eyes were
blinder, and we each were
faring alone,

And I with my eld and my wisdom,
and thou with thy youth and
thy might;

Yet whiles I dream I have wrought
thee, a beam of the morning
bright,

A fatherless motherless glory, to work
out my desire;

Then high my hope ariseth, and my
heart is all afire

For the world I behold from afar, and
the day that yet shall be;

Then I wake and all things I
remember and a youth of the

Kings I see—
—The child of the Wood-abider, the
seed of a conquered King,
The sword that the Gods have
fashioned, the fate that men
shall sing:—
Ah might the world run backward to
the days of the Dwarfs of old,
When I hewed out the pillars of
crystal, and smoothed the
walls of gold!"

Nought answered the Son of
Sigmund; nay he heard him
nought at all,
Save as though the wind were
speaking in the bights of the
mountain-hall:
But he leapt aback of Greyfell, and
the glorious sun rose up,
And the heavens glowed above him
like the bowl of Baldur's cup,
And a golden man was he waxen; as
the heart of the sun he
seemed,
While over the feet of the mountains
like blood the new light
streamed;
Then Sigurd cried to Greyfell and
swift for the pass he rode
And Regin followed after as a man
bowed down by a load.

Day-long they fared through the
mountains, and that highway's
fashioner

Forsooth was a fearful craftsman, and
his hands the waters were,
And the heaped-up ice was his
mattock, and the fire-blast
was his man,
And never a whit he heeded though
his walls were waste and wan,
And the guest-halls of that wayside
great heaps of the ashes spent.
But, each as a man alone, through the
sun-bright day they went,
And they rode till the moon rose
upward, and the stars were
small and fair,
Then they slept on the long-slaked
ashes beneath the heavens
bare;
And the cold dawn came and they
wakened, and the King of the
Dwarf-kind seemed
As a thing of that wan land fashioned;
but Sigurd glowed and
gleamed
Amid the shadowless twilight by
Greyfell's cloudy flank,
As a little space they abided while the
latest star-world shrank;
On the backward road looked Regin
and heard how Sigurd drew
The girths of Greyfell's saddle, and
the voice of his sword he
knew
And he feared to look on the Volsung,
as thus he fell to speak:

"I have seen the Dwarf-folk mighty, I
have seen the God-folk weak;

And now, though our might be
minished, yet have we gifts to
give.

When men desire and conquer, most
sweet is their life to live;
When men are young and lovely
there is many a thing to do,
And sweet is their fond desire and the
dawn that springs anew."

"This gift," said the Son of Sigmund,
"the Norns shall give me yet,
And no blossom slain by the sunshine
while the leaves with dew are
wet."

Then Regin turned and beheld him:
"Thou shalt deem it hard and
strange,
When the hand hath encompassed it
all, and yet thy life must
change.
Ah, long were the lives of men-folk,
if betwixt the Gods and them
Were mighty warders watching mid
the earth's and the heaven's
hem!
Is there any man so mighty he would
cast this gift away,—
The heart's desire accomplished, and
life so long a day,
That the dawn should be forgotten ere
the even was begun?"

Then Sigurd laughed and answered:
"Fare forth, O glorious sun;

Bright end from bright beginning,
 and the mid-way good to tell,
And death, and deeds accomplished,
 and all remembered well!
Shall the day go past and leave us,
 and we be left with night,
To tread the endless circle, and strive
 in vain to smite?
But thou—wilt thou still look
 backward? thou sayst I know
 thy thought:
Thou hast whetted the sword for the
 slaying, it shall turn aside for
 nought.
Fear not! with the Gold and the
 wisdom thou shalt deem thee
 God alone,
And mayst do and undo at pleasure,
 nor be bound by right nor
 wrong:
And then, if no God I be waxen, I
 shall be the weak with the
 strong."

And his war-gear clanged and tinkled
 as he leapt to the saddle-stead:
And the sun rose up at their backs
 and the grey world changed to
 red.
And away to the west went Sigurd by
 the glory wreathed about,
But little and black was Regin as a
 fire that dieth out.
Day-long they rode the mountains by
 the crags exceeding old,
And the ash that the first of the
 Dwarf-kind found dull and

quenched and cold.
Then the moon in the mid-sky swam,
and the stars were fair and
pale,
And beneath the naked heaven they
slept in an ash-grey dale;
And again at the dawn-dusk's ending
they stood upon their feet,
And Sigurd donned his war-gear nor
his eyes would Regin meet.

A clear streak widened in heaven low
down above the earth;
And above it lay the cloud-flecks, and
the sun, anigh its birth,
Unseen, their hosts was staining with
the very hue of blood,
And ruddy by Greyfell's shoulder the
Son of Sigmund stood.

Then spake the Master of Masters:
"What is thine hope this morn
That thou dightest thee, O Sigurd, to
ride this world forlorn?"

"What needeth hope," said Sigurd,
"when the heart of the
Volsungs turns
To the light of the Glittering Heath,
and the house where the
Waster burns?
I shall slay the Foe of the Gods, as
thou badst me a while ago,
And then with the Gold and its
wisdom shalt thou be left
alone."

"O Child," said the King of the
Dwarf-kind, "when the day at
last comes round
For the dread and the Dusk of the
Gods, and the kin of the Wolf
is unbound,
When thy sword shall hew the fire,
and the wildfire beateth thy
shield,
Shalt thou praise the wages of hope
and the Gods that pitched the
field?"

"O Foe of the Gods," said Sigurd,
"wouldst thou hide the evil
thing,
And the curse that is greater than
thou, lest death end thy
labouring,
Lest the night should come upon thee
amidst thy toil for nought?
It is me, it is me that thou fearest, if
indeed I know thy thought;
Yea me, who would utterly light the
face of all good and ill,
If not with the fruitful beams that the
summer shall fulfill,
Then at least with the world a-
blazing, and the glare of the
grinded sword."

And he sprang aloft to the saddle as
he spake the latest word,
And the Wrath sang loud in the
sheath as it ne'er had sung
before,

And the cloudy flecks were scattered
like flames on the heaven's
floor,
And all was kindled at once, and that
trench of the mountains grey
Was filled with the living light as the
low sun lit the way:
But Regin turned from the glory with
blinded eyes and dazed,
And lo, on the cloudy war-steed how
another light there blazed,
And a great voice came from amidst
it:

"O Regin, in
good
sooth,

I have hearkened not nor heeded the
words of thy fear and thy ruth:
Thou hast told thy tale and thy
longing, and thereto I
hearkened well:—
Let it lead thee up to heaven, let it
lead thee down to hell,
The deed shall be done to-morrow:
thou shalt have that
measureless Gold,
And devour the garnered wisdom that
blessed thy realm of old,
That hath lain unspent and begrudged
in the very heart of hate:
With the blood and the might of thy
brother thine hunger shalt
thou sate;
And this deed shall be mine and
thine; but take heed for what
followeth then!

Let each do after his kind! I shall do
the deeds of men;
I shall harvest the field of their
sowing, in the bed of their
strewing shall sleep;
To them shall I give my life-days, to
the Gods my glory to keep.
But thou with the wealth and the
wisdom that the best of the
Gods might praise,
If thou shalt indeed excel them and
become the hope of the days,
Then me in turn hast thou conquered,
and I shall be in turn
Thy fashioned brand of the battle
through good and evil to burn,
Or the flame that sleeps in thy stithy
for the gathered winds to
blow,
When thou listest to do and undo and
thine uttermost cunning to
show.
But indeed I wot full surely that thou
shalt follow thy kind;
And for all that cometh after, the
Norns shall loose and bind."

Then his bridle-reins rang sweetly,
and the warding-walls of
death,
And Regin drew up to him, and the
Wrath sang loud in the sheath,
And forth from that trench in the
mountains by the westward
way they ride;
And little and black goes Regin by
the golden Volsung's side;

But no more his head is drooping, for
 he seeth the Elf-king's Gold;
The garnered might and the wisdom
 e'en now his eyes behold.

So up and up they journeyed, and
 ever as they went
About the cold-slaked forges, o'er
 many a cloud-swept bent,
Betwixt the walls of blackness, by
 shores of the fishless meres,
And the fathomless desert waters, did
 Regin cast his fears,
And wrap him in desire; and all alone
 he seemed
As a God to his heirship wending,
 and forgotten and undreamed
Was all the tale of Sigurd, and the
 folk he had toiled among,
And the Volsungs, Odin's children,
 and the men-folk fair and
 young.

So on they ride to the westward, and
 huge were the mountains
 grown
And the floor of heaven was mingled
 with that tossing world of
 stone:
And they rode till the noon was
 forgotten and the sun was
 waxen low,
And they tarried not, though he
 perished, and the world grew

dark below.
Then they rode a mighty desert, a
 glimmering place and wide,
And into a narrow pass high-walled
 on either side
By the blackness of the mountains,
 and barred aback and in face
By the empty night of the shadow; a
 windless silent place:
But the white moon shone o'erhead
 mid the small sharp stars and
 pale,
And each as a man alone they rode on
 the highway of bale.

So ever they wended upward, and the
 midnight hour was o'er,
And the stars grew pale and paler,
 and failed from the heaven's
 floor,
And the moon was a long while dead,
 but there was the promise of
 day,
No change came over the darkness,
 no streak of the dawning grey;
No sound of the wind's uprising
 adown the night there ran:
It was blind as the Gaping Gulf ere
 the first of the worlds began.

Then athwart and athwart rode Sigurd
 and sought the walls of the
 pass,

But found no wall before him; and
the road rang hard as brass
Beneath the hoofs of Greyfell, as up
and up he trod:
—Was it the daylight of Hell, or the
night of the doorways of God?

But lo, at the last a glimmer, and a
light from the west there
came,
And another and another, like points
of far-off flame;
And they grew and brightened and
gathered; and whiles together
they ran
Like the moonwake over the waters;
and whiles they were scant
and wan,
Some greater and some lesser, like
the boats of fishers laid
About the sea of midnight; and a
dusky dawn they made,
A faint and glimmering twilight: So
Sigurd strains his eyes,
And he sees how a land deserted all
round about him lies
More changeless than mid-ocean, as
fruitless as its floor:
Then the heart leaps up within him,
for he knows that his journey
is o'er,
And there he draweth bridle on the
first of the Glittering Heath:
And the Wrath is waxen merry and
sings in the golden sheath
As he leaps adown from Greyfell, and
stands upon his feet,

And wends his ways through the
twilight the Foe of the Gods
to meet.

Sigurd slayeth Fafnir the Serpent.

Nought Sigurd seeth of Regin, and
nought he heeds of him,
As in watchful might and glory he
strides the desert dim,
And behind him paceth Greyfell; but
he deems the time o'erlong
Till he meet the great gold-warden,
the over-lord of wrong.

So he wendeth midst the silence
through the measureless
desert place,
And beholds the countless glitter with
wise and steadfast face,
Till him-seems in a little season that
the flames grow somewhat
wan,
And a grey thing glimmers before
him, and becomes a mighty
man,
One-eyed and ancient-seeming, in
cloud-grey raiment clad;
A friendly man and glorious, and of
visage smiling-glad:
Then content in Sigurd groweth
because of his majesty,
And he heareth him speak in the
desert as the wind of the
winter sea:

"Hail Sigurd! Give me thy greeting
ere thy ways alone thou
wend!"

Said Sigurd: "Hail! I greet thee, my
friend and my fathers' friend."

"Now whither away," said the elder,
"with the Steed and the
ancient Sword?"

"To the greedy house," said Sigurd,
"and the King of the Heavy
Hoard."

"Wilt thou smite, O Sigurd, Sigurd?"
said the ancient mighty-one.

"Yea, yea, I shall smite," said the
Volsung, "save the Gods have
slain the sun."

"What wise wilt thou smite," said the
elder, "lest the dark devour
thy day?"

"Thou hast praised the sword," said
the child, "and the sword shall
find a way."

"Be learned of me," said the Wise-
one, "for I was the first of thy
folk."

Said the child: "I shall do thy bidding,
and for thee shall I strike the
stroke."

Spake the Wise-one: "Thus shalt thou
do when thou wendest hence
alone:

Thou shalt find a path in the desert,
and a road in the world of

stone;
It is smooth and deep and hollow, but
the rain hath riven it not,
And the wild wind hath not worn it,
for it is but Fafnir's slot,
Whereby he wends to the water and
the fathomless pool of old,
When his heart in the dawn is weary,
and he loathes the Ancient
Gold:
There think of the great and the
fathers, and bare the whetted
Wrath,
And dig a pit in the highway, and a
grave in the Serpent's path:
Lie thou therein, O Sigurd, and thine
hope from the glooming hide,
And be as the dead for a season, and
the living light abide!
And so shall thine heart avail thee,
and thy mighty fateful hand,
And the Light that lay in the
Branstock, the well beloved
brand."

Said the child: "I shall do thy bidding,
and for thee shall I strike the
stroke;
For I love thee, friend of my fathers,
Wise Heart of the holy folk."

So spake the Son of Sigmund, and
beheld no man anear,
And again was the night the
midnight, and the twinkling
flames shone clear

In the hush of the Glittering Heath;
 and alone went Sigmund's son
Till he came to the road of Fafnir, and
 the highway worn by one,
By the drift of the rain unfurrowed,
 by the windy years unrent,
And forth from the dark it came, and
 into the dark it went.

Great then was the heart of Sigurd,
 for there in the midmost he
 stayed,
And thought of the ancient fathers,
 and bared the bright blue
 blade,
That shone as a fleck of the day-light,
 and the night was all around.
Fair then was the Son of Sigmund as
 he toiled and laboured the
 ground;
Great, mighty he was in his working,
 and the Glittering Heath he
 clave,
And the sword shone blue before him
 as he dug the pit and the
 grave:
There he hid his hope from the night-
 tide and lay like one of the
 dead,
And wise and wary he bided; and the
 heavens hung over his head.

Now the night wanes over Sigurd,
 and the ruddy rings he sees,
And his war-gear's fair adornment,
 and the God-folk's images;

But a voice in the desert ariseth, a
 sound in the waste has birth,
A changing tinkle and clatter, as of
 gold dragged over the earth:
O'er Sigurd widens the day-light, and
 the sound is drawing close,
And speedier than the trample of
 speedy feet it goes;
But ever deemeth Sigurd that the sun
 brings back the day,
For the grave grows lighter and
 lighter and heaven o'erhead is
 grey.

But now, how the rattling waxeth till
 he may not heed nor hark!
And the day and the heavens are
 hidden, and o'er Sigurd rolls
 the dark,
As the flood of a pitchy river, and
 heavy-thick is the air
With the venom of hate long hoarded,
 and lies once fashioned fair:
Then a wan face comes from the
 darkness, and is wrought in
 manlike wise,
And the lips are writhed with laughter
 and bleared are the blinded
 eyes;
And it wandereth hither and thither,
 and searcheth through the
 grave
And departeth, leaving nothing, save
 the dark, rolled wave on wave
O'er the golden head of Sigurd and
 the edges of the sword,

And the world weighs heavy on
Sigurd, and the weary curse of
the Hoard:
Him-seemed the grave grew straiter,
and his hope of life grew chill,
And his heart by the Worm was
enfolded, and the bonds of the
Ancient Ill.

Then was Sigurd stirred by his glory,
and he strove with the
swaddling of Death;
He turned in the pit on the highway,
and the grave of the Glittering
Heath;
He laughed and smote with the
laughter and thrust up over his
head,
And smote the venom asunder, and
clave the heart of Dread;
Then he leapt from the pit and the
grave, and the rushing river of
blood,
And fulfilled with the joy of the War-
God on the face of earth he
stood
With red sword high uplifted, with
wrathful glittering eyes;
And he laughed at the heavens above
him for he saw the sun arise,
And Sigurd gleamed on the desert,
and shone in the new-born
light,
And the wind in his raiment wavered,
and all the world was bright.

But there was the ancient Fafnir, and
the Face of Terror lay
On the huddled folds of the Serpent,
that were black and ashen-
grey
In the desert lit by the sun; and those
twain looked each on each,
And forth from the Face of Terror
went a sound of dreadful
speech:

"Child, child, who art thou that hast
smitten? bright child, of
whence is thy birth?"

"I am called the Wild-thing Glorious,
and alone I wend on the
earth."

"Fierce child, and who was thy
father?—Thou hast cleft the
heart of the Foe!"

"Am I like to the sons of men-folk,
that my father I should
know?"

"Wert thou born of a nameless
wonder? shall the lies to my
death-day cling?"

"How lieth Sigurd the Volsung, and
the Son of Sigmund the
King?"

"O bitter father of Sigurd!—thou hast
cleft mine heart atwain!"

"I arose, and I wondered and wended,
and I smote, and I smote not
in vain."

"What master hath taught thee of
murder?—Thou hast wasted
Fafnir's day."

"I, Sigurd, knew and desired, and the
bright sword learned the way."

"Thee, thee shall the rattling Gold and
the red rings bring to the
bane."

"Yet mine hand shall cast them
abroad, and the earth shall
gather again."

"I see thee great in thine anger, and
the Norns thou heedest not."

"O Fafnir, speak of the Norns and the
wisdom unforgot!"

"Let the death-doomed flee from the
ocean, him the wind and the
weather shall drown."

"O Fafnir, tell of the Norns ere thy
life thou layest adown!"

"O manifold is their kindred, and who
shall tell them all?
There are they that rule o'er men-folk
and the stars that rise and fall:

—I knew of the folk of the Dwarfs,
 and I knew their Norns of old;
And I fought, and I fell in the
 morning, and I die afar from
 the gold:
—I have seen the Gods of heaven,
 and their Norns withal I
 know:
They love and withhold their helping,
 they hate and refrain the blow;
They curse and they may not sunder,
 they bless and they shall not
 blend;
They have fashioned the good and the
 evil; they abide the change
 and the end."

"O Fafnir, what of the Isle, and what
 hast thou known of its name,
Where the Gods shall mingle edges
 with Surt and the Sons of
 Flame?"

"O child, O Strong Compeller?
 Unshapen is its hight;
There the fallow blades shall be
 shaken and the Dark and the
 Day shall smite,
When the Bridge of the Gods is
 broken, and their white steeds
 swim the sea,
And the uttermost field is stricken,
 last strife of thee and me."

"What then shall endure, O Fafnir, the
 tale of the battle to tell?"

"I am blind, O Strong Compeller, in
the bonds of Death and Hell.
But thee shall the rattling Gold and
the red rings bring unto bane."

"Yet the rings mine hand shall scatter,
and the earth shall gather
again."

"Woe, woe! in the days passed over I
bore the Helm of Dread,
I reared the Face of Terror, and the
hoarded hate of the Dead:
I overcame and was mighty; I was
wise and cherished my heart
In the waste where no man wandered,
and the high house builded
apart:
Till I met thine hand, O Sigurd, and
thy might ordained from of
old;
And I fought and fell in the morning,
and I die far off from the
Gold."

Then Sigurd leaned on his sword, and
a dreadful voice went by
Like the wail of a God departing and
the War-God's misery;
And strong words of ancient wisdom
went by on the desert wind,
The words that mar and fashion, the
words that loose and bind;
And sounds of a strange lamenting,
and such strange things
bewailed,

That words to tell their meaning the
tongue of man hath failed.

Then all sank into silence, and the
Son of Sigmund stood
On the torn and furrowed desert by
the pool of Fafnir's blood,
And the Serpent lay before him, dead,
chilly, dull, and grey;
And over the Glittering Heath fair
shone the sun and the day,
And a light wind followed the sun
and breathed o'er the fateful
place,
As fresh as it furrows the sea-plain or
bows the acres' face.

Sigurd slayeth Regin the Master of Masters on the Glittering Heath.

There standeth Sigurd the Volsung,
and leaneth on his sword,
And beside him now is Greyfell and
looks on his golden lord,
And the world is awake and living;
and whither now shall they
wend,
Who have come to the Glittering
Heath, and wrought that deed
to its end?
For hither comes Regin the Master
from the skirts of the field of
death,
And he shadeth his eyes from the
sunlight as afoot he goeth and
saith:
"Ah, let me live for a while! for a
while and all shall be well,

When passed is the house of murder
and I creep from the prison of
hell."

Afoot he went o'er the desert, and he
came unto Sigurd and stared
At the golden gear of the man, and
the Wrath yet bloody and
bared,
And the light locks raised by the
wind, and the eyes beginning
to smile,
And the lovely lips of the Volsung,
and the brow that knew no
guile;
And he murmured under his breath
while his eyes grew white
with wrath:

"O who art thou, and wherefore, and
why art thou in the path?"
Then he turned to the ash-grey
Serpent, and grovelled low on
the ground,
And he drank of that pool of the
blood where the stones of the
wild were drowned,
And long he lapped as a dog; but
when he arose again,
Lo, a flock of the mountain-eagles
that drew to the feastful plain;
And he turned and looked on Sigurd,
as bright in the sun he stood,
A stripling fair and slender, and
wiped the Wrath of the blood.

But Regin cried: "O Dwarf-kind, O
many-shifting folk,
O shapes of might and wonder, am I
too freed from the yoke,
That binds my soul to my body a
withered thing forlorn,
While the short-lived fools of man-
folk so fair and oft are born?
Now swift in the air shall I be, and
young in the concourse of
kings,
If my heart shall come to desire the
gain of earthly things."

And he looked and saw how Sigurd
was sheathing the Flame of
War,
And the eagles screamed in the wind,
but their voice came faint
from afar:
Then he scowled, and crouched and
darkened, and came to Sigurd
and spake:
"O child, thou hast slain my brother,
and the Wrath is alive and
awake."

"Thou sayest sooth," said Sigurd, "thy
deed and mine is done:
But now our ways shall sunder, for
here, meseemeth, the sun
Hath but little of deeds to do, and no
love to win aback."

Then Regin crouched before him, and
he spake: "Fare on to the
wrack!"

Fare on to the murder of men, and the
deeds of thy kindred of old!
And surely of thee as of them shall
the tale be speedily told.
Thou hast slain thy Master's brother,
and what wouldst thou say
thereto,
Were the judges met for the judging
and the doom-ring hallowed
due?"

Then Sigurd spake as aforetime: "Thy
deed and mine it was,
And now our ways shall sunder, and
into the world will I pass."

But Regin darkened before him, and
exceeding grim was he grown,
And he spake: "Thou hast slain my
brother, and wherewith wilt
thou atone?"

"Stand up, O Master," said Sigurd, "O
Singer of ancient days,
And take the wealth I have won thee,
ere we wend on the sundering
ways.
I have toiled and thou hast desired,
and the Treasure is surely
anear,
And thou hast wisdom to find it, and I
have slain thy fear."

But Regin crouched and darkened:
"Thou hast slain my brother,"
he said.

"Take thou the Gold," quoth Sigurd,
"for the ransom of my head!"

Then Regin crouched and darkened,
and over the earth he hung;
And he said: "Thou hast slain my
brother, and the Gods are yet
but young."

Bright Sigurd towered above him,
and the Wrath cried out in the
sheath,
And Regin writhed against it as the
adder turns on death;
And he spake: "Thou hast slain my
brother, and to-day shalt thou
be my thrall:
Yea a King shall be my cook-boy and
this heath my cooking-hall."

Then he crept to the ash-grey coils
where the life of his brother
had lain,
And he drew a glaive from his side
and smote the smitten and
slain,
And tore the heart from Fafnir, while
the eagles cried o'erhead,
And sharp and shrill was their voice
o'er the entrails of the dead.

Then Regin spake to Sigurd: "Of this
slaying wilt thou be free?
Then gather thou fire together and
roast the heart for me,
That I may eat it and live, and be thy
master and more;

For therein was might and wisdom,
and the grudged and hoarded
lore:—
—Or else, depart on thy ways afraid
from the Glittering Heath."

Then he fell abackward and slept, nor
set his sword in the sheath,
But his hand was red on the hilts and
blue were the edges bared,
Ash-grey was his visage waxen, and
with open eyes he stared
On the height of heaven above him,
and a fearful thing he seemed,
As his soul went wide in the world,
and of rule and kingship he
dreamed.

But Sigurd took the Heart, and wood
on the waste he found,
The wood that grew and died, as it
crept on the niggard ground,
And grew and died again, and lay like
whitened bones;
And the ernes cried over his head, as
he builded his hearth of
stones,
And kindled the fire for cooking, and
sat and sang o'er the roast
The song of his fathers of old, and the
Wolflings' gathering host:
So there on the Glittering Heath rose
up the little flame,
And the dry sticks crackled amidst it,
and alow the eagles came,
And seven they were by tale, and
they pitched all round about

The cooking-fire of Sigurd, and sent
their song-speech out:
But nought he knoweth its wisdom,
or the word that they would
speak:
And hot grew the Heart of Fafnir and
sang amid the reek.

Then Sigurd looketh on Regin, and he
deemeth it overlong
That he dighteth the dear-bought
morsel, and the might for the
Master of wrong,
So he reacheth his hand to the roast to
see if the cooking be o'er;
But the blood and the fat seethed
from it and scalded his finger
sore,
And he set his hand to his mouth to
quench the fleshly smart,
And he tasted the flesh of the Serpent
and the blood of Fafnir's
Heart:
Then there came a change upon him,
for the speech of fowl he
knew,
And wise in the ways of the beast-
kind as the Dwarfs of old he
grew;
And he knitted his brows and
hearkened, and wrath in his
heart arose;
For he felt beset of evil in a world of
many foes.
But the hilt of the Wrath he handled,
and Regin's heart he saw,

And how that the Foe of the Gods the
net of death would draw;
And his bright eyes flashed and
sparkled, and his mouth grew
set and stern
As he hearkened the voice of the
eagles, and their song began
to learn.

For the first cried out in the desert:
"O mighty Sigmund's son,
How long wilt thou sit and tarry now
the dear-bought roast is
done?"

And the second: "Volsung, arise! for
the horns blow up to the hall,
And dight are the purple hangings,
and the King to the feasting
should fall."

And the third: "How great is the feast
if the eater eat aright
The Heart of the wisdom of old and
the after-world's delight!"

And the fourth: "Yea what of Regin?
shall he scatter wrack o'er the
world?
Shall the father be slain by the son,
and the brother 'gainst brother
be hurled?"

And the fifth: "He hath taught a
stripling the gifts of a God to
give:

He hath reared up a King for the
slaying, that he alone might
live."

And the sixth: "He shall waken
mighty as a God that scorneth
a truth;
He hath drunk of the blood of the
Serpent, and drowned all hope
and ruth."

And the seventh: "Arise, O Sigurd,
lest the hour be overlate!
For the sun in the mid-noon shineth,
and swift is the hand of Fate:
Arise! lest the world run backward
and the blind heart have its
will,
And once again be tangled the
sundered good and ill;
Lest love and hatred perish, lest the
world forget its tale,
And the Gods sit deedless, dreaming,
in the high-walled heavenly
vale."

Then swift ariseth Sigurd, and the
Wrath in his hand is bare,
And he looketh, and Regin sleepeth,
and his eyes wide-open glare;
But his lips smile false in his
dreaming, and his hand is on
the sword;
For he dreams himself the Master and
the new world's fashioning-
lord.

And his dream hath forgotten Sigurd,
and the King's life lies in the
pit;
He is nought; Death gnaweth upon
him, while the Dwarfs in
mastery sit.

But lo, how the eyes of Sigurd the
heart of the guileful behold,
And great is Allfather Odin, and
upriseth the Curse of the
Gold,
And the Branstock bloometh to
heaven from the ancient
wondrous root;
The summer hath shone on its
blossoms, and Sigurd's Wrath
is the fruit:
Dread then he cried in the desert:
"Guile-master, lo thy deed!
Hast thou nurst my life for
destruction, and my death to
serve thy need?
Hast thou kept me here for the net
and the death that tame things
die?
Hast thou feared me overmuch, thou
Foe of the Gods on high?
Lest the sword thine hand was
wielding should turn about
and cleave
The tangled web of nothing thou
hadst wearied thyself to
weave.
Lo here the sword and the stroke!
judge the Norns betwixt us
twain!

But for me, I will live and die not, nor
shall all my hope be vain."
Then his second stroke struck Sigurd,
for the Wrath flashed thin and
white,
And 'twixt head and trunk of Regin
fierce ran the fateful light;
And there lay brother by brother a
faded thing and wan.
But Sigurd cried in the desert: "So far
have I wended on!
Dead are the foes of God-home that
would blend the good and the
ill;
And the World shall yet be famous,
and the Gods shall have their
will.
Nor shall I be dead and forgotten,
while the earth grows worse
and worse,
With the blind heart king o'er the
people, and binding curse
with curse."

How Sigurd took to him the Treasure of the Elf Andvari.

Now Sigurd eats of the heart that
once in the Dwarf-king lay,
The hoard of the wisdom begrudged,
the might of the earlier day.
Then wise of heart was he waxen, but
longing in him grew
To sow the seed he had gotten, and
till the field he knew.
So he leapeth aback of Greyfell, and
rideth the desert bare,

And the hollow slot of Fafnir, that led
to the Serpent's lair.
Then long he rode adown it, and the
ernes flew overhead,
And tidings great and glorious of that
Treasure of old they said.
So far o'er the waste he wended, and
when the night was come
He saw the earth-old dwelling, the
dread Gold-wallower's home:
On the skirts of the Heath it was
builded by a tumbled stony
bent;
High went that house to the heavens,
down 'neath the earth it went,
Of unwrought iron fashioned for the
heart of a greedy king:
'Twas a mountain, blind without, and
within was its plenishing
But the Hoard of Andvari the ancient,
and the sleeping Curse
unseen,
The Gold of the Gods that spared not
and the greedy that have been.
Through the door strode Sigurd the
Volsung, and the grey moon
and the sword
Fell in on the tawny gold-heaps of the
ancient hapless Hoard:
Gold gear of hosts unburied, and the
coin of cities dead,
Great spoil of the ages of battle, lay
there on the Serpent's bed:
Huge blocks from mid-earth quarried,
where none but the Dwarfs
have mined,

Wide sands of the golden rivers no
 foot of man may find
Lay 'neath the spoils of the mighty
 and the ruddy rings of yore:
But amidst was the Helm of Aweing
 that the Fear of earth-folk
 bore,
And there gleamed a wonder beside
 it, the Hauberk all of gold,
Whose like is not in the heavens nor
 has earth of its fellow told:
There Sigurd seeth moreover
 Andvari's Ring of Gain,
The hope of Loki's finger, the
 Ransom's utmost grain;
For it shone on the midmost gold-
 heap like the first star set in
 the sky
In the yellow space of even when
 moon-rise draweth anigh.
Then laughed the Son of Sigmund,
 and stooped to the golden
 land,
And gathered that first of the harvest
 and set it on his hand;
And he did on the Helm of Aweing,
 and the Hauberk all of gold,
Whose like is not in the heavens nor
 has earth of its fellow told:
Then he praised the day of the
 Volsungs amid the yellow
 light,
And he set his hand to the labour and
 put forth his kingly might;
He dragged forth gold to the moon,
 on the desert's face he laid

The innermost earth's adornment, and
rings for the nameless made;
He toiled and loaded Greyfell, and
the cloudy war-steed shone
And the gear of Sigurd rattled in the
flood of moonlight wan;
There he toiled and loaded Greyfell,
and the Volsung's armour rang
Mid the yellow bed of the Serpent:
but without the eagles sang:

"Bind the red rings, O Sigurd! let the
gold shine free and clear!
For what hath the Son of the Volsungs
the ancient Curse to fear?"

"Bind the red rings, O Sigurd! for thy
tale is well begun,
And the world shall be good and
gladdened by the Gold lit up
by the sun."

"Bind the red rings, O Sigurd, and
gladden all thine heart!
For the world shall make thee merry
ere thou and she depart."

"Bind the red rings, O Sigurd! for the
ways go green below,
Go green to the dwelling of Kings,
and the halls that the Queen-
folk know."

"Bind the red rings, O Sigurd! for
what is there bides by the
way,
Save the joy of folk to awaken, and
the dawn of the merry day?"

"Bind the red rings, O Sigurd! for the
strife awaits thine hand,
And a plenteous war-field's reaping,
and the praise of many a
land."

"Bind the red rings, O Sigurd! But
how shall store-house hold
That glory of thy winning and the
tidings to be told?"

Now the moon was dead, and the
star-worlds were great on the
heavenly plain,
When the steed was fully laden; then
Sigurd taketh the rein
And turns to the ruined rock-wall that
the lair was built beneath,
For there he deemed was the gate and
the door of the Glittering
Heath,
But not a whit moved Greyfell for
aught that the King might do;
Then Sigurd pondered a while, till the
heart of the beast he knew,
And clad in all his war-gear he leaped
to the saddle-stead,
And with pride and mirth neighed
Greyfell and tossed aloft his
head,

And sprang unspurred o'er the waste,
and light and swift he went,
And breasted the broken rampart, the
stony tumbled bent;
And over the brow he clomb, and
there beyond was the world,
A place of many mountains and great
crag together hurled.
So down to the west he wendeth, and
goeth swift and light,
And the stars are beginning to wane,
and the day is mingled with
night;
For full fain was the sun to arise and
look on the Gold set free,
And the Dwarf-wrought rings of the
Treasure and the gifts from
the floor of the sea.

How Sigurd awoke Brynhild upon Hindfell.

By long roads rideth Sigurd amidst
that world of stone,
And somewhat south he turneth; for
he would not be alone,
But longs for the dwellings of man-
folk, and the kingly people's
speech,
And the days of the glee and the
joyance, where men laugh
each to each.
But still the desert endureth, and afar
must Greyfell fare
From the wrack of the Glittering
Heath, and Fafnir's golden
lair.

Long Sigurd rideth the waste, when,
 lo, on a morning of day
From out of the tangled crag-walls,
 amidst the cloud-land grey
Comes up a mighty mountain, and it
 is as though there burns
A torch amidst of its cloud-wreath; so
 thither Sigurd turns,
For he deems indeed from its topmost
 to look on the best of the
 earth;
And Greyfell neigheth beneath him,
 and his heart is full of mirth.

So he rideth higher and higher, and
 the light grows great and
 strange,
And forth from the clouds it flickers,
 till at noon they gather and
 change,
And settle thick on the mountain, and
 hide its head from sight;
But the winds in a while are
 awakened, and day bettereth
 ere the night,
And, lifted a measureless mass o'er
 the desert crag-walls high,
Cloudless the mountain riseth against
 the sunset sky,
The sea of the sun grown golden, as it
 ebbs from the day's desire;
And the light that afar was a torch is
 grown a river of fire,
And the mountain is black above it,
 and below is it dark and dun;
And there is the head of Hindfell as
 an island in the sun.

Night falls, but yet rides Sigurd, and
hath no thought of rest,
For he longs to climb that rock-world
and behold the earth at its
best;
But now mid the maze of the foot-
hills he seeth the light no
more,
And the stars are lovely and gleaming
on the lightless heavenly
floor.
So up and up he wendeth till the night
is wearing thin;
And he rideth a rift of the mountain,
and all is dark therein,
Till the stars are dimmed by dawning
and the wakening world is
cold;
Then afar in the upper rock-wall a
breach doth he behold,
And a flood of light poured inward
the doubtful dawning blinds:
So swift he rideth thither and the
mouth of the breach he finds,
And sitteth awhile on Greyfell on the
marvellous thing to gaze:
For lo, the side of Hindfell
enwrapped by the fervent
blaze,
And nought 'twixt earth and heaven
save a world of flickering
flame,
And a hurrying shifting tangle, where
the dark rents went and came.

Great groweth the heart of Sigurd
 with uttermost desire,
And he crieth kind to Greyfell, and
 they hasten up, and nigher,
Till he draweth rein in the dawning
 on the face of Hindfell's steep:
But who shall heed the dawning
 where the tongues of that
 wildfire leap?
For they weave a wavering wall, that
 driveth over the heaven
The wind that is born within it; nor
 ever aside is it driven
By the mightiest wind of the waste,
 and the rain-flood amidst it is
 nought;
And no wayfarer's door and no
 window the hand of its builder
 hath wrought.
But thereon is the Volsung smiling as
 its breath uplifteth his hair,
And his eyes shine bright with its
 image, and his mail gleams
 white and fair,
And his war-helm pictures the
 heavens and the waning stars
 behind:
But his neck is Greyfell stretching to
 snuff at the flame-wall blind,
And his cloudy flank upheaveth, and
 tinkleth the knitted mail,
And the gold of the uttermost waters
 is waxen wan and pale.

Now Sigurd turns in his saddle, and
 the hilt of the Wrath he shifts,

And draws a girth the tighter; then the
gathered reins he lifts,
And crieth aloud to Greyfell, and
rides at the wildfire's heart;
But the white wall wavers before him
and the flame-flood rusheth
apart,
And high o'er his head it riseth, and
wide and wild is its roar
As it beareth the mighty tidings to the
very heavenly floor:
But he rideth through its roaring as
the warrior rides the rye,
When it bows with the wind of the
summer and the hid spears
draw anigh;
The white flame licks his raiment and
sweeps through Greyfell's
mane,
And bathes both hands of Sigurd and
the hilts of Fafnir's bane,
And winds about his war-helm and
mingles with his hair,
But nought his raiment dusketh or
dims his glittering gear;
Then it fails and fades and darkens
till all seems left behind,
And dawn and the blaze is swallowed
in mid-mirk stark and blind.

But forth a little further and a little
further on
And all is calm about him, and he
sees the scorched earth wan

Beneath a glimmering twilight, and
 he turns his conquering eyes,
And a ring of pale slaked ashes on the
 side of Hindfell lies;
And the world of the waste is beyond
 it; and all is hushed and grey,
And the new-risen moon is a-paleing,
 and the stars grow faint with
 day.

Then Sigurd looked before him and a
 Shield-burg there he saw,
A wall of the tiles of Odin wrought
 clear without a flaw,
The gold by the silver gleaming, and
 the ruddy by the white;
And the blazonings of their glory
 were done upon them bright,
As of dear things wrought for the
 war-lords new come to Odin's
 hall.

Piled high aloft to the heavens uprose
 that battle-wall,
And far o'er the topmost shield-rim
 for a banner of fame there
 hung
A glorious golden buckler; and
 against the staff it rung
As the earliest wind of dawning
 uprose on Hindfell's face
And the light from the yellowing east
 beamed soft on the shielded
 place.

But the Wrath cried out in answer as
 Sigurd leapt adown
To the wasted soil of the desert by
 that rampart of renown;

He looked but little beneath it, and
the dwelling of God it
seemed,
As against its gleaming silence the
eager Sigurd gleamed:
He draweth not sword from scabbard,
as the wall he wendeth
around,
And it is but the wind and Sigurd that
wakeneth any sound:
But, lo, to the gate he cometh, and the
doors are open wide,
And no warder the way withstandeth,
and no earls by the threshold
abide;
So he stands awhile and marvels;
then the baleful light of the
Wrath
Gleams bare in his ready hand as he
wendeth the inward path:
For he doubteth some guile of the
Gods, or perchance some
Dwarf-king's snare,
Or a mock of the Giant people that
shall fade in the morning air:
But he getteth him in and gazeth; and
a wall doth he behold,
And the ruddy set by the white, and
the silver by the gold;
But within the garth that it girdeth no
work of man is set,
But the utmost head of Hindfell
ariseth higher yet;
And below in the very midmost is a
Giant-fashioned mound,
Piled high as the rims of the Shield-
burg above the level ground;

And there, on that mound of the
Giants, o'er the wilderness
forlorn,
A pale grey image lieth, and gleameth
in the morn.

So there was Sigurd alone; and he
went from the shielded door,
And aloft in the desert of wonder the
Light of the Branstock he
bore;
And he set his face to the earth-
mound, and beheld the image
wan,
And the dawn was growing about it;
and, lo, the shape of a man
Set forth to the eyeless desert on the
tower-top of the world,
High over the cloud-wrought castle
whence the windy bolts are
hurled.

Now he comes to the mound and
climbs it, and will see if the
man be dead;
Some King of the days forgotten laid
there with crownèd head,
Or the frame of a God, it may be, that
in heaven hath changed his
life,
Or some glorious heart belovèd, God-
rapt from the earthly strife:
Now over the body he standeth, and
seeth it shapen fair,

And clad from head to foot-sole in
pale grey-glittering gear,
In a hauberk wrought as straitly as
though to the flesh it were
grown:
But a great helm hideth the head and
is girt with a glittering crown.

So thereby he stoopeth and kneeleth,
for he deems it were good
indeed
If the breath of life abide there and
the speech to help at need;
And as sweet as the summer wind
from a garden under the sun
Cometh forth on the topmost Hindfell
the breath of that sleeping-
one.

Then he saith he will look on the
face, if it bear him love or
hate,
Or the bonds for his life's
constraining, or the sundering
doom of fate.

So he draweth the helm from the
head, and, lo, the brow snow-
white,

And the smooth unfurrowed cheeks,
and the wise lips breathing
light;

And the face of a woman it is, and the
fairest that ever was born,
Shown forth to the empty heavens
and the desert world forlorn:
But he looketh, and loveth her sore,
and he longeth her spirit to
move,

And awaken her heart to the world,
that she may behold him and
love.

And he toucheth her breast and her
hands, and he loveth her
passing sore;

And he saith: "Awake! I am Sigurd;"
but she moveth never the
more.

Then he looked on his bare bright
blade, and he said: "Thou—
what wilt thou do?

For indeed as I came by the war-garth
thy voice of desire I knew."

Bright burnt the pale blue edges for
the sunrise drew anear,

And the rims of the Shield-burg
glittered, and the east was
exceeding clear:

So the eager edges he setteth to the
Dwarf-wrought battle-coat

Where the hammered ring-knit collar
constraineth the woman's
throat;

But the sharp Wrath biteth and
rendeth, and before it fail the
rings,

And, lo, the gleam of the linen, and
the light of golden things:

Then he driveth the blue steel
onward, and through the skirt,
and out,

Till nought but the rippling linen is
wrapping her about;

Then he deems her breath comes
quicker and her breast begins

to heave,
So he turns about the War-Flame and
 rends down either sleeve,
Till her arms lie white in her raiment,
 and a river of sun-bright hair
Flows free o'er bosom and shoulder
 and floods the desert bare.

Then a flush cometh over her visage
 and a sigh upheaveth her
 breast,
And her eyelids quiver and open, and
 she wakeneth into rest;
Wide-eyed on the dawning she
 gazeth, too glad to change or
 smile,
And but little moveth her body, nor
 speaketh she yet for a while;
And yet kneels Sigurd moveless her
 wakening speech to heed,
While soft the waves of the daylight
 o'er the starless heavens
 speed,
And the gleaming rims of the Shield-
 burg yet bright and brighter
 grow,
And the thin moon hangeth her horns
 dead-white in the golden
 glow.
Then she turned and gazed on Sigurd,
 and her eyes met the
 Volsung's eyes.
And mighty and measureless now did
 the tide of his love arise,
For their longing had met and
 mingled, and he knew of her
 heart that she loved,

As she spake unto nothing but him
and her lips with the speech-
flood moved:

"O, what is the thing so mighty that
my weary sleep hath torn,
And rent the fallow bondage, and the
wan woe over-worn?"

He said: "The hand of Sigurd and the
Sword of Sigmund's son,
And the heart that the Volsungs
fashioned this deed for thee
have done."

But she said: "Where then is Odin
that laid me here alow?
Long lasteth the grief of the world,
and man-folk's tangled woe!"

"He dwelleth above," said Sigurd,
"but I on the earth abide,
And I came from the Glittering Heath
the waves of thy fire to ride."

But therewith the sun rose upward
and lightened all the earth,
And the light flashed up to the
heavens from the rims of the
glorious girth;
But they twain arose together, and
with both her palms
outspread,
And bathed in the light returning, she
cried aloud and said:

"All hail O Day and thy Sons, and thy
 kin of the coloured things!
Hail, following Night, and thy
 Daughter that leadeth thy
 wavering wings!
Look down with unangry eyes on us
 to-day alive,
And give us the hearts victorious, and
 the gain for which we strive!
All hail, ye Lords of God-home, and
 ye Queens of the House of
 Gold!
Hail thou dear Earth that bearest, and
 thou Wealth of field and fold!
Give us, your noble children, the
 glory of wisdom and speech,
And the hearts and the hands of
 healing, and the mouths and
 hands that teach!"

Then they turned and were knit
 together; and oft and o'er
 again
They craved, and kissed rejoicing,
 and their hearts were full and
 fain.

Then Sigurd looketh upon her, and
 the words from his heart arise:
"Thou art the fairest of earth, and the
 wisest of the wise;
O who art thou that lovest? I am
 Sigurd, e'en as I told;
I have slain the Foe of the Gods, and
 gotten the Ancient Gold;
And great were the gain of thy love,
 and the gift of mine earthly

days,
If we twain should never sunder as
we wend on the changing
ways.
O who art thou that lovest, thou
fairest of all things born?
And what meaneth thy sleep and thy
slumber in the wilderness
forlorn?"

She said: "I am she that loveth: I was
born of the earthly folk,
But of old Allfather took me from the
Kings and their wedding
yoke:
And he called me the Victory-Wafer,
and I went and came as he
would,
And I chose the slain for his war-host,
and the days were glorious
and good,
Till the thoughts of my heart
overcame me, and the pride of
my wisdom and speech,
And I scorned the earth-folk's Framer
and the Lord of the world I
must teach:
For the death-doomed I caught from
the sword, and the fated life I
slew,
And I deemed that my deeds were
goodly, and that long I should
do and undo.
But Allfather came against me and
the God in his wrath arose;
And he cried: 'Thou hast thought in
thy folly that the Gods have

friends and foes,
That they wake, and the world wends
onward, that they sleep, and
the world slips back,
That they laugh, and the world's weal
waxeth, that they frown and
fashion the wrack:
Thou hast cast up the curse against
me; it shall fall aback on thine
head;
Go back to the sons of repentance,
with the children of sorrow
wed!
For the Gods are great unholpen, and
their grief is seldom seen,
And the wrong that they will and
must be is soon as it hath not
been.'

"Yet I thought: 'Shall I wed in the
world, shall I gather grief on
the earth?
Then the fearless heart shall I wed,
and bring the best to birth,
And fashion such tales for the telling,
that Earth shall be holpen at
least,
If the Gods think scorn of its fairness,
as they sit at the changeless
feast.'

"Then somewhat smiled Allfather;
and he spake: 'So let it be!
The doom thereof abideth; the doom
of me and thee.
Yet long shall the time pass over ere
thy waking-day be born:

Fare forth, and forget and be weary
 'neath the Sting of the
Sleepful Thorn!

"So I came to the head of Hindfell
 and the ruddy shields and
 white,
And the wall of the wildfire wavering
 around the isle of night;
And there the Sleep-thorn pierced
 me, and the slumber on me
 fell,
And the night of nameless sorrows
 that hath no tale to tell.
Now I am she that loveth; and the day
 is nigh at hand
When I, who have ridden the sea-
 realm and the regions of the
 land,
And dwelt in the measureless
 mountains and the forge of
 stormy days,
Shall dwell in the house of my fathers
 and the land of the people's
 praise;
And there shall hand meet hand, and
 heart by heart shall beat,
And the lying-down shall be joyous,
 and the morn's uprising sweet.
Lo now, I look on thine heart and
 behold of thine inmost will,
That thou of the days wouldst
 hearken that our portion shall
 fulfill;
But O, be wise of man-folk, and the
 hope of thine heart refrain!

As oft in the battle's beginning ye vex
the steed with the rein,
Lest at last in its latter ending, when
the sword hath hushed the
horn,
His limbs should be weary and fail,
and his might be over-worn.
O be wise, lest thy love constrain me,
and my vision wax o'er-clear,
And thou ask of the thing that thou
shouldst not, and the thing
that thou wouldst not hear.

"Know thou, most mighty of men,
that the Norns shall order all,
And yet without thine helping shall
no whit of their will befall;
Be wise! 'tis a marvel of words, and a
mock for the fool and the
blind;
But I saw it writ in the heavens, and
its fashioning there did I find:
And the night of the Norns and their
slumber, and the tide when the
world runs back,
And the way of the sun is tangled, it
is wrought of the dastard's
lack.
But the day when the fair earth
blossoms, and the sun is
bright above,
Of the daring deeds is it fashioned
and the eager hearts of love.

"Be wise, and cherish thine hope in
the freshness of the days,
And scatter its seed from thine hand
in the field of the people's
praise;
Then fair shall it fall in the furrow,
and some the earth shall
speed,
And the sons of men shall marvel at
the blossom of the deed:
But some the earth shall speed not;
nay rather, the wind of the
heaven
Shall waft it away from thy longing
—and a gift to the Gods hast
thou given,
And a tree for the roof and the wall in
the house of the hope that
shall be,
Though it seemeth our very sorrow,
and the grief of thee and me.

"Strive not with the fools of man-
folk: for belike thou shalt
overcome;
And what then is the gain of thine
hunting when thou bearest the
quarry home?
Or else shall the fool overcome thee,
and what deed thereof shall
grow?
Nay, strive with the wise man rather,
and increase thy woe and his
woe;
Yet thereof a gain hast thou gotten;
and the half of thine heart hast
thou won

If thou mayst prevail against him, and
his deeds are the deeds thou
hast done:

Yea, and if thou fall before him, in
him shalt thou live again,
And thy deeds in his hand shall
blossom, and his heart of
thine heart shall be fain.

"When thou hearest the fool
rejoicing, and he saith, 'It is
over and past,
And the wrong was better than right,
and hate turns into love at the
last,
And we strove for nothing at all, and
the Gods are fallen asleep;
For so good is the world a growing
that the evil good shall reap:'
Then loosen thy sword in the
scabbard and settle the helm
on thine head,
For men betrayed are mighty, and
great are the wrongfully dead.

"Wilt thou do the deed and repent it?
thou hadst better never been
born:

Wilt thou do the deed and exalt it?
then thy fame shall be
outworn:

Thou shalt do the deed and abide it,
and sit on thy throne on high,
And look on to-day and to-morrow as
those that never die.

"Love thou the Gods—and withstand
 them, lest thy fame should fail
 in the end,
And thou be but their thrall and their
 bondsman, who wert born for
 their very friend:
For few things from the Gods are
 hidden, and the hearts of men
 they know,
And how that none rejoiceth to quail
 and crouch alow.

"I have spoken the words, beloved, to
 thy matchless glory and
 worth;
But thy heart to my heart hath been
 speaking, though my tongue
 hath set it forth:
For I am she that loveth, and I know
 what thou wouldst teach
From the heart of thine unlearned
 wisdom, and I needs must
 speak thy speech."

Then words were weary and silent,
 but oft and o'er again
They craved and kissed rejoicing, and
 their hearts were full and fain.

Then spake the Son of Sigmund:
 "Fairest, and most of worth,
Hast thou seen the ways of man-folk
 and the regions of the earth?
Then speak yet more of wisdom; for
 most meet meseems it is
That my soul to thy soul be shapen,
 and that I should know thy

bliss."

So she took his right hand meekly,
nor any word would say,
Not e'en of love or praising, his
longing to delay;
And they sat on the side of Hindfell,
and their fain eyes looked and
loved,
As she told of the hidden matters
whereby the world is moved:
And she told of the framing of all
things, and the houses of the
heaven;
And she told of the star-worlds'
courses, and how the winds be
driven;
And she told of the Norns and their
names, and the fate that
abideth the earth;
And she told of the ways of King-folk
in their anger and their mirth;
And she spake of the love of women,
and told of the flame that
burns,
And the fall of mighty houses, and
the friend that falters and
turns,
And the lurking blinded vengeance,
and the wrong that amendeth
wrong,
And the hand that repenteth its stroke,
and the grief that endureth for
long;
And how man shall bear and forbear,
and be master of all that is;

And how man shall measure it all, the
wrath, and the grief, and the
bliss.

"I saw the body of Wisdom, and of
shifting guise was she
wrought,
And I stretched out my hands to hold
her, and a mote of the dust
they caught;
And I prayed her to come for my
teaching, and she came in the
midnight dream—
And I woke and might not remember,
nor betwixt her tangle deem:
She spake, and how might I hearken;
I heard, and how might I
know;
I knew, and how might I fashion, or
her hidden glory show?
All things I have told thee of Wisdom
are but fleeting images
Of her hosts that abide in the
Heavens, and her light that
Allfather sees:
Yet wise is the sower that sows, and
wise is the reaper that reaps,
And wise is the smith in his smiting,
and wise is the warder that
keeps:
And wise shalt thou be to deliver, and
I shall be wise to desire;
—And lo, the tale that is told, and the
sword and the wakening fire!
Lo now, I am she that loveth, and
hark how Greyfell neighs,

And Fafnir's Bed is gleaming, and
 green go the downward ways.
The road to the children of men and
 the deeds that thou shalt do
In the joy of thy life-days' morning,
 when thine hope is fashioned
 anew.
Come now, O Bane of the Serpent,
 for now is the high-noon
 come,
And the sun hangeth over Hindfell
 and looks on the earth-folk's
 home;
But the soul is so great within thee,
 and so glorious are thine eyes,
And me so love constraineth, and
 mine heart that was called the
 wise,
That we twain may see men's
 dwellings and the house
 where we shall dwell,
And the place of our life's beginning,
 where the tale shall be to tell."

So they climb the burg of Hindfell,
 and hand in hand they fare,
Till all about and above them is
 nought but the sunlit air,
And there close they cling together
 rejoicing in their mirth;
For far away beneath them lie the
 kingdoms of the earth,
And the garths of men-folk's
 dwellings and the streams that
 water them,
And the rich and plenteous acres, and
 the silver ocean's hem,

And the woodland wastes and the
 mountains, and all that
 holdeth all;
The house and the ship and the
 island, the loom and the mine
 and the stall,
The beds of bane and healing, the
 crafts that slay and save,
The temple of God and the Doom-
 ring, the cradle and the grave.

Then spake the Victory-Wafer: "O
 King of the Earthly Age,
As a God thou beholdest the treasure
 and the joy of thine heritage,
And where on the wings of his hope
 is the spirit of Sigurd borne?
Yet I bid thee hover awhile as a lark
 alow on the corn;
Yet I bid thee look on the land 'twixt
 the wood and the silver sea
In the bight of the swirling river, and
 the house that cherished me!
There dwelleth mine earthly sister
 and the king that she hath
 wed;
There morn by morn aforetime I
 woke on the golden bed;
There eve by eve I tarried mid the
 speech and the lays of kings;
There noon by noon I wandered and
 plucked the blossoming
 things;
The little land of Lymdale by the
 swirling river's side,
Where Brynhild once was I called in
 the days ere my father died;

The little land of Lymdale 'twixt the
woodland and the sea,
Where on thee mine eyes shall
brighten and thine eyes shall
beam on me."

"I shall seek thee there," said Sigurd,
"when the day-spring is
begun,
Ere we wend the world together in
the season of the sun."

"I shall bide thee there," said
Brynhild, "till the fullness of
the days,
And the time for the glory appointed,
and the springing-tide of
praise."

From his hand then draweth Sigurd
Andvari's ancient Gold;
There is nought but the sky above
them as the ring together they
hold,
The shapen ancient token, that hath
no change nor end,
No change, and no beginning, no
flaw for God to mend:
Then Sigurd cries: "O Brynhild, now
hearken while I swear,
That the sun shall die in the heavens
and the day no more be fair,
If I seek not love in Lymdale and the
house that fostered thee,
And the land where thou awakedst
'twixt the woodland and the
sea!"

And she cried: "O Sigurd, Sigurd,
now hearken while I swear
That the day shall die for ever and the
sun to blackness wear,
Ere I forget thee, Sigurd, as I lie
'twixt wood and sea
In the little land of Lyndale and the
house that fostered me!"

Then he set the ring on her finger and
once, if ne'er again,
They kissed and clung together, and
their hearts were full and fain.

So the day grew old about them and
the joy of their desire,
And eve and the sunset came, and
faint grew the sunset fire,
And the shadowless death of the day
was sweet in the golden tide;
But the stars shone forth on the
world, and the twilight
changed and died;
And sure if the first of man-folk had
been born to that starry night,
And had heard no tale of the sunrise,
he had never longed for the
light:
But Earth longed amidst her slumber,
as 'neath the night she lay,
And fresh and all abundant abode the
deeds of Day.

THE END.

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Vide Household Words, Novels and Tales, and John Forster.

Charles Dickens:

The Letters of Charles Dickens edited by his Sister-in-law and his eldest
Daughter 4 v.

B. Disraeli (Lord Beaconsfield):

Coningsby 1 v.
Sybil 1 v.
Contarini Fleming (w. portrait) 1 v.
Alroy 1 v. Tancred 2 v.
Venetia 2 v.
Vivian Grey 2 v.
Henrietta Temple 1 v.
Lothair 2 v.
Endymion 2 v.

W. Hepworth Dixon:

Personal History of Lord Bacon 1 v.
The Holy Land 2 v.
New America 2 v.
Spiritual Wives 2 v.

Her Majesty's Tower 4 v.
Free Russia 2 v.
History of two Queens 6 v.
White Conquest 2 v.
Diana, Lady Lyle 2 v.

The Earl and the Doctor:
South Sea Bubbles 1 v.

Mrs. Edwardes:
Archie Lovell 2 v.
Steven Lawrence, Yeoman 2 v.
Ought we to Visit her? 2 v.
A Vagabond Heroine 1 v.
Leah: A Woman of Fashion 2 v.
A Blue-Stocking 1 v.
Jet: Her Face or Her Fortune? 1 v.
Vivian the Beauty 1 v.
A Ballroom Repentance 2 v.
A Girton Girl 2 v.

Miss Amelia B. Edwards:
Barbara's History 2 v.
Miss Carew 2 v.
Hand and Glove 1 v.
Half a Million of Money 2 v.
Debenham's Vow 2 v.
In the Days of my Youth 2 v.
Untrodden Peaks and unfrequented Valleys 1 v.
Monsieur Maurice 1 v.
Black Forest 1 v.
A Poetry-Book of Elder Poets 1 v.
A Thousand Miles up the Nile 2 v.
A Poetry-Book of Modern Poets 1 v.
Lord Brackenbury 2 v.

Miss M. Betham-Edwards:

The Sylvestres 1 v.
Felicia 2 v.
Brother Gabriel 2 v.
Forestalled 1 v.
Exchange no Robbery 1 v.
Disarmed 1 v.
Doctor Jacob 1 v.
Pearla 1 v.

Barbara Elbon:
Bethesda 2 v.

George Eliot:
Scenes of Clerical Life 2 v.
Adam Bede 2 v.
The Mill on the Floss 2 v.
Silas Marner 1 v.
Romola 2 v.
Felix Holt 2 v.
Daniel Deronda 4 v.
The Lifted Veil and Brother Jacob 1 v.
Impressions of Theophrastus Such 1 v.
Essays 1 v.

George Eliot's Life as related in her Letters and Journals. Arranged and ed.
by her Husband J. W. Cross 4 v.

Mrs. Elliot:
Diary of an Idle Woman in Italy 2 v.
Old Court Life in France 2 v.
The Italians 2 v.
The Diary of an Idle Woman in Sicily 1 v.
Pictures of Old Rome 1 v.
Diary of an Idle Woman in Spain 2 v.
The Red Cardinal 1 v.

Essays and Reviews 1 v.

Estelle Russell 2 v.

Expiated 2 v.

G. M. Fenn:

The Parson o' Dumford 2 v.

The Clerk of Portwick 2 v.

Fielding:

The History of Tom Jones 2 v.

Five Centuries of the English Language and Literature 1 v.

George Fleming:

Kismet 1 v.

Andromeda 2 v.

A. Forbes:

My Experiences of the War between France and Germany 2 v.

Soldiering and Scribbling 1 v.

See also "Daily News," War Correspondence.

Mrs. Forrester:

Viva 2 v.

Rhona 2 v.

Roy and Viola 2 v.

My Lord and My Lady 2 v.

I have Lived and Loved 2 v.

June 2 v.

Omnia Vanitas 1 v.

Although he was a Lord, etc. 1 v.

Corisande, etc. 1 v.

John Forster:

Life of Charles Dickens 6 v.

Life and Times of Oliver Goldsmith 2 v.

Jessie Fothergill:

The First Violin 2 v.

Probation 2 v.

Made or Marred and "One of Three" 1 v.

Kith and Kin 2 v.

Peril 2 v.

"Found Dead," Author of—

vide James Payn.

Caroline Fox:

Memories of Old Friends from her Journals, edited by Horace N. Pym 2 v.

Frank Fairlegh 2 v.

E. A. Freeman:

The Growth of the English Constitution 1 v.

Select Historical Essays 1 v.

Lady G. Fullerton:

Ellen Middleton 1 v.

Grantley Manor 2 v.

Lady-Bird 2 v.

Too Strange not to be True 2 v.

Constance Sherwood 2 v.

A stormy Life 2 v.

Mrs. Gerald's Niece 2 v.

The Notary's Daughter 1 v.

The Lilies of the Valley 1 v.

The Countess de Bonneval 1 v.

Rose Leblanc 1 v.

Seven Stories 1 v.

The Life of Luisa de Carvajal 1 v.

A Will and a Way 2 v.

Eliane 2 v. (*vide* Craven).

Laurentia 1 v.

Mrs. Gaskell:

Mary Barton 1 v.

Ruth 2 v.

North and South 1 v.

Lizzie Leigh 1 v.

The Life of Charlotte Brontë 2 v.

Lois the Witch 1 v.

Sylvia's Lovers 2 v.

A Dark Night's Work 1 v.

Wives and Daughters 3 v.

Cranford 1 v.

Cousin Phillis, and other Tales 1 v.

Geraldine Hawthorne *vide* "Miss Molly."

Agnes Giberne:

The Curate's Home 1 v.

Right Hon. W. E. Gladstone:

Rome and the newest Fashions in Religion 1 v.

Bulgarian Horrors: Russia in Turkistan 1 v.

The Hellenic Factor in the Eastern Problem 1 v.

Goldsmith:

Select Works: The Vicar of Wakefield; Poems; Dramas (w. portrait) 1 v.

Major-Gen. C. G. Gordon's Journals, at Kartoum. Introduction and Notes by
A. E. Hake (with eighteen Illustrations) 2 v.

Mrs. Gore:

Castles in the Air 1 v.

The Dean's Daughter 2 v.

Progress and Prejudice 2 v.

Mammon 2 v.

A Life's Lessons 2 v.

The two Aristocracies 2 v.
Heckington 2 v.

Miss Grant:

Victor Lescar 2 v.
The Sun-Maid 2 v.
My Heart's in the Highlands 2 v.
Artiste 2 v.
Prince Hugo 2 v.
Cara Roma 2 v.

W. A. Baillie Grohman:

Tyrol and the Tyrolese 1 v.

"Guy Livingstone," Author of—

Guy Livingstone 1 v.
Sword and Gown 1 v.
Barren Honour 1 v.
Border and Bastille 1 v.
Maurice Dering 1 v.
Sans Merci 2 v.
Breaking a Butterfly 2 v.
Anteros 2 v.
Hagarene 2 v.

J. Habberton:

Helen's Babies & Other People's Children 1 v.
The Bowsham Puzzle 1 v.
One Tramp; Mrs. Mayburn's Twins 1 v.

Hake: v. Gordon's Journals.

Mrs. S. C. Hall:

Can Wrong be Right? 1 v.
Marian 2 v.

Thomas Hardy:

The Hand of Ethelberta 2 v.
Far from the Madding Crowd 2 v.
The Return of the Native 2 v.
The Trumpet-Major 2 v.
A Laodicean 2 v.
Two on a Tower 2 v.
A Pair of Blue Eyes 2 v.

Agnes Harrison:

Martin's Vineyard 1 v.

Bret Harte:

Prose and Poetry (Tales of the Argonauts; Spanish and American Legends; Condensed Novels; Civic and Character Sketches; Poems) 2 v.

Idyls of the Foothills 1 v.
Gabriel Conroy 2 v.
Two Men of Sandy Bar 1 v.
Thankful Blossom 1 v.
The Story of a Mine 1 v.
Drift from Two Shores 1 v.
An Heiress of Red Dog 1 v.
The Twins of Table Mountain, etc. 1 v.
Jeff Briggs's Love Story, etc. 1 v.
Flip, etc. 1 v.
On the Frontier 1 v.
By Shore and Sedge 1 v.
Maruja 1 v.

Sir H. Havelock, by the Rev. W. Brock, 1 v.

N. Hawthorne:

The Scarlet Letter 1 v.
Transformation 2 v.
Passages from the English Note-Books 2 v.

"Heir of Redclyffe," Author of—
vide Yonge.

Sir Arthur Helps:

Friends in Council 2 v.

Ivan de Biron 2 v.

Mrs. Hemans:

The Select Poetical Works 1 v.

Mrs. Cashel Hoey:

A Golden Sorrow 2 v.

Out of Court 2 v.

Oliver Wendell Holmes:

The Autocrat of the Breakfast-Table 1 v.

The Professor at the Breakfast-Table 1 v.

The Poet at the Breakfast-Table 1 v.

Household Words conducted by Ch. Dickens. 1851-56. 36 v.

Novels and Tales reprinted from Household Words by Ch. Dickens.
1856-59. 11 v.

Miss Howard:

One Summer 1 v.

Aunt Serena 1 v.

Guenn 2 v.

W. D. Howells:

A Foregone Conclusion 1 v.

The Lady of the Aroostook 1 v.

A Modern Instance 2 v.

The Undiscovered Country 1 v.

Venetian Life (w. portr.) 1 v.

Italian Journeys 1 v.

A Chance Acquaintance 1 v.

Their Wedding Journey 1 v.

A Fearful Responsibility, etc. 1 v.

A Woman's Reason 2 v.

Dr. Breen's Practice 1 v.

Thos. Hughes:

Tom Brown's School Days 1 v.

Jean Ingelow:

Off the Skelligs 3 v.

Poems 2 v.

Fated to be Free 2 v.

Sarah de Berenger 2 v.

Don John 2 v.

J. H. Ingram:

vide E. A. Poe.

Washington Irving:

Sketch Book (w. portrait) 1 v.

Life of Mahomet 1 v.

Successors of Mahomet 1 v.

Oliver Goldsmith 1 v.

Chronicles of Wolfert's Roost 1 v.

Life of George Washington 5 v.

Helen Jackson:

Ramona 2 v.

G. P. R. James:

Morley Earnstein (w. portrait) 1 v.

Forest Days 1 v.

The False Heir 1 v.

Arabella Stuart 1 v.

Rose d'Albret 1 v.

Arrah Neil 1 v.

Agincourt 1 v.

The Smuggler 1 v.

The Step-Mother 2 v.

Beauchamp 1 v.

Heidelberg 1 v.
The Gipsy 1 v.
The Castle of Ehrenstein 1 v.
Darnley 1 v.
Russell 2 v.
The Convict 2 v.
Sir Theodore Broughton 2 v.

Henry James:

The American 2 v.
The Europeans 1 v.
Daisy Miller 1 v.
Roderick Hudson 2 v.
The Madonna of the Future, etc. 1 v.
Eugene Pickering, etc. 1 v.
Confidence 1 v.
Washington Square 2 v.
The Portrait of a Lady 3 v.
Foreign Parts 1 v.
French Poets and Novelists 1 v.
The Siege of London, etc. 1 v.
Portraits of Places 1 v.
A Little Tour in France 1 v.

J. Cordy Jeaffreson:

A Book about Doctors 2 v.
A Woman in Spite of herself 2 v.
The Real Lord Byron 3 v.

Mrs. Jenkin:

"Who Breaks—Pays" 1 v.
Skirmishing 1 v.
Once and Again 2 v.
Two French Marriages 2 v.
Within an Ace 1 v.
Jupiter's Daughters 1 v.

Edward Jenkins:

Ginx's Baby; Lord Bantam 2 v.

"Jennie of 'the Prince's,'" Author of—

vide Mrs. Buxton.

Douglas Jerrold:

The History of St. Giles and St. James 2 v.

Men of Character 2 v.

"John Halifax," Author of—

vide Mrs. Craik.

"Johnny Ludlow," Author of—

vide Mrs. Wood.

Johnson:

The Lives of the English Poets 2 v.

Emily Jolly:

Colonel Dacre 2 v.

"Joshua Davidson," Author of—

vide E. Lynn Linton.

Miss Kavanagh:

Nathalie 2 v.

Daisy Burns 2 v.

Grace Lee 2 v.

Rachel Gray 1 v.

Adèle 3 v.

A Summer and Winter in the Two Sicilies 2 v.

Seven Years 2 v.

French Women of Letters 1 v.

English Women of Letters 1 v.

Queen Mab 2 v.

Beatrice 2 v.

Sybil's Second Love 2 v.
Dora 2 v.
Silvia 2 v.
Bessie 2 v.
John Dorrien 3 v.
Two Lilies 2 v.
Forget-me-nots 2 v.

Annie Keary:
Oldbury 2 v.
Castle Daly 2 v.

Elsa D'Esterre-Keeling:
Three Sisters 1 v.

Kempis:
vide Thomas a Kempis.

R. B. Kimball:
Saint Leger 1 v.
Romance of Student Life abroad 1 v.
Undercurrents 1 v.
Was he Successful? 1 v.
To-Day in New-York 1 v.

A. W. Kinglake:
Eothen 1 v.
Invasion of the Crimea v. 1-10.

Charles Kingsley:
Yeast 1 v.
Westward ho! 2 v.
Two Years ago 2 v.
Hypatia 2 v.
Alton Locke 1 v.
Hereward the Wake 2 v.
At Last 2 v.

Charles Kingsley:

His Letters and Memories of his Life edited by his Wife 2 v.

Henry Kingsley:

Ravenshoe 2 v.

Austin Elliot 1 v.

The Recollections of Geoffry Hamlyn 2 v.

The Hillyars and the Burtons 2 v.

Leighton Court 1 v.

Valentin 1 v.

Oakshott Castle 1 v.

Reginald Hetherege 2 v.

The Grange Garden 2 v.

May Laffan:

Flitters, Tatters, and the Counsellor, etc. 1 v.

Charles Lamb:

The Essays of Elia and Eliana 1 v.

Mary Langdon:

Ida May 1 v.

"Last of the Cavaliers," Author of—

Last of the Cavaliers 2 v.

The Gain of a Loss 2 v.

Leaves from the Journal of our Life in the Highlands from 1848 to 1861, 1 v.

More Leaves from the Journal of a Life in the Highlands from 1862 to 1882, 1 v.

Holme Lee:

vide Miss Parr.

S. Le Fanu:

Uncle Silas 2 v.
Guy Deverell 2 v.

Mark Lemon:

Wait for the End 2 v.
Loved at Last 2 v.
Falkner Lyle 2 v.
Leyton Hall 2 v.
Golden Fetters 2 v.

Charles Lever:

The O'Donoghue 1 v.
The Knight of Gwynne 3 v.
Arthur O'Leary 2 v.
The Confessions of Harry Lorrequer 2 v.
Charles O'Malley 3 v.
Tom Burke of "Ours" 3 v.
Jack Hinton 2 v.
The Daltons 4 v.
The Dodd Family abroad 3 v.
The Martins of Cro' Martin 3 v.
The Fortunes of Glencore 2 v.
Roland Cashel 3 v.
Davenport Dunn 3 v.
Con Cregan 2 v.
One of Them 2 v.
Maurice Tiernay 2 v.
Sir Jasper Carew 2 v.
Barrington 2 v.
A Day's Ride: a Life's Romance 2 v.
Luttrell of Arran 2 v.
Tony Butler 2 v.
Sir Brook Fossbrooke 2 v.
The Bramleights of Bishop's Folly 2 v.
A Rent in a Cloud 1 v.
That Boy of Norcott's 1 v.
St. Patrick's Eve; Paul Gosslett's Confessions 1 v.

Lord Kilgobbin 2 v.

G. H. Lewes:

Ranthorpe 1 v.

Physiology of Common Life 2 v.

On Actors and the Art of Acting 1 v.

E. Lynn Linton:

Joshua Davidson 1 v.

Patricia Kemball 2 v.

The Atonement of Leam Dundas 2 v.

The World well Lost 2 v.

Under which Lord? 2 v.

With a Silken Thread etc. 1 v.

Todhunters' at Loanin' Head etc. 1 v.

"My Love!" 2 v.

The Girl of the Period, etc. 1 v.

Ione 2 v.

Laurence W. M. Lockhart:

Mine is Thine 2 v.

Longfellow:

Poetical Works (w. portrait) 3 v.

The Divine Comedy of Dante Alighieri 3 v.

The New-England Tragedies 1 v.

The Divine Tragedy 1 v.

Three Books of Song 1 v.

The Masque of Pandora 1 v.

M. Lonsdale:

Sister Dora 1 v.

A Lost Battle 2 v.

Lutfullah:

Autobiography of Lutfullah, by Eastwick 1 v.

Lord Lytton:
 vide Bulwer.

Robert Lord Lytton (Owen Meredith):
 Poems 2 v.
 Fables in Song 2 v.

Lord Macaulay:
 History of England (w. portrait) 10 v.
 Critical and Historical Essays 5 v.
 Lays of Ancient Rome 1 v.
 Speeches 2 v.
 Biographical Essays 1 v.
 William Pitt, Atterbury 1 v.
 (See also Trevelyan).

Justin M^cCarthy:
 Waterdale Neighbours 2 v.
 Lady Disdain 2 v.
 Miss Misanthrope 2 v.
 A History of our own Times 5 v.
 Donna Quixote 2 v.
 A short History of our own Times 2 v.
 A History of the Four Georges vol. 1.

George MacDonald:
 Alec Forbes of Howglen 2 v.
 Annals of a Quiet Neighbourhood 2 v.
 David Elginbrod 2 v.
 The Vicar's Daughter 2 v.
 Malcolm 2 v.
 St. George and St. Michael 2 v.
 The Marquis of Lossie 2 v.
 Sir Gibbie 2 v.
 Mary Marston 2 v.
 The Gifts of the Child Christ, etc. 1 v.

The Princess and Curdie 1 v.

Mrs. Mackarness:

Sunbeam Stories 1 v.

A Peerless Wife 2 v.

A Mingled Yarn 2 v.

Charles McKnight:

Old Fort Duquesne 2 v.

Norman Macleod:

The old Lieutenant and his Son 1 v.

Mrs. Macquoid:

Patty 2 v.

Miriam's Marriage 2 v.

Pictures across the Channel 2 v.

Too Soon 1 v.

My Story 2 v.

Diane 2 v.

Beside the River 2 v.

A Faithful Lover 2 v.

"Mademoiselle Mori," Author of—

Mademoiselle Mori 2 v.

Denise 1 v.

Madame Fontenoy 1 v.

On the Edge of the Storm 1 v.

The Atelier du Lys 2 v.

In the Olden Time 2 v.

Lord Mahon:

vide Stanhope.

E. S. Maine:

Scarscliff Rocks 2 v.

Lucas Malet:

Colonel Enderby's Wife 2 v.

Lord Malmesbury:

Memoirs of an Ex-Minister 3 v.

R. Blachford Mansfield:

The Log of the Water Lily 1 v.

Mark Twain:

The Adventures of Tom Sawyer 1 v.

The Innocents Abroad; or, the New Pilgrims' Progress 2 v.

A Tramp Abroad 2 v.

"Roughing it" 1 v.

The Innocents at Home 1 v.

The Prince and the Pauper 2 v.

The Stolen White Elephant, etc. 1 v.

Life on the Mississippi 2 v.

Sketches 1 v.

Huckleberry Finn 2 v.

Marmorne 1 v.

Capt. Marryat:

Jacob Faithful (w. portrait) 1 v.

Percival Keene 1 v.

Peter Simple 1 v.

Japhet 1 v.

Monsieur Violet 1 v.

The Settlers 1 v.

The Mission 1 v.

The Privateer's-Man 1 v.

The Children of the New-Forest 1 v.

Valerie 1 v.

Mr. Midshipman Easy 1 v.

The King's Own 1 v.

Florence Marryat:

Love's Conflict 2 v.
For Ever and Ever 2 v.
The Confessions of Gerald Estcourt 2 v.
Nelly Brooke 2 v.
Véronique 2 v.
Petronel 2 v.
Her Lord and Master 2 v.
The Prey of the Gods 1 v.
Life of Captain Marryat 1 v.
Mad Dumaresq 2 v.
No Intentions 2 v.
Fighting the Air 2 v.
A Star and a Heart 1 v.
The Poison of Asps 1 v.
A Lucky Disappointment 1 v.
My own Child 2 v.
Her Father's Name 2 v.
A Harvest of Wild Oats 2 v.
A Little Stepson 1 v.
Written in Fire 2 v.
Her World against a Lie 2 v.
A Broken Blossom 2 v.
The Root of all Evil 2 v.
The Fair-haired Alda 2 v.
With Cupid's Eyes 2 v.
My Sister the Actress 2 v.
Phyllida 2 v.
How They Loved Him 2 v.
Facing the Footlights (w. portrait) 2 v.
A Moment of Madness 1 v.
The Ghost of Charlotte Cray, etc. 1 v.
Peeress and Player 2 v.
Under the Lilies and Roses 2 v.
The Heart of Jane Warner 2 v.
The Heir Presumptive 2 v.

Mrs. Marsh:

Ravenscliffe 2 v.
Emilia Wyndham 2 v.
Castle Avon 2 v. Aubrey 2 v.
The Heiress of Haughton 2 v.
Evelyn Marston 2 v.
The Rose of Ashurst 2 v.

Emma Marshall:

Mrs. Mainwaring's Journal 1 v.
Benvenuta 1 v.
Lady Alice 1 v.
Dayspring 1 v.
Life's Aftermath 1 v.
In the East Country 1 v.

H. Mathers:

"Cherry Ripe!" 2 v.
"Land o' the Leal" 1 v.
My Lady Green Sleeves 2 v.
As he comes up the Stair, etc. 1 v.
Sam's Sweetheart 2 v.
Eyre's Acquittal 2 v.
Found Out 1 v.
Murder or Manslaughter? 1 v.

"Mehalah," Author of—

Mehalah 1 v.
John Herring 2 v.

Whyte Melville:

Kate Coventry 1 v.
Holmby House 2 v.
Digby Grand 1 v.
Good for Nothing 2 v.
The Queen's Maries 2 v.
The Gladiators 2 v.

The Brookes of Bridlemere 2 v.
Cerise 2 v.
The Interpreter 2 v.
The White Rose 2 v.
M. or N. 1 v.
Contraband; or A Losing Hazard 1 v.
Sarchedon 2 v.
Uncle John 2 v.
Katerfelto 1 v.
Sister Louise 1 v.
Rosine 1 v.
Roy's Wife 2 v.
Black but Comely 2 v.
Riding Recollections 1 v.

George Meredith:

The Ordeal of Feverel 2 v.
Beauchamp's Career 2 v.
The Tragic Comedians 1 v.

Owen Meredith:

vide Robert Lord Lytton.

Milton:

Poetical Works 1 v.

"Miss Molly," Author of—

Geraldine Hawthorne 1 v.

"Molly Bawn," Author of—

Molly Bawn 2 v.

Mrs. Geoffrey 2 v.

Faith and Unfaith 2 v.

Portia 2 v.

Loÿs, Lord Berresford, etc. 1 v.

Her First Appearance, etc. 1 v.

Phyllis 2 v.

Rossmoyne 2 v.
Doris 2 v.
A Maiden all Forlorn, etc. 1 v.
A Passive Crime 1 v.

Miss Florence Montgomery:

Misunderstood 1 v.
Thrown Together 2 v.
Thwarted 1 v.
Wild Mike 1 v.
Seaforth 2 v.
The Blue Veil 1 v.

Moore:

Poetical Works (w. portrait) 5 v.

Lady Morgan's Memoirs 3 v.

Henry Morley:

Of English Literature in the Reign of Victoria. With Facsimiles of the Signatures of Authors in the Tauchnitz Edition [v. 2000].

E. C. Grenville: Murray:

The Member for Paris 2 v.
Young Brown 2 v.
The Boudoir Cabal 3 v.
French Pictures in English Chalk (1st Series) 2 v.
The Russians of To-day 1 v.
French Pictures in English Chalk (2nd Series) 2 v.
Strange Tales 1 v.
That Artful Vicar 2 v.
Six Months in the Ranks 1 v.
People I have met 1 v.

"My little Lady," Author of—
vide E. Frances Poynter.

New Testament [v. 1000].

Mrs. Newby:

Common Sense 2 v.

Dr. J. H. Newman:

Callista 1 v.

"Nina Balatka," Author of—
vide Anthony Trollope.

"No Church," Author of—
No Church 2 v.
Owen:—a Waif 2 v.

Lady Augusta Noel:

From Generation to Generation 1 v.

Hon. Mrs. Norton:

Stuart of Dunleath 2 v.

Lost and Saved 2 v.

Old Sir Douglas 2 v.

Novels and Tales

vide Household Words.

Not Easily Jealous 2 v.

L. Oliphant:

Altiora Peto 2 v.

Mrs. Oliphant:

Passages in the Life of Mrs. Margaret Maitland of Sunnyside 1 v.

The Last of the Mortimers 2 v.

Agnes 2 v.

Madonna Mary 2 v.

The Minister's Wife 2 v.

The Rector, and the Doctor's Family 1 v.
Salem Chapel 2 v.
The Perpetual Curate 2 v.
Miss Marjoribanks 2 v.
Ombra 2 v.
Memoir of Count de Montalembert 2 v.
May 2 v.
Innocent 2 v.
For Love and Life 2 v.
A Rose in June 1 v.
The Story of Valentine and his Brother 2 v.
Whiteladies 2 v.
The Curate in Charge 1 v.
Phoebe, Junior 2 v.
Mrs. Arthur 2 v.
Carità 2 v.
Young Musgrave 2 v.
The Primrose Path 2 v.
Within the Precincts 3 v.
The greatest Heiress in England 2 v.
He that will not when he may 2 v.
Harry Joscelyn 2 v.
In Trust 2 v.
It was a Lover and his Lass 3 v.
The Ladies Lindores 3 v.
Hester 3 v.
The Wizard's Son 3 v.

Ossian:

Poems 1 v.

Ouida:

Idalia 2 v.
Tricotrin 2 v.
Puck 2 v.
Chandos 2 v.
Strathmore 2 v.

Under two Flags 2 v.
Folle-Farine 2 v.
A Leaf in the Storm; A Dog of Flanders and other Stories 1 v.
Cecil Castlemaine's Gage 1 v.
Madame la Marquise 1 v.
Pascarèl 2 v.
Held in Bondage 2 v.
Two little Wooden Shoes 1 v.
Signa (w. portrait) 3 v.
In a Winter City 1 v.
Ariadnê 2 v.
Friendship 2 v.
Moths 3 v.
Pipistrello 1 v.
A Village Commune 2 v.
In Maremma 3 v.
Bimbi 1 v.
Wanda 3 v.
Frescoes, etc. 1 v.
Princess Napraxine 3 v.
A Rainy June (60 Pf.). Othmar 3 v.

Miss Parr (Holme Lee):

Basil Godfrey's Caprice 2 v.
For Richer, for Poorer 2 v.
The Beautiful Miss Barrington 2 v.
Her Title of Honour 1 v.
Echoes of a Famous Year 1 v.
Katherine's Trial 1 v.
Bessie Fairfax 2 v.
Ben Milner's Wooing 1 v.
Straightforward 2 v.
Mrs. Denys of Cote 2 v.
A Poor Squire 1 v.

Mrs. Parr:

Dorothy Fox 1 v.

The Prescotts of Pamphillon 2 v.
Gosau Smithy 1 v.
Robin 2 v.

"Paul Ferroll," Author of—
Paul Ferroll 1 v.
Year after Year 1 v.
Why Paul Ferroll killed his Wife 1 v.

James Payn:

Found Dead 1 v.
Gwendoline's Harvest 1 v.
Like Father, like Son 2 v.
Not Wooed, but Won 2 v.
Cecil's Tryst 1 v.
A Woman's Vengeance 2 v.
Murphy's Master 1 v.
In the Heart of a Hill 1 v.
At Her Mercy 2 v.
The Best of Husbands 2 v.
Walter's Word 2 v.
Halves 2 v.
Fallen Fortunes 2 v.
What He cost Her 2 v.
By Proxy 2 v.
Less Black than we're Painted 2 v.
Under one Roof 2 v.
High Spirits 1 v.
High Spirits (Second Series) 1 v.
A Confidential Agent 2 v.
From Exile 2 v.
A Grape from a Thorn 2 v.
Some Private Views 1 v.
For Cash Only 2 v.
Kit: A Memory 2 v.
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Page 72, "Lilybæaum" changed to "Lilybæum"

Page 149, "Golden, und gleaming" changed to "Golden, and gleaming"

Page 279, "turned aud beheld" changed to "turned and beheld"

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